



15 SECRETS SUCCESSFUL PEOPLE KNOW ABOUT TIME MANAGEMENT

THE PRODUCTIVITY HABITS OF 7 BILLIONAIRES,
13 OLYMPIC ATHLETES, 29 STRAIGHT-A STUDENTS,
AND 239 ENTREPRENEURS

NEW YORK TIMES BESTSELLING AUTHOR
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KEVIN KRUSE
New York Times Bestselling Author

First Edition

THE KRUSE GROUP

Philadelphia

What if a few new habits could increase your productivity by 5x or even 10x?

Imagine you had an extra hour each day to read, exercise, or to spend with your family?

Based on survey research and interviews with billionaires, Olympic athletes, straight-A students, and over 200 entrepreneurs—including Mark Cuban, Kevin Harrington, James Altucher, John Lee Dumas, Grant Cardone, and Lewis Howes—*New York Times* bestselling author, Kevin Kruse, answers the question:

What are the secrets to extreme productivity?

You will learn:

- How to cure procrastination with “Time Travel”
- How to save 8 hours a week with “3 Questions”
- How to identify your *real* top priorities
- How to get to zero emails in your inbox every day
- How the E-3C system will boost productivity by 10x
- How to reduce stress with the Richard Branson Tool

- How to leave work at 5:00 without feeling guilty
- How to run meetings like Apple, Google & Virgin
- How to conquer social media distractions
- **BONUS:** Discover Your Time Personality quiz
- **BONUS:** 100+ Time Management Quotes

YOUR TWO FREE GIFTS

As a thank you for buying this book, I'm offering two
FREE resources:

**1) How Millionaire's Schedule
Their Day
(1-Page Planner Tool)**

**2) 15 Surprising Things Ultra
Productive People Do Differently
(Quick Guide)**

Tap The Link Below To Get Instant Access:

www.MasterYourMinutes.com

Kevin Kruse
New York Times Bestselling Author
Forbes Contributor
Inc 500 Entrepreneur

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“Overworked and Overwhelmed” on a New Jersey Highway

“License and registration!”

5:20 a.m. Dark and cold, pulled over on the shoulder of Route 1 in New Jersey. I had been heading to work.

“Do you know why I pulled you over?”

Why did he have to shout?

“I assume I was speeding,” my voice cracked.

“Speeding!” He leaned down until the brim of his hat touched the top of my window. Eye to eye, he said, “You flew up behind me, rode my bumper, swung around and passed me, and kept on going. *I* was doing 65 in the slow lane.”

I wish I could say the officer had been driving an unmarked car, but he wasn’t. Big white Crown Vic with the light bar on top. Giant blue and yellow “State Police” decals on the doors.

I can’t really explain it. I have no memory of coming up on any car, let alone a well-marked cop car.

Apparently, half asleep and thinking of work, I was driving over 80 miles per hour when I came upon a state trooper who was going a measly 65, so I just switched lanes and drove right past him.

“I’m sorry, officer. I just, uh, zoned out I guess...”

“Zoned out?!”

“I didn’t get much sleep, and...”

I was lucky he didn’t arrest me.

I was really lucky I didn’t crash and kill somebody.

This was 20 years ago, when I was young and dumb. I was so “crazy busy” that I just kept adding more hours to my workday and more tasks to each hour. I’d leave the house at five in the morning and work until midnight. No time for proper meals. Coffee and a buttered roll eaten in my car for breakfast. Skipped lunch. Wolfed down dinner standing up.

I drank so many diet Red Bulls that I started looking at those silver and blue cans the way an alcoholic looks at a bottle of wine. Those cans called to me.

Passing a trooper on the highway without even realizing it was definitely the worst thing I did, but there were other signs of being out of control before that.

Like when I filled up my car with gas, drove away, and KLAANK! I had forgotten to take the gas nozzle out of my car. It’s a miracle I didn’t blow the place up.

And the times my wife kept telling me, “I just don’t feel connected to you anymore.” She’s now my ex-wife.

It wasn’t like I was completely clueless about time management. I had read all the bestsellers. I was the master of the to-do list and prioritized it every night for the next day. At one point I had such a long list that I used a standard piece of ruled notebook paper and filled in *two* columns—35 ruled lines, 2 tasks per line, 70 total to-do items.

I look back at that time in my life with horror and embarrassment.

Thankfully, today I’m a different person.

I’m a single dad with three kids. I help them with their homework every night and am home for dinner at the kitchen table more than half the time. I attend most of their games, plays, and music recitals. I’m no athlete, but I exercise routinely and am maintaining a healthy weight. I manage at least one or two “date nights” with my girlfriend each week.

For work, I run a small consulting practice, write two books a year, give speeches around the world, and oversee my investments in various startups and commercial real estate.

I take a lot of vacation time, too. Last year alone I went to Puerto Rico, Cancun, and the Jersey shore; spent several weekends in New York City; and for my daughter's 16th birthday, I took her on an epic trip to Barcelona, Madrid, and to see the running of the bulls in Pamplona.

I do all this—and this is the key point—*while rarely feeling stressed out, rushed, overwhelmed, or guilty*. I definitely don't feel “crazy busy” and don't feel the need to brag about being “crazy busy” to those around me.

Don't you just hate me?

My personal time and stress transformation started as I began to ask my successful friends how *they* managed time.

I immediately noticed that none of them mentioned the things that are taught in traditional time management books.

My curiosity soon turned into a quest, and I did original survey research of working professionals, looking for correlations between specific time management practices and productivity, stress, and happiness. I funded a study of thousands of working professionals and we found no correlation between time management training and higher levels of productivity or reduced stress. Zero!

I then interviewed hundreds of highly successful people including Mark Cuban and other billionaires, famous entrepreneurs, gold medal Olympians like Shannon Miller, and straight-A students.

What I discovered is that highly successful people don't prioritize tasks on a to-do list, or follow some complex five-step system, or refer to logic tree diagrams to make decisions.

Actually, highly successful people don't think about time much at all. Instead, they think about values, priorities, and *consistent habits*.

While no two people manage time exactly the same way, there are common themes. And if you really try them, you might find that just one of their “secrets” has the power to transform your career and your life.

Kevin Kruse

Bucks County, PA

The Power of 1440

Can a single number change your life?

A three-word question used to send chills of dread down my spine.

“Got a minute?”

Sure, I believed in an open door policy. Sure, I was the boss. Sure, some people would say I was overly detail oriented, which made people check in with me too frequently (who, me?).

I was the founder and president of a digital learning company that quickly took off. Revenue doubling every year and all the related challenges: new hires, sales, product launches, fundraising, and on and on.

The fires to put out kept multiplying, as did the knocks on my office door followed by, “Got a minute?”

There was nothing wrong with people asking me for advice or help. But I quickly found entire days were being spent on other people’s priorities and problems as the requested minute-meetings inevitably turned into 30 minutes or more. My priorities, the company’s strategic priorities—washed away by the never-ending torrent of “urgent” got-a-minutes.

Finally, I printed a big **1440** on a piece of paper and taped it to the outside of my office door.

No other words. No explanation. Just “1440” in Arial, bold, 300-point font.

How I Beat Back Time Thieves

Every time I walked into my own office, I passed that giant “1440” sign as a reminder. Tick, tick, tick. I could not be careless with my minutes.

But what also happened was that when people stopped by to ask, “Got a minute?” and I would say yes, they would immediately ask, “So what’s that 1,440 all about?”

I would explain that it was a simple reminder to *me* of the value of time and how I needed to “invest” each minute of my day very wisely.

I always made it about me, but the length of these got-a-minute meetings suddenly got shorter. One person heard my explanation and replied, “You know what, I don’t need to talk anymore. I just realized it can wait until the team huddle on Monday.”

I can only assume that my 1440 sign initially freaked people out. *Kevin must be in a bad mood; he doesn’t want us talking to him anymore. Kevin’s a hypocrite...he says he has an open door policy but then insults us with that sign.*

But the sign stayed up, and the novelty wore off. Soon I heard other people in the office talking about “only 1440 minutes” as they prioritized tasks or turned down invitations to irrelevant meetings.

1,440 Minutes in a Day

If you’re like most people who want to improve their time management, you probably want a list of tips, tools, and systems that will increase your productivity and add hours to your week.

Yet, the single most important thing when it comes to time and productivity isn’t a tactic or a trick—it’s a shift in mindset.

Self-made millionaires, professional athletes, straight-A students, and other highly successful people think about time differently. They experience time differently.

In Their Own Words...

Before I decide to take on a new project, I analyze it...How much of my time will this take, and what is my financial upside potential. I create a “dollar per minute” analysis, hopefully a million dollar per week upside.

—Kevin Harrington is the inventor of the infomercial, a bestselling author, an original investor on Shark Tank, and founder and chairman of As Seen On TV, Inc.

Take a minute to think about the most valuable things in life. Really take a minute to look up from this book, maybe even close your eyes, and come up with a list of all the things in the world that you value most.

I'll wait...

Did you really do this little exercise? Don't just read this book and let it go in and out! You need to do the activities to anchor the lessons. Changing behaviors is hard and passively reading won't get it done. Do it!

OK, if you are like most people, your list of the most valuable things includes your spouse, children, friends, health, money, and of course, time.

Highly successful people have a similar list—but they rank time as the most important item of all.

Shouldn't health be number one? You can be healthy, and then get sick, and then regain your health.

How about money? You can lose all your money, and then you can make it all back.

Friends? Friends are important, and yet, how many friends did you have back in college that you no longer keep in touch with? Or even people who were guests at your wedding, and that was the last day you ever saw them? Yes, friends are prized, yet we lose them and make new ones all the time.

Yes, your spouse means the world to you. And 50 percent of married people get a divorce, and many divorced people get a new husband or wife that is suddenly the love of their life.

But time...

You can never lose time and get it back again.

You can't spend time and go earn more of it. You can't buy it, rent it, or borrow it.

Time Is the Most Important Asset

Time is unique because it's the one true equalizer. Some people are born rich, others born poor. Some have Ivy League degrees, while others are high school dropouts. Some are genetically gifted athletes, others physically challenged.

But we all have the same minutes in a day. Time is the lowest common denominator.

Hold your hand to your heart.

Again, I need you to really do it. Hold your hand to your chest and feel your heart. Beat, beat, beat.

Become conscious of your breathing. In. Out. In. Out.

You will never get those beats back. You will never get those breaths back. In fact, I just took three beats away from your life. I just took two breaths from you.

But it was worth it if it helped you to truly feel time slipping away.

You might be thinking, "Yeah, yeah, the importance of time. Of course, that's why I'm reading this. I get it!"

But are you *living* it?

Think about how much attention you give to your money. Working hard to make money, tracking your money in your bank account, researching the best ways to invest your money, reading about ways to make more money, worrying that somebody might steal your money.

You would never leave your wallet sitting out in the open. You'd never give your ATM card and password to a bunch of strangers.

And yet we typically think little about our time. We routinely let people steal our time, even though it's our most valuable possession.

The magic number that can change your life is 1,440.

I encourage you to try it yourself. Just draw a big "1,440" on a piece of paper and tape it on your office door, under your TV, next to your computer monitor—wherever it will best

serve as a constant reminder of the very limited and oh so precious time you have each day.

Why Minutes, Not Seconds?

There are 86,400 seconds in a day. And if that number is more powerful to you, by all means, put up a “86,400” sign to remind you of time.

But personally, I find focusing on minutes to be more powerful. Seconds can slip away fairly easily. But minutes! Just think of all the ways you can spend just one minute.

I asked the members of my Facebook page (www.facebook.com/KruseAuthor) how they could use a single minute. Their responses included:

- Do 30 sit-ups
- Tell someone how much you love them
- Do a yoga Breath of Fire
- Write a thank you note
- Introduce yourself to a stranger
- Read a poem
- Have a great idea
- Water a plant
- Pet your cat
- Have your heart broken or break a heart
- Sing a song
- Write in a journal
- Eat an apple
- Drink a glass of water
- Send a text to someone you are thinking about
- Stand in the sun
- Write three things you're grateful for
- Make a decision to give up smoking

- Give feedback
- Give a donation
- Apologize
- Boil water for tea
- Send a positive tweet
- Daydream
- Smile
- Take a photo that will turn into a memory
- Plank
- Breathe...in with abundance, out with gratitude
- Journal
- Hug your mom
- Have one really, really good kiss
- Recall a happy moment
- Meditate
- Pray

Highly successful people feel the passage of time. They know the potential that every minute holds.

In Their Own Words...

I'll just say that actually being disciplined about adopting these habits is, in my experience, a huge differentiator of successful people...If I was building a character in a business video game and I had ten character points to distribute, I'd put three of them into intelligence and seven of them into self-discipline.

—Andrew Mason is the co-founder of Detour and co-founder and former CEO of Groupon.

When you wake up and subconsciously start the countdown —1440, 1439, 1438—adopting the habits of highly successful

people becomes very easy.

SECRET #1

Time is your most valuable and scarcest resource.

How would your life change if each and every day you truly felt your 1,440 minutes?

*** * FREE BONUS * ***

*To download a ready-to-print “1440” poster and other
FREE bonuses, visit: www.MasterYourMinutes.com*

The Power of Proper Priorities

How would you like to be totally clear on your “one thing”?

Whose Dreams Are You Chasing Anyway?

If you aren't busy working on your own goals, you'll be working to achieve somebody else's goals.

What's Your One Thing?

In the hilarious 1991 movie *City Slickers*, the old cowboy Curly (played by Jack Palance) gives a secret to Mitch (played by Billy Crystal). Holding up his index finger, Curly explains that you need to figure out your one thing and stick to it.

But the “one thing” concept goes back a lot further than a Billy Crystal comedy. Consider this advice from the ages:

- “To do two things at once is to do neither.” – Publilius Syrus
- “If you chase two rabbits, you will catch neither one.” –Russian proverb
- “Things which matter most must never be at the mercy of things which matter least.” –Goethe
- “It is those who concentrate on but one thing at a time who advance in this world.” –Og Mandino
- “Drive for the one thing on which you have decided.” –General George Patton
- “Efficiency is doing the thing right. Effectiveness is doing the right thing.” –Peter Drucker
- “Success demands singleness of purpose.” – Vince Lombardi

Identify Your Most Important Task (MIT)

Therese Macan, a professor at the University of Missouri-St. Louis, conducted groundbreaking research into time management, productivity, and stress, discovering that the two most important keys are priorities and mechanics (i.e., the mechanics of implementing time management techniques and tactics).

Put simply, the most important things are to know *what* to focus on and *how* you are going to get it done. I call this always knowing your *most important task*, or MIT.

Research Says...

In addition to increased productivity, having a daily MIT correlates to higher levels of happiness and energy.

(Source: The Kruse Group, 2015)

Entire books have been written on goal setting, and I may write one myself someday, but it all comes down to understanding what is most important to you and what activity right now will provide the greatest leverage to getting there.

In Their Own Words...

About six months before an Olympics, I would relate all the decisions I made to the ultimate vision of winning gold. The simple question I would ask several times a day was, "Will this activity help me perform better and therefore help us win gold?"

*—**Briana Scurry** won two gold medals as the starting goalkeeper for the United States women's soccer team in 1996 and 2004.*

I work more on time alignment. Is this part of my mission? Does this serve others or strengthen my ability to serve others? Those two questions keep me tight to my map. That's how I best manage my time and priorities.

*—**Chris Brogan** is a bestselling author and CEO of Owner Media Group.*

I always start with the most important thing on my priority list. If you didn't spend your week working on the most important thing, it was a week wasted.

*—**Randy Gage** is the author of nine books including the New York Times bestseller, *Risky Is the New Safe*.*

Most people set goals for health, wealth, and relationships. Others add things like spirituality, charity, and recreation.

Regardless of your focus areas, conventional wisdom dictates that your goal be specific and measurable. Instead of writing a goal to “save money,” it should be something like “Save \$5,000 by the end of the year.” Instead of “lose weight,” you would specify, “Lose ten pounds in ten weeks.”

After identifying your most important goal, you need to identify which activities will lead to goal achievement and which activity is most important *right now*.

Don’t get sidetracked by the goal setting if you don’t already have identified goals. In fact, other experts, like CEO coach Peter Bregman, suggest that there is a downside to goals. Instead, Bregman suggests picking focus areas.

For example, at the time I’m writing this book, I know that I really want to increase my passive income this year. But I don’t have a specific dollar amount in mind and because I have plenty of money, I’m not feeling any pressure to define it.

But in order to grow passive income, I also know that I need to *create* all kinds of things like books, assessments, and online training. Right now, when I ask myself:

What is the single most important task (MIT) to get closer to my goal right now?

I know it’s working on this book. Once the book is done, I’ll create spin-off content. And once I have more stuff to sell, my “one thing” will likely be working on marketing material or webinars to spread the word. But for now, I know that my MIT is writing this book.

Your own MIT may look very different based on your job and personal goals. A rookie salesperson’s MIT might be cold calling in order to hit a sales target. A software engineer’s MIT might be to debug a particular module in order to hit a launch deadline. A senior software executive’s MIT might be recruiting a new programmer in order to develop a new app. A startup CEO’s MIT might be to create a slide deck in order to land venture capital. A student’s MIT might be to find a tutor

in order to do well on an upcoming exam. A stay-at-home parent's MIT might be to reserve a campground site at the state park to line up the family's favorite summer vacation.

Mark Pincus on His MIT

Identifying your MIT makes your scheduling decisions much easier. Having identified what is most important to you, you'll need a very good reason *not* to be spending time on it.

The social gaming company Zynga is probably best known for its game *Farmville*, which at its peak had over 265 million active users. Zynga CEO, Mark Pincus, clearly has his MIT well defined and believes in spending at least half of his time on it.

In Their Own Words...

If you want to build great products, devote more than 50 percent of your work hours to product. Don't accept speaking opportunities if you can't justify them as benefitting your users or your company.

—Mark Pincus is the co-founder and CEO of Zynga.

Two Awesome Hours in the Morning

After identifying your MIT, you need to turn it into a calendar item and book it as early in your day as possible.

Dan Ariely, a Duke University professor of psychology and behavioral economics, suggests that most people are most productive and have the highest cognitive functioning in the first two hours after they're fully awake. In a Reditt Ask Me Anything, Ariely wrote:

One of the saddest mistakes in time management is the propensity of people to spend the two most productive hours of their day on things that don't require high cognitive capacity (like social media). If we could salvage those precious hours, most of us would be much more successful in accomplishing what we truly want.

Why do we do this? Why do we spend our best hours on our least important tasks?

Many of us jump into our day trying to take care of all the quick and easy things. Responding to all those overnight emails, sorting our stack of mail, signing off on purchase orders...it all feels so productive! *Look, it's only 11:00 in the morning, and I must have done at least 50 things.*

In Their Own Words...

Invest the first part of your day working on your number one priority that will help build your business. Do this without interruptions—no email or text—and before the rest of the world is awake.

—Tom Ziglar is the CEO of Ziglar, Inc.

Do creative work first. Reactive work second.

—Jonathan Milligan is the author of The 15 Success Traits of Pro Bloggers.

Others choose to do the most unpleasant tasks early in the morning in what's known as the “eat the frog first” strategy. It's a procrastination-fighting technique that says if you have something unpleasant to do, just get it out of the way first thing. This is good advice if it defeats procrastination, but it can also be counterproductive if you routinely use up your peak hours.

In Their Own Words...

I prepare a MUST DO list the night before...when I get to my desk, I do those items first before I turn on my email.

*—Andrew McCauley is the co-founder of
Autopilot Your Business.*

Not only are most people at their cognitive best earlier in the day, but it's less likely that unexpected items will jump onto the calendar or require urgent attention.

In Their Own Words...

I try to reserve the morning for doing “real work.” I find I can focus more in the morning whereas it's harder to get focused after having been bombarded by meetings, so I try to save meetings for later in the day.

—Nathan Blecharczyk is the co-founder of Airbnb.

Taking Dr. Ariely's advice to heart, drink that first cup of coffee while driving in to work, but then shut your door, silence your phone, close email and social media, and work on your MIT.

In Their Own Words...

I schedule a series of 90-minute "Jam Sessions" throughout my day/week where I focus exclusively on one vital priority and nothing else.

–**Stephen Woessner** is host of the Onward Nation podcast and CEO of Predictive ROI.

I have found that I am most productive from 6:00 a.m. to noon. I'm up, fresh, creative, and that is the time I make crazy things happen. I do more in those hours than people probably do all week.

–**Christina Daves** is the author of PR for Anyone and the CEO and founder of PR for Anyone®.

How Does This Apply If You're A(n)...

Entrepreneur: Would it be helpful to identify the one thing that is most important to achieving your quarterly goals?

Executive: Would it be helpful to be crystal clear on the number one objective you'll be evaluated against when it comes time for your annual performance review?

Freelancer: Would it be helpful to identify the one thing that will lead to more clients?

Student: Would it help to pick the one class that is most important for you to raise your grade in?

Stay-at-Home Parent: Would it be helpful to identify the one thing that is currently most important for your child's health and development (e.g., organizing a playgroup, choosing a summer camp, finding a music tutor)?

SECRET #2

Identify your Most Important Task (MIT) and work on it each day before doing anything else.

So, what's your one thing? What's your MIT?

*** * FREE BONUS * ***

*To download the Priorities & MIT worksheet and other
FREE bonuses, visit: www.MasterYourMinutes.com*

Stop Making To-Do Lists—Do This Instead

Do you really think millionaires and billionaires walk around with a to-do list?

Do you really think Bill Gates, Donald Trump and Warren Buffett write a long to-do list and prioritize items as A1, A2, B1, B2, C1, and on and on?

Do you really think Steve Jobs kept a to-do list and asked himself several times a day, “What’s my next action?”

The Problem with To-Do Lists

To-do lists should be called nagging wish-lists. A series of tasks you hope to accomplish, without a specific plan as to when you’ll get them all done. How many items on your current to-do list have been on there for several days? For weeks? Months?

The first problem with recording tasks on a to-do list is that it doesn’t distinguish between items that take only a few minutes and items that require an hour or more. So when you randomly look at your list and ask, “Hmm, what should I tackle next?” You are very likely going to pick the quick tasks, the easy items, not necessarily the thing that is most important.

Research Says...

*41% of to-do list items are **never** completed.*

*(Source: The Busy Person’s Guide to the Done List, *iDoneThis*)*

Second, and similar to the first problem, to-do lists make it really easy to work on the *urgent* instead of the important. That’s why I still have “Create annual family photo album for 2013” still on my to-do list (from two years ago!). *Do you know how many men have had “colonoscopy” on their to-do list year after year?!*

Research Says...

50% of to-do list items are completed within a day, many within the first hour of being written down. (Source: The Busy Person's Guide to the Done List, iDoneThis)

Third, to-do lists cause unnecessary stress. Indeed, when we carry around a long list of undone items it's one way to remember them. But it's also a constant reminder, a constant nagging, that there are many things we still need to deal with. No wonder we feel overwhelmed. No wonder at night we collapse exhausted, but fight insomnia as our brain processes all that still has to get done. No wonder our bodies are breaking down from stress.

Research Says...

The Zeigarnik effect is a psychological term based on studies that show unfinished goals cause intrusive, uncontrolled thoughts.

Live Life from Your Calendar

Highly successful people don't have a to-do list, but they do have a very well-kept calendar. One of the most consistent messages I got from all the interviews and research I did for this book was that no matter what it is, if you truly want to get it done, *schedule* time for it.

In Their Own Words...

Use a calendar and schedule your entire day into 15-minute blocks. It sounds like a pain, but this will set you up in the 95th percentile as far as organization goes. If it's not on the calendar, it doesn't get done. If it's on the calendar, it gets done no matter what. Use this not just for appointments, but workouts, calls, email blocks, etc.

—Jordan Harbinger is the co-founder of The Art of Charm and host of The Art of Charm Podcast, a school that teaches networking and relationship-development skills

This is why hyper-busy politicians, executives and celebrities have full-time schedulers. This is why—as pretentious as it sounds—successful people are prone to saying things like, “Have your people call my people to set something up.”

In Their Own Words...

I simply put everything on my schedule. That's it. Everything I do on a day-to-day basis gets put on my schedule. Thirty minutes of social media—on the schedule. Forty-five minutes of email management—on the schedule. Catching up with my virtual team—on the schedule. Quiet time to contemplate and plan—on the schedule. Bottom line, if it doesn't get scheduled, it doesn't get done.

—Chris Ducker is a serial entrepreneur, keynote speaker, and bestselling author as well as a popular business blogger and podcaster.

Surprisingly, the simple act of scheduling tasks on your calendar—instead of writing them on a to-do list—will free your mind, reduce stress, and increase cognitive performance. Florida State University Researchers showed that the Zeigarnik effect—the stressful conscious and unconscious thoughts caused by unfinished tasks—could be overcome simply by making a *plan* to accomplish a task—you didn't actually have to complete the task itself.

Research Says...

*“A **plan** increases one's odds of attaining a goal and simultaneously **reduces** cognitive activities...”*

(Source: Consider It Done!, Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 2011)

There are several key concepts to managing your life using your calendar instead of a to-do list.

First, schedule a chunk of time for everything that is important to you; this is called “time blocking” or “time boxing.” If you truly value being healthy and have decided that a 30-minute daily workout is your enabling goal, then don't put it on your to-do list—put it on your calendar.

Schedule it as a recurring appointment. If you value customer intimacy as a business strategy and have an enabling goal of talking to at least two customers a day, then schedule a daily appointment for “customer calls.”

In Their Own Words...

During training, I balanced family time, chores, schoolwork, Olympic training, appearances, and other obligations by outlining a very specific schedule. I was forced to prioritize...To this day, I keep a schedule that is almost minute by minute. Focus on those things that bring you further to your goal each and every day. Every moment counts!

—Shannon Miller, a member of the 1992 and 1996 U.S. Olympic gymnastics team who won a combined seven Olympic medals.

Second, important items should be scheduled as early in the day as possible. No matter how much we try to control our time and calendars, we all have things that “come up” that might need our attention. It could be a meeting request from our boss, an angry client call, or the school nurse calling to say we need to pick up Johnnie from school. Naturally, as more time ticks away in each day, the more likely it is that something unexpected will happen.

I personally struggle with this immensely. If I have my daily workout scheduled for the late afternoon or night, the odds are high that I’ll feel some other priority is in need of extra attention by the time I actually get to my exercise time block. I basically know that if I don’t hit the treadmill in the morning, the odds of hitting it at all go way down.

Third, don’t cancel goals; reschedule them if necessary. For example, if you normally work out every day from 12:00 to 1:00 p.m.—during your lunch hour—but you have to be on an airplane on Monday traveling for work at noon, you would reschedule the exercise appointment for earlier or later in the day.

In Their Own Words...

Get one of those big blue calendars. Planning your life on your phone is fine, but it doesn’t give you the same perspective.

–Will Dean is an Olympic rower for Canada and competed in the London 2012 Olympics. He is currently training for Rio 2016.

Fourth, treat your time-blocked calendar entries as if they were appointments with your doctor; they are that important. Most of us cave in on our self-scheduled appointments too easily. If we time block 4:00 to 5:00 p.m. to work on an important report at the office, and then a colleague asks for 15 minutes of time because “something has come up I need to run by you,” we reflexively say “sure,” thinking we’ll finish the report in only 45 minutes, or we’ll stay 15 minutes later or adjust in some other way.

But imagine if instead of working on a report you had an appointment with your doctor or dentist. Would you still agree to give away that time and show up for your doctor 15 minutes late? Of course not.

In Their Own Words...

What I found to be the most effective way to manage my time was to buy an agenda with a big calendar. I handwrite what topics I need to cover and how long I need to be studying that topic each night.

–Caitlin Hale was a straight-A student in college and currently attends the University of Medicine and Dentistry of New Jersey.

If it’s not in my calendar, it won’t get done. But if it is in my calendar, it will get done. I schedule out every 15 minutes of every day to conduct meetings, review materials, write, and do any activities I need to get done. And while I take meetings with just about anyone who wants to meet with me, I reserve just one hour a week for these “office hours.” People can schedule time at <http://ScheduleDave.com>.

–Dave Kerpen is the NY Times bestselling author of three books, the co-founder & chairman of Likeable Media, and the founder & CEO of Likeable Local.

The best habit is to automatically respond to unanticipated requests that conflict with your calendar by saying something like, “I have an important appointment on my calendar from 4:00 to 5:00. Is there any chance we can talk after 5:00, or can it wait until the morning?”

You'll be surprised at how frequently the unanticipated item can then be scheduled in an open block. Sure there will be times when an important person—a boss or spouse, for example—needs our attention, and it really is more important than our time block activity. But we can always ask to fit it in elsewhere as a first reaction.

Jeff Weiner Time Blocks Buffer Time

The CEO of LinkedIn, Jeff Weiner, wrote a blog post describing how he time blocks “do nothing” time on his calendar. He wrote:

If you were to see my calendar, you'd probably notice a host of time slots greyed out but with no indication of what's going on. There is no problem with my Outlook or printer. The grey sections reflect “buffers,” or time periods I've purposely kept clear of meetings.

In aggregate, I schedule between 90 minutes and two hours of these buffers every day (broken down into 30- to 90-minute blocks). It's a system I developed over the last several years in response to a schedule that was becoming so jammed with back-to-back meetings that I had little time left to process what was going on around me or just think.

At first, these buffers felt like indulgences. I could have been using the time to catch up on meetings I had pushed out or said “no” to. But over time I realized not only were these breaks important, they were absolutely necessary in order for me to do my job.

Design Your Ideal Week with Time Blocks

Another way your calendar can become a powerful life-guiding tool is by using it to design your ideal week.

Think about what your ideal workweek would look like.

If you're a freelancer, consultant, or coach, it might include focused time to work on client projects, but also time to learn new skills or to be inspired by others' work, or to work on your own marketing initiatives.

If you're a mid-level executive, your ideal week might include one-on-one coaching time with some of your team members, time for a team meeting, as well as time to sit alone to think strategically about the year ahead.

Regardless of your professional role, you may also find that your ideal week—and even ideal day—has some recurring personal things: exercise, time with your family, time to relax or to pursue hobbies.

Mapping all of these items onto your calendar—and making them recurring appointments—is the right way to design your life. It's a powerful way to stay consistent to those activities that give you the most return, and the most joy.

My own calendar reflects many of my values:

- I value health, so I time block 60 minutes each morning for exercise.
- I value coaching my team members, so I time block one-on-one meetings with each direct report on Mondays as a way to kick off the week.
- I value team alignment and breaking down silos, so I time block a weekly full-team meeting.
- I value writing so I have two to three blocks of time scheduled each week to write uninterrupted.
- I value my children's education, so I time block evenings after dinner to help them with their homework.
- I value recharging and new experiences, so I block off long weekends or entire weeks—sometimes a year in advance—for vacations, even if I don't know yet where I'm going yet.

Remember that the key point is *not* to use a to-do list as your primary time management tool. Items on a to-do list can sit there forever, constantly getting bumped by things that seem urgent in the moment. And having this list of things that still need to get done is the root cause of our underlying stress.

When you master the practice of time blocking—using your calendar instead of your to-do-list—you can literally see your life's priorities by looking at your weekly calendar.

How Does This Apply If You're A(n)...

Entrepreneur: Would it be helpful to block time each week to talk directly to customers, review metrics against goals, or coach your direct reports?

Executive: Would it be helpful to block time for your top objectives?

Freelancer: Would it be helpful to set up time blocks each week to read industry blogs or learn how to use new tools?

Student: Would it help to time block study group time and your teachers' office hours?

Stay-at-Home Parent: Would it be helpful to time block trips to the gym, weekly errands, and bill paying?

SECRET #3

Work from your calendar, not a to-do list.

How much less stress would you feel if you could rip up your to-do list and work from your calendar?

* * **FREE BONUS** * *

To download the Millionaire Day Planner worksheet and other FREE bonuses, visit: www.MasterYourMinutes.com

The Procrastination Cure

Imagine if you could use a mental exercise to finally defeat procrastination. How different might your life be?

Procrastination Isn't about Laziness

It's ironic, but I'm procrastinating right now as I write this chapter. I'm supposed to be doing research and customization for a speaking engagement I landed with a giant energy company. But instead I'm writing this chapter. It's not like the motivation isn't there. They're paying me \$54,425 to deliver three talks in three days. So I should be jumping up and down for joy and eager to dive in. But alas, writing a book on time and productivity is easier and more fun for me than spending a half day poking around Google Scholar, reading dry academic papers, and creating compelling new slides. Besides, I can get to it tomorrow....

Procrastination is the habit of putting off important, less pleasurable tasks by doing easier, more pleasurable tasks. Things like email, Twitter, Facebook, food, and TV are excellent ways to procrastinate.

In an interview with the American Psychological Association, Joseph Ferrari, PhD, shared some of his research findings:

We all put tasks off, but my research has found that 20 percent of U.S. men and women are chronic procrastinators. They delay at home, work, school, and in relationships. These 20 percent make procrastination their way of life...Let's place the 20 percent in perspective—that's higher than the number of people diagnosed with clinical depression or phobias, two tendencies many people know about.

To beat procrastination once and for all, you have to understand it. You don't procrastinate because you're lazy.

You procrastinate because:

1. You lack enough motivation, and/or
2. You underestimate the power of *present* emotions versus *future* emotions when you set your goals or make your task list.

We tend to procrastinate a wide variety of things. You might procrastinate doing that school report, or making those cold calls, or firing someone who clearly has to go, or cleaning out the garage.

For me, my weak spot is exercise. In every other area of life, once I've decided on the goal, I'm able to execute it without procrastination. But working out? That's a whole other story. So let me use exercise and fitness as our example in the following procrastination busters.

Research Says...

People who rarely procrastinate report higher levels of productivity, happiness, and energy.

(Source: The Kruse Group, 2015)

Procrastination Buster #1: Time Travel

This is a big one. The underlying problem we all have is that we are what psychologists call ***time-inconsistent***.

This means we *think* we'll eat salads during the week, so we stock up on lettuce at the grocery store, but inevitably we end up with slimy rotting lettuce two weeks later at the bottom of our refrigerator.

Being time-inconsistent also means we add documentaries and indie films to our Netflix queue because certainly we'll watch them in the future, and yet they never move to #1 because we keep choosing Will Ferrell movies.

And it's why I keep buying new workout equipment and a fancy scale and healthy food cookbooks, and yet I'm still not seeing my six-pack abs.

Despite what we think we are going to want in the future, we have “**present bias.**” When the present actually gets here—and yes, the present is always here—we choose candy, sitcoms, Facebook, and cat videos. They’re easier and more fun. And hey, we can always get to that other thing in the afternoon, or on Monday, or do the resolution again in January, right?

We always underestimate how hard it is to be our best self in the present moment.

To overcome this time inconsistency, we must do battle with our future self—the one who, in the present moment, will sabotage us. Our future self is the enemy of our best self.

I like to think of this battle as time traveling to defeat my future self. Using the health example, I start by thinking, *how will I sabotage my health goals in the future?* How can I overcome that now?

- My future self is going to sabotage me by eating junk food in the kitchen during my breaks. To beat him, my present self is going to throw out all the junk food and not keep any in the house. I’m also going to buy baby carrots and hummus to reach for as a replacement.
- My future self is going to sabotage my workout by saying it’s too busy of a day to fit it in. My present self will defeat him by time blocking exercise first thing in the morning, and I will immediately put workout clothes on as soon as I get out of bed, and I will refuse to look at email until after I work out.
- My future self is also going to sabotage my workouts by thinking *I’m actually pretty healthy, I don’t look that bad compared to most people who go to the mall, and my blood pressure and cholesterol are fine.* My present self is going to tell my girlfriend to pinch my love handle flab on any day I don’t hit the treadmill...dang, that will be embarrassing and gross!

One friend of mine goes to extreme measures to battle her five-minute future self! In pursuit of her health goals, whenever she eats out at a restaurant and they bring her a side of French fries, she immediately opens the salt shaker and dumps the entire thing on top of the fries. She has learned not to trust regular old willpower to not eat the fries. Her five-minutes-in-the-future self is likely to say, “I’ll just have one.” And we all know how that goes.

How are you going to do battle with your future self?

Procrastination Buster #2: Pain & Pleasure

Ultimately, if we aren’t jumping out of bed in the morning excited to tackle our project, it’s because our dreams aren’t big enough. They aren’t motivating enough. And motivation comes down to pain and pleasure. For the tough tasks you always tend to procrastinate, think about and even visualize the “why” behind them.

What pleasure will I get by doing this thing?

What pain will I feel if I don’t do it?

One of my enabling goals is to work out every day. Yoga stretches, resistance training, and the treadmill. I need to really pile on the pain and pleasure in my mind to actually do my workouts. *Why do I want to work out? Because I want to look good, I want definition in my abs (come on, what guy doesn’t?), I want high energy, and I believe cardiovascular exercise keeps the brain healthy.*

What’s the pain I’ll feel if I don’t work out? I visualize looking flabby with a beer belly (sometimes I don’t need to “visualize” it!). I think about that weird pain above my knee that I get when I don’t do the pigeon pose in yoga. I think about feeling like a loser, a couch potato, with no energy. I even think about the fact that not working out is disrespectful to my girlfriend.

Does this mental routine sound extreme? I definitely go through this pain and pleasure thought cycle if I’m not feeling motivated, but it’s actually helpful to just run through it routinely to burn it into my mindset.

Procrastination Buster #3: Accountability Partner

My childhood friend Curt grew up and became a sports psychologist. He tells me that the number one predictor of whether someone will stick to an exercise routine or not is whether they are doing it with someone else.

This can be a neighbor who meets you every morning at 6 a.m. for a jog. It can be a professional trainer whom you pay \$50 an hour to come to your house to kick your butt. It can be your boss who likes to play basketball every day at lunch. It can be a Weight Watchers club where you weigh in every week. And of course, it can be a study buddy at school or just a good friend who is going to check in with you and keep you accountable.

The reason why this is so powerful is that when we procrastinate, we are merely breaking a promise to ourselves; we feel far worse when we break a promise to somebody else.

Procrastination Buster #4: Reward and Punishment

Some people I know respond very well to bribes—even though they are the one in control of the bribe!

One friend told herself she could buy a new pair of expensive shoes, but only after she paid off her credit cards. Another friend bought an excellent bottle of wine but wouldn't drink it until he got down to a certain percentage of body fat.

But in addition to the “carrot,” don't forget about the stick approach. Human psychology is such that we actually fear loss more than we want a gain. So instead of rewarding yourself for goal achievement, you can also punish yourself for goal failure.

One company, StickK (<http://www.stickk.com/>), has made a website that lets you set up a “commitment contract.” You pick the goal, the penalty, and a charity of your choice will receive your money if you don't hit the goal. As of this

writing, over \$14 million has been put up as stakes against goals.

My friend John recently set up a team weight loss goal with his colleagues in the office. Liberal in their political views, they each chipped in \$100 and have to donate it to the National Rifle Association if they *don't* shed the agreed upon pounds.

Of course, you don't need fancy software to execute on this strategy. You can always just set up a commitment contract with friends. Give them \$100, or whatever amount will "hurt" you, and share your goal. If you don't follow through, they can keep the money or give it to a charity.

Procrastination Buster #5: Act As If...

Be. That's it. Be.

Admittedly, this one is a little deep. It has to do with our identity. We all work really hard to stay consistent with who we think we are.

Much of the problem behind task avoidance is that we aren't yet the person we are trying to become. We can visualize our ideal future state, but sometimes the present state—sitting here on the couch watching TV—*feels* a lot better. One unusual but very effective strategy is to self-talk yourself (out loud or in your head) as if you already were your ideal self.

I am a healthy eater. I am a jogger. I am the #1 sales rep in my company. I am a neat person. I am a bestselling author. I am an entrepreneur.

What this self-talk is doing is anchoring your values. If you are already a jogger, it will feel bad and unnatural not to go out jogging today. If you are a writer, of course you are going to sit and write at the computer today—it's what writers do. If you are a healthy person, of course you'll get a to-go salad at the airport instead of a slice of pizza.

Just *be* who you want to become. It will then feel bad—it will be incongruent—*not* to do the task you might be tempted to procrastinate.

Procrastination Buster #6: Settle For Good Enough

Sometimes we find it easy to *start* things, but we procrastinate finishing them. One trick to use is to just plan on settling for less than perfect.

Procrastinating that three mile jog? Well, just suit up and go outside and agree to run around the block once...that will be good enough. And maybe it will be, or maybe once you're done with the block you'll keep going.

Procrastinating finishing that book you've been working on? Well, just agree to push through it sloppily to complete draft one...you can always come back later to revise it.

Procrastinating finishing that new product? Just launch it to the marketplace even if it isn't perfect, and get it closer to perfection each quarter with a new release.

Once you start something, once you agree that imperfect is OK, you'll feel a stronger motivation to finish it up.

How Does This Apply If You're A(n)...

Entrepreneur: Would overcoming procrastination help you to work on the things that feel outside of your comfort zone?

Executive: Would overcoming procrastination make you more effective at having those difficult constructive feedback conversations with your direct reports?

Freelancer: Would overcoming procrastination help you to achieve more billable hours each day?

Student: Would overcoming procrastination help you to complete class projects sooner?

Stay-at-Home Parent: Would overcoming procrastination help you to finally organize the rooms in your house—thus making your mind more peaceful?

Procrastination can be overcome when you figure out how to beat your future self, who cannot be trusted to do the right thing.

You know what needs to get done this week; how will you ensure that you don't put it off?

*** * FREE BONUS * ***

To download your “Procrastination Cure Infographic” and other FREE bonuses, visit: www.MasterYourMinutes.com

How to Leave the Office at 5:00—Without Guilt

How can the world's most important people always seem so calm, stress free, and fully present in the moment?

Republican political strategist Karl Rove wrote a fascinating op-ed in the *Wall Street Journal*.

It all started on New Year's Eve in 2005. President Bush asked what my New Year's resolutions were. I told him that as a regular reader who'd gotten out of the habit, my goal was to read a book a week in 2006. Three days later, we were in the Oval Office when he fixed me in his sights and said, "I'm on my second. Where are you?" Mr. Bush had turned my resolution into a contest.

And the outcome of the bet?

At year's end, I defeated the president, 110 books to 95. My trophy looks suspiciously like those given out at junior bowling finals. The president lamely insisted he'd lost because he'd been busy as leader of the free world.

The leader of the free world has time to read 95 books in one year?

Sheryl Sandberg Makes It Home for Dinner

Look at the habits of these highly successful business leaders:

- Facebook COO Sheryl Sandberg leaves work at 5:30 p.m. every day so she can have dinner with her kids at 6:00 p.m.
- Former Intel president Andy Grove would arrive at 8:00 a.m. and leave work at 6:00 p.m. consistently.
- Virgin Group founder Richard Branson has over 400 companies in his conglomerate, yet he always

seems to be hanging out on his private island or breaking some crazy world record as an adventurer.

Don't you find this shocking? How can they do that?

When I first read about President Bush, I was blown away. You just know the president of the United States of America has a million things to do, right? At the end of the day, there are still more foreign leaders to call and influence, more CIA briefings to read, more campaign contributors to suck up to, more wounded veterans to visit, more voters to rally, more, more, more—and time until the end of his term was ticking away. He had a limited number of days to create his legacy! And yet President Bush “found” time to read 95 books in one year.

Doug Conant, who was the CEO of Campbell's Soup for a decade, used to send out 20 handwritten thank you notes a day. Can you imagine all the responsibilities of being the CEO of a Fortune 500 company? There are always more emails to read, more calls to return, more reports to scan, more meetings to attend, more thinking about the future, and yet...Doug would calmly end his day by hand writing 20 notes.

Back when I was young and dumb, I was running a company that was part of a larger conglomerate. My company was doubling in size every year, and there were never enough hours in the day. I can remember literally jogging through the hallways trying to get back to my office as quickly as possible.

Yet my business partner and boss, Neil, who oversaw my company and 11 other divisions, always moved at a leisurely pace, always had time to tell a funny joke or story, and spent lots of time at the local golf club.

Who has time to play golf? I used to wonder.

The Secret to Guilt-Free Balance

Andy Grove revealed this ultimate secret in his book *High Output Management*.

My day ends when I'm tired and ready to go home, not when I'm done. I am never done. Like a housewife's, a manager's work is never done. There is always more to be done, more that should be done, always more than can be done.

And that is the secret.

There will always be more to do, and always more than can be done.

This is another one of those simple concepts that, once it truly sinks in, can dramatically change your life.

I can remember the very moment I read Grove's book. It hit me like a ton of bricks.

For too long, I let my to-do list master me. "Sorry, I can't make it home for dinner because I still have that report to do."

I never exercised, I skipped most meals, and then I would gorge on fast food. My life was one dimensional, and even in that dimension (business), my around-the-clock pace kept me down in the weeds instead of above the trees.

Super successful people don't just burn hour after hour trying to cross more items off their task list. Instead, they think through their priorities, schedule time for each, and then enough is enough.

George Bush probably valued reading two books a week because it was a way to relieve stress, get smarter, or was just plain fun. He knew that learning and recharging are valuable tasks, and he wasn't going to let them get blocked out by "urgent" items.

Sheryl Sandberg clearly puts a high value on dinner with the family and keeps it scheduled. Yes, she wants to maximize the success of Facebook, but the "success" of her relationship with her children is even more important.

Richard Branson places a high value on fun and adventure and calendars it accordingly. And he smartly crafts his adventures into brand building for Virgin.

Research Says...

People who leave work at a consistent time are less likely to feel “wired” later at night.

(Source: The Kruse Group, 2015)

Do You Need to Be Everything for Everyone?

Jessica Turner, the author of *The Fringe Hours: Making Time for You*, surveyed over 2,000 women for her book and, among other things, asked them to describe the hardest part of being a woman. The common theme: **Being everything to everyone.**

This is something Turner relates to herself. In addition to being a writer, she runs the highly popular Mom Creative (www.themomcreative.com) blog, has a husband, has three children under the age of six, and tries hard to maintain her friendships. She describes how these multiple roles can become unhealthy.

For women, this “disease to please” can wreak havoc on every area of our lives. We are nurturers by nature. We want to help and love on others. But sometimes our actions are not an outpouring of love but a result of wanting to please someone else.

This phenomenon is closely related to the disease of perfectionism. It’s dangerous to base our *self*-worth on what *others* think of us.

Many people are surprised that I, a man, can relate a lot to what Turner is describing in her book. Perhaps it’s because I’m a single dad and accustomed to maintaining a household. Regardless of the reason, I still spend too much time—and more importantly, too much stress—on little things that really don’t matter.

Recently, my financial advisor told me he was going to be in my neighborhood and wanted to stop by my home and give me an update on my money. It was a sign of high service, and I was grateful.

But my mind immediately took off—*better brew a pot of coffee; is the fridge stocked with Coke? What if he drinks Diet Coke, do I have any of that? We'll be meeting in the kitchen—need to clean the kitchen counter. Is he allergic to cats? I should lock them in the basement...*

It's completely ridiculous to think this way about my advisor making a house call. Among the numerous reasons:

1. He works for me; he'll keep working for me if I keep paying him.
2. He knows far more important things about me—like my net worth—than my kitchen.
3. He's a guy and is probably in awe that another guy is able to keep the house as clean as I do!
4. He knows me personally and I'm sure judges me by my values and kindness, not my hospitality skills.

It is one thing to have good manners and to want to treat friends well and another to *feel like you have to be perfect*. Instead of running around for half an hour preparing for a visitor, I could have just greeted him with a smile and asked, “Can I get you some water?”

As Turner says in her book:

You are never too busy to make time for what you love. It's just a matter of prioritizing—evaluating how you spend your days and dedicating time for what you value. If something is really important to you, you will find a way to fit it into your life.

There Will Always Be More to Do

There will always be more to do in every area:

- You can always do more stuff at work.

- You can always straighten up more rooms and clean more closets.
- You can always do more yard work.
- More, more, more!

So you need to master the practice of letting go of the more, since there will always be more to do.

Once you master this, you'll find it easier to get those workouts in, easier to get home to the family at a reasonable hour, and easier to spend time on yourself without feeling guilty.

How Does This Apply If You're A(n)...

Entrepreneur: Would realizing there will always be more to do enable you to spend more time with your family and friends?

Executive: Would realizing there will always be more to do enable you to hit the gym on a more consistent basis?

Freelancer: Would realizing there will always be more to do enable you to spend more time learning new skills and thinking strategically about your future?

Student: Would realizing there will always be more to do enable you to be satisfied with a good grade instead of a perfect grade?

Stay-at-Home Parent: Would realizing there will always be more to do enable you to give yourself an hour a day—for reading, exercising, or scrapbooking?

SECRET #5

Accept the fact that there will *always* be more to do and more that can be done.

How much better will you feel when you finally accept the fact that you *can't* do it all, because there will always be more that can be done?

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Richard Branson's Secret Productivity Tool

How can you get your brain to quiet down? How can you always remember your great ideas?

Branson's Most Important Possession

Sir Richard Branson. Arguably the most celebrated entrepreneur of our time. Founder of the Virgin Group, which now comprises over 400 companies, Branson is reportedly worth \$4.8 billion.

When asked about items he takes wherever he goes, Branson singled out one item as being most important. In a May 5, 2006, interview he said:

It may sound ridiculous, but my most important is to always carry a little notebook in your back pocket. I think the number one thing that I take with me when I'm traveling is the notebook...I could never have built the Virgin Group into the size it is without those few bits of paper.

Branson, writing on his blog, elaborated on his note-taking habits. He said, "If you have a thought but don't write it down, by the next morning it may be gone forever." One time, when Branson had an idea for a business metaphor, he didn't have a notebook nearby. So he just scribbled the thought down in his passport!

Advice from Billionaire Aristotle Onassis

Greek shipping magnate Aristotle Onassis once gave an interview in which he shared his "million dollar lesson."

Always carry a notebook. Write everything down. When you have an idea, write it down. When you meet

someone new, write down everything you know about them. That way you will know how much time they are worth. When you hear something interesting, write it down. Writing it down will make you act upon it. If you don't write it down you will forget it. THAT is a million dollar lesson they don't teach you in business school!

Jim Rohn's Three Treasures

Self-made millionaire and legendary success coach Jim Rohn wrote and spoke frequently about the power of journaling.

If you're serious about becoming a wealthy, powerful, sophisticated, healthy, influential, cultured, and unique individual, keep a journal.

Keeping a journal is so important. I call it one of the three treasures to leave behind for the next generation...

The first treasure is your pictures. Take a lot of pictures...

The second treasure is your library. This is the library that taught you, that instructed you, that helped you defend your ideals. It helped you develop a philosophy. It helped you become wealthy, powerful, healthy, sophisticated, and unique...

The third treasure is your journals: the ideas that you picked up, the information that you meticulously gathered. But of the three, journal writing is one of the greatest indications that you're a serious student.

Notebooks of 20 Famous People

The blog *The Art of Manliness* has a great article (<http://www.artofmanliness.com/2010/09/13/the-pocket-notebooks-of-20-famous-men/>) that shows pictures of the notebooks of 20 famous men including **Mark Twain, George Patton, Thomas Jefferson, Charles Darwin, George Lucas, Ernest Hemingway, Ludwig van Beethoven, Ben Franklin, Thomas Edison, Leonardo da Vinci, Frank Capra, and John Rockefeller.**

Although you can see a wide range of notebook styles and penmanship, all show how these great thinkers were never without a means to jot down an observation, an idea, or in Mark Twain's case, dirty jokes.

What Type of Notebook Is the Best?

There are different strokes for different folks:

- Many creative wannabes use Moleskine (<http://www.moleskine.com/us/home>) notebooks. I use them myself. These high-quality leather-bound books are made in Italy and cost from \$9 to \$25.
- Some Moleskine fans are switching to Ecosystem (<http://www.ecosystemlife.com/>) notebooks, including Michael Hyatt (<http://michaelhyatt.com/why-i-ditched-my-moleskine-journal.html>), because they use recycled paper, are made in the USA, and each page is perforated.
- For many years, I preferred the more expensive and unfortunately very nerdy Boorum & Pease Account Book. It's hard cover, 300 pages so it lasts a long time, thick enough to stand up and stand out on a bookshelf—and so big I never misplaced it.
- Author and entrepreneur James Altucher (<http://www.jamesaltucher.com/>) recommends waiter's pads, which cost ten cents each. He explains they are the perfect size and a great conversation starter—they also show people you're frugal.

Notice that nobody is recommending yellow legal pads or loose pieces of paper. They are just too easy to get lost in stacks or otherwise damaged. Notebooks are designed to last.

In Their Own Words...

I use this Moleskine notebook that I'll just carry around with me. I make training notes in it. I make work notes in it. I have a whole bookshelf full of old ones at home, because I'll go back and refer to old things in it all the time.

—Sara Hendershot is an Olympic rower for the United States and competed in the 2012 Olympics. She is currently training for Rio 2016.

I use the Bullet Journal as my go-to organization system. It keeps ideas, thoughts, and other important agenda items at my fingertips. I highly recommend keeping a journal, because a life worth living is a life worth recording.

—Honorée Corder is an author, speaker, and personal transformation expert.

While apps can be wonderful and help us increase productivity, I prefer to plan in my Moleskine Executive Daily.

—Natalie MacNeil is an Emmy Award-winning media entrepreneur, creator of SheTakesOnTheWorld.com, and author of The Conquer Kit (Perigee 2015).

Take Notes by Hand, Not on a Laptop

Using paper-based bound notebooks for notes is better than taking notes on a laptop, tablet, or smartphone.

Let the hate mail begin!

First, let me say that if you have dyslexia or another learning disability and can really only record notes by typing them into a digital device, *go for it*. It's not a sin, and I'm not trying to bias the world against you.

But if you are using a digital device as a general preference and just think I'm being an old fashioned Luddite, I encourage you to consider an interesting article, "The Pen Is Mightier Than the Keyboard," published in the journal *Psychological Science* in 2014.

Pam Mueller and Daniel Oppenheimer, psychologists at Princeton University and the University of California, Los Angeles, did three different experiments with 327 undergraduates. In one study, students watched a TED talk, took notes, and then took a test on it 30 minutes later. While

the laptop users and hand-writers scored the same on factual questions, the laptop users did worse on the conceptual questions.

Noticing that laptop users were transcribing the TED talk instead of noting key concepts, Drs. Mueller and Oppenheimer did a second study and specifically told the laptop users to just take notes in their own words. The results were the same; hand-writers had better recall of the material.

One defense of laptop note-taking is that it enables you to take a more complete set of notes, which is helpful when you need to review the material at a later date. In other words, you'll have more of the raw content to study. So the researchers did a third study in which students took the test a week later, and were given time to study before the test. Once again, hand-writers scored higher.

This latest research from Princeton and UCLA just confirms what others have discovered in the past. The act of taking notes by hand involves active listening, cognitive processing, and finally recalling it to record it. People who take notes with a laptop tend to just robotically record spoken words, without doing the mental work to process it.

And don't forget, if you want to keep a digital, searchable archive of all your notes, you can always scan them into Evernote, use the Jot Script 2 Evernote stylus, or use the Livescribe notebook by Moleskine.

My Personal Notebook System

There are many different fancy Moleskine systems available—including people who cut out tabs or use fancy labeling systems. But you might find inspiration in my Kevin Kruse Moleskine Genius System (OK, I just made that up, I don't have a fancy name for my system). To me, the more complicated I make a paper notebook, the less likely I'll use it. So I just keep it simple.

1. Get yourself a brand new notebook. (I'm back to using Moleskine.) Doesn't it feel great in your hands?

2. Get yourself some Pilot G2 gel pens. They're cheap and a joy to write with. I also like the Sharpie Extra Fine Point pens.
3. Tape your business card to the inside front cover so if you ever leave it behind in a conference room or airplane, a good Samaritan will get it back to you. Some people write, "If found, please call or email me. I will pay a reward to get this back!"
4. Write the current date on the inside cover so you can quickly locate the notebook in the future if you are trying to find notes from a specific meeting or event. Some people like to use a Sharpie to write the start date on the edge of the pages, so it can be seen without even opening the notebook.
5. Jot down everything and anything you don't want to forget. Record random creative ideas you have: new ideas for books you want to write, companies you want to start, products to invent, new marketing tactics, gift ideas for your family, future vacation destinations, restaurant recommendations, a great bottle of wine, names for your baby, whatever! Write everything down, and you'll never worry or stress out about forgetting something again.
6. Whenever you encounter great advice or an inspirational quote—whether someone says it or you read it—write it down in the back of the book. Reserve pages in the back for these nuggets of wisdom so they can all stay together and be easily reviewed in the future.
7. At the beginning of each phone call or meeting, write the date, time, and names of the people you are speaking with. Jot down any notes from the call, especially any follow-up items or commitments people are making.
8. If you are meeting people for the first time, draw a little diagram of the conference table and write their names in the location where they are sitting to help you remember them. Jot down notes from

the meeting but do not try to record everything that is said. You aren't a court reporter! Just try to record key goals, actions, next steps. Summarize.

9. When you have filled your notebook, write the end date on the inside front cover, again to help you locate the right book in the future when you have a whole row of them on your bookshelf.
10. Put the book up on the shelf next to the previous journals. Here will be a detailed record of your entire life!
11. Every New Year's Day, make it a new tradition to thumb through your old journals from the previous year. You'll be amazed at how much you'll re-learn from your notes, and it will remind you of all your progress. For any thoughts or ideas that you'll want to revisit in the current year, just rewrite them in your new or current notebook.

I also use shorthand that adds clarity to my free-form notes.

- I put an open square (□) next to any item that is a "to do," which I'll put onto my calendar as soon as possible.
- I put an open circle (○) next to any item that is an event to calendar later.
- I put an exclamation mark (!) next to items that require a follow-up action from me.
- I put a question mark (?) next to items that I want to ask about at the end of the meeting.
- I put an asterisk (*) next to items that are important or key themes from an event.

How Does This Apply If You're A(n)...

Entrepreneur: Would a notebook help you keep a record of all the commitments colleagues make during meetings?

Executive: Would a notebook help you record all that you accomplish throughout the year?

Freelancer: Would a notebook help you remember key client obligations?

Student: Would a notebook help you to capture key lecture notes?

Stay-at-Home Parent: Would a notebook help you to capture all the random to-do items that occur each day? Remember, you can review and transfer them to your calendar at a later time.

SECRET #6

Always carry a notebook.

How much less stress will you feel when you begin to dump everything important into your notebook?

* * **FREE BONUS** * *

To download the “Get The Most from Your Notebook” quick reference card and other FREE bonuses, visit:

www.MasterYourMinutes.com

Master Your Email Inbox With 321Zero

How can you empty your email inbox quickly and keep it from interfering with truly productive work?

Email as a Cognitive Slot Machine

According to a survey conducted by the McKinsey Global Institute, office workers spend 2.6 hours per day reading and answering emails, which equates to 33 percent of a 40-hour workweek. (OK, OK, nobody only works 40 hours anymore, but it's *still* a big chunk of an average work week!)

Clearly people send too much email at work, and as the dominant form of professional communication, it's hard to ignore. But you have to take responsibility for your own role in email overwhelm, too.

Your brain uses email—and all social media—like a cognitive slot machine. Like pulling a slot handle, there is anticipation, which feels good as you go to check for new messages. And most of the time it's a bust, nothing there. But every now and then, *ding ding ding*, “*Oh, look! An interesting article!*” Or even, “*Oh, someone has a question I can answer in only five minutes! I'm so helpful and productive!*”

And our brain releases a bit of dopamine with every triple cherry on the email slot machine. *Ah, that feels good!* Which makes us come back and check it again and again. Yes, you receive too much email, but you need to take responsibility for handling it.

7 Steps to Mastering Your Email

Unsubscribe from email newsletters. Come on! Do you really need to subscribe to all those fashion websites? Those flash deals-of-the-day offers? Those viral clickbait “news” headlines? Don't give permission to all those companies to

intrude on your day, to interrupt your flow, to tempt you with their offers. They are trying hard to get into your head, but they can't if they're not in your inbox to begin with! Just go into your email and search for "unsubscribe" and then unsubscribe from all the email newsletters that you find. You can also go to a cool site called www.Unroll.me and it will let you easily unsubscribe from the newsletters you want to trash, and then it will consolidate the newsletters you want to keep into one big daily email.

Turn off all email notifications. Email is not intended to be an urgent form of communication, and especially in these times when most of us are getting 50 to 500 emails a day, getting email notifications is a sin. Notifications interrupt your concentration, your work sprints, and your ability to be present during meetings and conversations. Whether you have an audible ding, a phone vibration, or a little window that pops up with every new email...TURN ALL THAT OFF.

Only process email three times a day, using the 321-Zero system. Schedule three times a day to process your email (morning, noon, night), set the timer on your phone for 21 minutes, and try to get to inbox zero in that time. Make a game out of it. 21 minutes is intentionally not enough time, but it will keep you focused, ensure that your responses are short, and that you don't start clicking links out onto the wonderful world of internet distractions.

Immediately apply the 4 D's. Every time you open an email, you should be ready to **Do** it, **Delegate** it, **Defer** it, or **Delete** (archive) it.

If you defer an email, in most cases that means immediately adding an entry to your calendar—"moving" the email to a calendar entry (remember, no to-do lists!).

When you think "delete," in most cases you should really just archive. These days, with virtually unlimited storage space, it's easy to just hit the Archive button on most things, knowing that you can use the search function to get it back again in the future.

In addition to the 4 D's, consider F for **File It**. In my opinion, this is just another form of archiving, but it can be helpful especially if you are nervous you might not be able to find something again. Just create folders for all your projects, clients, or even something crazy like "Respond to Someday," and then drag emails related to those topics into the folders to keep your inbox nice and clean.

In Their Own Words...

Meetings, phone calls, and emails can break up your entire day if you let them, leaving you little time to get any big thinking done...Cancel meetings you don't need. And only check email a few times a day.

—Jonah Berger is a marketing professor at the Wharton School at the University of Pennsylvania and author of Contagious: Why Things Catch On.

How do you create an effective work routine? Simple: by choosing what you want it to be, rather than letting others dictate it for you. Except that most people do exactly the opposite, through one simple (terrible) habit: they check their email first thing in the morning...This means that their focus and energy are going where others are directing it, rather than where they stand to make the greatest impact.

—Danny Iny is the founder of marketing education firm Firepole Marketing as well as the bestselling author of Engagement from Scratch! and The Audience Revolution.

Think twice before you forward, cc, or bcc. As reported in an August 9, 2013, article in the *Wall Street Journal*, London-based International Power reduced total email traffic by 54 percent just by encouraging their top executives to "think twice" before they forwarded an email or added anyone to the cc: line. Too often we forward or cc someone in the spirit of keeping them "in the loop," but in reality we are contributing to the information overload problem. Remember, every email you send and every cc you include means you are likely going to get a reply back into your own email box. If you *send* less email, you'll also *receive* less email.

Use the subject line to indicate the action required. An ideal subject line doesn't just indicate the subject of the email, but also the type of action it requires. This helps email recipients to process your email in less time. And they'll learn

to reciprocate. The idea is to preface your subject line message with some meta-information. I like to use all caps to make this part of the subject stand out from the message. Here are some examples:

- “FYI: [subject]”—Use the FYI designation when you are just passing info along as a courtesy.
- “ACTION REQUIRED by [DATE]: [subject]” or “TO DO by [DATE]”—Use ACTION REQUIRED when your recipients should take an action, but they don’t report to you; use TO DO when you are giving a directive to someone who reports to you.
- “NRN: [subject]”—NRN stands for “no response needed” and can be used to eliminate the polite response emails that people often send like “Thanks” or “Looks interesting” or “I’ll take a look at this next week,” etc.
- “[subject]–EOM”—My personal favorite, EOM stands for “end of message” and lets you put super short messages right in the subject line. EOM tells the recipient, don’t bother opening this one because all the content is in the subject line.

Keep emails short—really short. Realize that being brief isn’t rude; it’s a sign of respect for the other person’s time (in addition to your own).

There is even a movement that suggests we consider email messages to be similar to text messages. The website five.sentenc.es suggests you limit all your emails to five sentences or fewer and then add a footer message that directs people to the website for an explanation.

In Their Own Words...

Why use 100 words when 10 words will do. Whether that is in an email, a report, a presentation, or a pitch. Brevity can be powerful.

—Naomi Simson, founder of RedBalloon, author of Live What You Love, and investor on Shark Tank Australia.

Keep emails short and sweet. Over the years, I've trained myself to write three-sentence emails, leaving out the fluff and keeping only the most essential points. It saves my time and it saves the reader's time.

—Ryan Holmes is the founder and CEO of HootSuite.

How to Get to Inbox Zero in Ten Minutes

My friend Christine has over 10,000 emails in her inbox, most of them unread! Perhaps you can relate?

If this is the situation you find yourself in, you might want to declare email bankruptcy and quickly start at “inbox zero” before applying the email management steps in this chapter.

My suggestion is:

1. Deal with all email that arrived within the last 48 hours.
2. Create a folder called Old Emails.
3. Move ALL of the emails sitting in your inbox into the Old Emails folder.
4. Voila, you're starting fresh at inbox zero.

Is this sort of cheating? Maybe.

Couldn't you just archive all your emails instead of creating a new folder? Yes.

But why haven't you previously deleted or archived or filed your emails? Why are they sitting there to begin with? Most people tell me that they're afraid there is something valuable that they'll never find again. They don't seem to trust the archive function or know how to use it. So a simple solution is to just create your own labeled folder and move everything there. Enjoy!

How Does This Apply If You're A(n)...

Entrepreneur: Would keeping your email inbox clean reduce your levels of stress and enable you to spend more time on revenue-producing activities?

Executive: Would reducing the time spent on email enable you to spend more time on strategic priorities?

Freelancer: Would reducing the time spent on email enable you to spend more time advancing your skills?

Student: I'm guessing you don't use email very much!

Stay-at-Home Parent: Would eliminating the number of email newsletters you receive help you to spend time more productively?

SECRET #7

Email is a great way for other people to put *their* priorities into *your* life; control your inbox.

Are you ready to commit to checking email no more than three times a day?

*** * FREE BONUS * ***

To download your "Get to Inbox Zero" infographic and other FREE bonuses, visit: www.MasterYourMinutes.com

Meeting Hacks from Google, Apple, and Virgin

How can you immediately shorten the time spent in meetings by one-third?

Been to a great meeting lately? Yeah, didn't think so. Most meetings are poorly organized, poorly facilitated, and highly inefficient.

In a survey conducted in 2015 by Clarizan, 35 percent of those polled said their weekly status meetings were a waste of time. And if a dozen people are sitting in a one-hour “waste of time” meeting, it's actually a waste of *12 hours*! That's a dozen hours of lost productivity, often to present or review information that could have been covered in minutes through a different medium.

Yet Harvard professor Nancy Koehn estimates that 11 million meetings are held in the U.S. each day!

Why Meetings Suck

Why do the majority of meetings suck so badly?

Meetings start late. Whether a result of unprofessional behavior or the fact that many people literally have meetings stacked back to back, most meetings end up starting late. This becomes a cultural phenomenon as late meetings actually train people to arrive late. When everyone knows the meeting won't start until five or ten minutes past the hour, they don't bother showing up on time. When dozens, hundreds, or even thousands of people in an organization sit around waiting for other people to arrive, those minutes add up to many hours over the course of a year.

The wrong people are in the meeting. The default idea seems to be “When in doubt, invite them!” This wastes the time of the person who was invited (and who may not have the

professional courage to say “no thanks”), and if that person feels compelled to ask questions or give input, it wastes the time of everyone else in the meeting, too.

Parkinson’s law of triviality. Also known as the bike-shed effect, this law states that organizations spend the most time on trivial issues and the least time on the most important issues. The story goes that a committee must make several decisions related to an expensive nuclear power plant. The approval of the power plant goes quickly with little input because it’s too complicated of a topic for most participants to weigh in on. Yet when it comes to deciding on the design of the bike shed for the staff, since everyone understands the trivial project, great time is spent nitpicking and debating it.

Meetings break up the day in illogical ways and may interfere with flow or peak concentration times.

The wrong people dominate meetings. By their nature, the overconfident and the extroverts tend to dominate the communication in a meeting—at the expense of others who may know more but are less inclined to share a meeting format.

The Mark Cuban Meeting Rule

I reached out to hundreds of highly successful people as I was doing research for this book. By design, I was trying to contact the most successful people on the planet, and knowing that they only have 1,440 minutes a day, it never surprised me when people didn’t respond to me.

What *did* surprise me was when billionaire entrepreneur Mark Cuban responded to my email only 61 minutes after I sent it.

In his typical direct and to-the-point style, Cuban’s time management advice described his approach to meetings.

In Their Own Words...

Never take meetings unless someone is writing a check.

*—Mark Cuban is the owner of the Dallas Mavericks,
a serial entrepreneur, and an investor*

Dustin Moskovitz's No Meeting Wednesdays!

If you think Mark Cuban's advice is a bit extreme or impractical, perhaps you can swear off meetings for one day a week.

In an interview for this book, Dustin Moskovitz shared his "NMW" productivity hack, which he brought with him from Facebook.

In Their Own Words...

Pick one day a week that you and your team can focus on getting individual work done without any interruptions like meetings. At Asana, we have [No Meeting Wednesdays](#) established to encourage flow and productivity across the company.

—Dustin Moskovitz is the co-founder of [team productivity](#) app Asana and co-founder of Facebook.

Others have taken to this one-day meeting reprieve and called them "Maker Days." The idea is that everyone leaves everyone else alone to focus on "making" stuff—especially if it's making progress on their most important task (MIT).

How to Design Effective Meeting Agendas

If you *have* to have a meeting, highly successful people know that effective meetings begin with effective agendas, which are circulated in advance. Secrets to creating effective agendas include:

- Seek input on the agenda from participants before the meeting, so new topics don't crop up and derail the primary goal.
- Clearly state the purpose of the meeting.
- Clearly state who the facilitator is.
- Identify all invited participants. The fewer the better, but you also want to make sure a key person isn't being forgotten. Google tries to limit meeting participants to ten or fewer. Steve Jobs

was known to throw people out of the room if they couldn't come up with a good reason for being there.

- List agenda topics as questions whenever possible in order to focus the participants on decision-making.
- Attach time estimates to each agenda item so participants can monitor the progress and pace of the meeting; make sure time estimates are realistic.

Google Ventures' Secret Weapon

Jake Knapp, design partner at Google Ventures, is an advocate for using a physical clock to count down the time remaining in a meeting. He discovered a specific type of timer, called the Time Timer, while visiting his child's classroom.

Teachers have been known to call it “The Magic Clock.” Coming in various sizes—for about \$25 from Amazon.com—the Time Timer is battery powered and large enough to be seen by meeting participants from across a room. A red disc silently spins, showing the amount of time remaining. Why not just set a timer on your smartphone? As Knapp wrote on Medium (<https://medium.com/@jakek>):

The Time Timer is WAY better than a timer app on a screen. Because it's physical, it's easier to adjust and set, and absolutely impossible to ignore.

During her time at Google, Marissa Mayer was known for using a projector attached to a laptop to display a giant count-down timer up on the wall of the meeting room. I can only assume she still uses this practice at Yahoo!

The Steve Jobs Meeting Method

In 1999, a team of psychologists conducted research on the difference between sit-down and stand-up meetings across 56 different groups. As reported in the *Journal of Applied Psychology*:

Sit-down meetings were 34 percent longer than stand-up meetings, but they produced no better decisions than stand-up meetings.

In a different study, researchers at Washington University in St. Louis determined that standing meetings were far better than sit-down meetings in terms of outcomes. They reported in *Social Psychological & Personality Science* that stand-up meetings led to better collaboration and less possessiveness of ideas, higher levels of engagement, and more problem-solving creativity.

I still remember the first time I sold one of my businesses. Rudy Karsan was the CEO of the acquiring company, and in my very first visit to his corner office, he jumped up before I could sit and said, “Let’s go for a walk!” Thirty minutes later, we shook hands on a \$2 million deal.

Richard Branson isn’t into traditional meetings either. He writes in his blog (<http://www.virgin.com/author/richard-branson>):

One of my favourite tricks is to conduct most of my meetings standing up. I find it to be a much quicker way of getting down to business, making a decision and sealing the deal. When given the opportunity I often like to take things a step further – literally, with a walking meeting.

Steve Jobs was notorious for his long walking meetings, a practice that has been adopted by Mark Zuckerberg and Jack Dorsey as well.

Marissa Mayer and Richard Branson Hold 10-Minute Meetings

Why do all meetings seem to default to 30 minutes or one hour? It’s almost as if people choose that duration because that’s the default time block in the Outlook calendar. And we all know that work tends to fill up the space allocated to it.

In an interview with Bloomberg Business in 2006, when Marissa Mayer was still with Google (she now runs Yahoo),

she told the interviewer that she holds up to 70 meetings a week. The only way she can cram them all in is to break down the “30-minute” block into small meetings, sometimes as few as five or ten minutes each.

Virgin founder Richard Branson often talks about his aversion to meetings. In a blog post he shared:

It's very rare that a meeting on a single topic should need to last more than 5-10 minutes.

In Their Own Words...

The default length of a meeting or call—both internally and externally—should be 20 minutes; anything longer should be an exception...Even if you're just moving from 30-minute meetings to 20-minute meetings, you can fit in 4-6 more meetings, calls, or appointments in a day.

—Ryan Delk leads growth at Gumroad.

No Smartphones Allowed

Do you check your phone for text messages or emails during business meetings?

If you answered yes, research from the University of Southern California's Marshall School of Business suggests you are annoying your boss and colleagues. Their study found:

- 86 percent think it's inappropriate to answer phone calls during formal meetings.
- 84 percent think it's inappropriate to write texts or emails during formal meetings.
- 75 percent think it's inappropriate to read texts or emails during formal meetings.
- 66 percent think it's inappropriate to write texts or emails during any meetings.
- At least 22 percent think it's inappropriate to use phones during any meetings.

Why do so many people—especially more successful people—find smartphone use in meetings to be inappropriate? It's because when you access your phone, it shows:

- **Lack of respect.** You consider the information on your phone to be more important than the conversation in the meeting; you view people outside of the meeting to be more important than those sitting in front of you.
- **Lack of attention.** You are unable to stay focused on more than one item at a time; the ability to multitask is a myth.
- **Lack of listening.** You aren't demonstrating the attention and focus that is required of truly active listening.
- **Lack of power.** You are like a modern day Pavlovian dog who responds to the beck and call of others through the buzz of your phone.

To make the most of valuable time spent in meetings, participants should mute and pocket their devices and leave them in their pockets.

Daily Huddles Eliminate Other Meetings

Can more meetings lead to fewer meetings?

I've worked with a lot of consultants over the years, but only Verne Harnish ever gave me the secrets to building highly successful, fast-growing companies. Harnish is the founder of the legendary Entrepreneurs Organization, the CEO of Gazelles and also the author of *Scaling Up*.

One of the big aha moments I had from his work is that an organization can only move as fast as the leadership team. As goes leadership, goes the rest of the company. To make sure everyone is moving fast and staying in sync, it's critical to establish a rhythm or cadence of meetings—the most important being the *daily* huddle.

Initially I was very skeptical.

Daily huddles are quick stand-up meetings with you and your team members. No longer than 15 minutes, always scheduled at the same time each day.

What I quickly discovered is that once daily huddles were in place, they eliminated the need for many other longer one-off meetings, reduced the number of phone calls and emails, and had a dramatic impact on other variables including employee engagement and cross-selling.

The agendas of daily huddles include three things:

- What's up—highlights from the last 24 hours, especially anything relevant to other team members
- Numbers—this is to review any daily metrics, whether sales, conversion rates, or widget production
- Stuck—are you “stuck” on anything, whether it's a problem to solve, red tape to cut, or a question that needs an answer

In Their Own Words...

“Routine sets you free” is the mantra underpinning our tools and approach in Scaling Up companies, including the 15-minute daily huddle with your team (and spouse!) that will save everyone collectively over an hour each day and allow you to avoid minor train wrecks (that grow into bigger problems) and take advantage of immediate opportunities. “If you want to move faster, pulse faster.”

—Verne Harnish is the CEO of Gazelles.

Keep your daily huddles to 15 minutes! If they start to run longer, people will be less likely to show up. Force people to be brief, and any “stuck” items that can't be solved immediately should be taken offline.

How Does This Apply If You're A(n)...

Entrepreneur: Would reducing the time spent in meetings enable you to spend more time improving your product?

Executive: Would reducing the time spent in meetings enable you to spend more time coaching your team members?

Freelancer: Would reducing the time spent in meetings enable you to spend more time finding new clients?

Student: Do study groups truly help you with homework, or would you save time studying alone?

Stay-at-Home Parent: How many meetings do you attend in support of the PTA, the soccer league, or other community events? Could you have more impact by actually having fewer meetings?

SECRET #8

Schedule and attend meetings as a last resort,
when all other forms of communication won't
work.

**Look at the meetings on your calendar for the week ahead.
How can you eliminate them or reduce their allotted time?**

*** * FREE BONUS * ***

*To download your “Maximize Your Meetings” poster and
other FREE bonuses, visit: www.MasterYourMinutes.com*

One Little Word That Multiplies Success

Want a one-word magic spell that will instantly free up space on your calendar in the future?

“Focusing is about saying no.”—Steve Jobs

Email, social media, and text messaging has not only increased the overall amount of information we must deal with, but it has also made it far too easy for other people to ask us for things. Often the requests are social or personal in nature. Want to hang out tonight? Want to go to happy hour? Want to go out to lunch?

And for people who have experienced any amount of business or financial success, the inbound requests to “do lunch” and “grab coffee” flood the inbox each day.

Endless Requests for Our Time

These are the requests I’ve received in the last 24 hours:

- From a business friend, “Let’s grab lunch...”
- From an author acquaintance, “If you have something to say about the book, I’d be delighted if you’d post an Amazon review. You can do it here...”
- From an agent, asking me to include her roster of clients on my “Top 100 Leadership Speakers” list
- From an entrepreneur I’ve never met, “I am now over here in Boston—a bit of a shock to the system with all the snow— and I’d welcome the opportunity to have a quick five minute call if that was at all possible to say hello and seek your advice.”

- From a wonderful, local nonprofit leader letting me know about an upcoming fundraiser, “I hope that everyone on the committee will sell 10 tickets!”
- From the dean of a local college, “I am excited to talk to you about what we are doing here in the business department...Would you be available to meet for coffee one day?”
- Nine emails from readers introducing themselves and telling me about their current challenge.

And then of course are the requests that come through LinkedIn. I get 10–20 messages a day requesting a meeting or call to see if I would like to invest in a company, review a new product offering, provide advice for their startup, help them write their first book, and on and on.

Now don’t get me wrong. I’m not complaining about the requests, nor am I making fun of any of the people reaching out. On the contrary, I’m flattered and view these requests on my time to be a sign that I’m doing something right. And in fact, many of these requests I will respond to (coffee with the dean, for example).

But we must be vigilant with our time.

Remember, only 1,440 minutes in a day!

In Their Own Words...

Part of being an Olympic athlete is just that there are a lot of things that I have to miss, and moments or events that I have to skip. I’ve almost just gotten to the point where I’m used to having to say “No” to things.

—Sara Hendershot is an Olympic rower for the United States and competed in the 2012 Olympics. She is currently training for Rio 2016.

Even a 30-minute chunk of time for a phone call or coffee meeting means something else won’t get done. It could be a poem that never gets written, a chunk of code that doesn’t get debugged, a report that doesn’t get proofed, a client that doesn’t get called back until the next day, two miles that don’t

get run, or a brilliant idea that never occurs to you. *There is always a price.*

“The difference between successful people and very successful people is that very successful people say ‘no’ to almost everything.”—Warren Buffett

Beware of Distant Elephants

They say that in the distance, even giant elephants at first look small. Unfortunately, many small things turn into big things when they actually arrive.

Research Says...

People who routinely say “no” to requests for their time report higher levels of happiness and energy.

(Source: The Kruse Group, 2015)

A young woman, an undergraduate at Dickinson College, emailed me out of the blue one day and told me she was a fan of my leadership work. She said her school had a speaker series each year, and she asked if it was OK for her to suggest me.

Sure, I said. That was my first yes.

A month later, a Dickinson College administrator emailed to follow up with a specific date for me to come speak and to let me know there would be no fee. Would I consider it? My typical speaking fee is \$12,500 to \$22,500, but I love speaking to students and always try to schedule at least one pro bono speech each month to a nonprofit group.

I looked up the date on my calendar—three months down the road—and that date was free. In fact, my whole week was unscheduled. *Wow, the future was going to really be a lot less busy than the present!* I was looking forward to it. I accepted the invitation. That was my second yes.

As the date got closer, another student asked me if she could interview me for the college radio station. I would have to arrive a couple hours earlier than my event to record the interview. Sure, I said; I'd be honored. That was my third yes.

A week before the event, a professor emailed to ask if I wouldn't mind speaking to his economics class about business and ethics and engagement. His class was earlier in the day. I love speaking to students, I'd be there anyway—just now a little earlier in the day—so, of course, I gave my fourth yes.

As time ticked away and the pro bono event at the college got closer and closer, inevitably things came up. My daughter's school play got scheduled for the same day; I would have to miss it. I was asked to do a corporate keynote event on the same day—for my full fee; I had to turn it down. A TV news program in Australia wanted to do a live interview with me on the same day via satellite, but I was already booked.

Yes, it was a big bummer missing out on all those other things, especially my kid's play, but I don't regret my original decision or the string of yeses that followed.

But I share this story as an extreme example of how *we mistakenly think we'll be less busy in the future than we are in the present.*

It's far too easy to accept a lunch date when you look at your calendar three weeks from now and see that you have no meetings or other lunch plans that day. Sure, that day looks great to grab a casual lunch! And then that day comes, and it's filled with meetings and deadlines and family obligations.

You have to realize: whatever obligations and projects and tasks you have now, you'll also have in a month, six months, or a year. Unless you make a radical change in your life, your kids will continue to get sick, play sports, and require parent-teacher conferences; your boss will still be giving you projects; your car will still need oil changes and inspections; your friends will still be throwing parties.

Every Yes Is a No to Something Else

This is a lesson I even try to teach my kids: every yes is a no to something else. It's not that they should say no to everything; it's that they should think it through.

In Their Own Words...

If something is not a "hell, YEAH!" then it's a "no!"

–**James Altucher** is a bestselling author, active investor, and host of The James Altucher Show.

Multipliers realize that perfection is achieved not only when nothing more can be added, but when nothing more can be taken away. It is the permission to ignore. Because anything we can say no to today, creates more time tomorrow.

–**Rory Vaden** is the author of *Procrastinate On Purpose and Take the Stairs*.

True focus is saying no to the things YOU really want to do.

–**Nikhil Arora & Alejandro Velez**, co-founders of *Back to the Roots*.

My best tool is to keep front of mind this idea: Everything you say yes to means you are saying no to something else.

–**Melanie Benson** is the co-author of *Entrepreneur.com's Startup Guide to Starting an Information Marketing Business*.

My daughter had RSVP'd yes to a friend's birthday party. Then the pop singer Max Schneider announced a local concert date that fell right on the same date. What should she do? Oh the teen angst! She'd told her friend she'd be at the party, and she needed to honor that commitment.

My eleven-year-old son signed up to play travel soccer; he's one of two goalies on the team. After the season was underway, he was asked to play a part in a local play. He really wanted to do it, but the play performance would mean he would miss one or two soccer games. What to do? He made a commitment to his coach and fellow teammates, so he was going to play soccer.

Again, the lesson isn't to *always* say no. Just realize that every yes will be a no to something else when the time comes. Understanding that there is always an opportunity cost will make you hesitate and really be careful about what you are agreeing to put on your calendar.

Why It's Hard to Say No

Despite the fact that “every *yes* is a *no* to something else,” we find it so hard to just say no. There are many reasons:

- We're afraid to make people mad.
- We're afraid to hurt someone's feelings.
- We want to be liked.
- We don't want to be rude; we were raised to be polite.
- We underestimate how much time it will really take.
- We aren't clear on our own priorities.
- We feel good by being helpful.
- We like earning future return favors.

Indeed we are raised and socialized to want to help others in need; we value helping others.

But uncontrolled, saying yes to requests for time will quickly block out all the other things we value—including the very things that made us successful in the first place. We are self-imposing the pressure and the feelings of guilt when we say no.

Give yourself permission to say no without guilt. You should not care about what others think of you for declining their requests!

7 Easy Ways to Say No

First of all, know that “no” is enough. You don't owe it to anybody to have to say more than that.

But if you are still struggling with “just say no,” then try these more subtle responses. I often send a response email beginning with “Thanks for reaching out...” and continue with one of these messages:

1. "...but I'm on a deadline right now and am not taking any new meetings until I'm done." I use this approach often with strangers who cold-contact me. I don't specify what the deadline is—since they're strangers, they don't need to know my details and shouldn't expect me to share. And the word *deadline* has a magic to it, a power that most people can relate to.
2. "...Unfortunately my schedule is so packed at this time I can only take calls and meetings with paying clients. Thanks for understanding." I use this approach for people who are looking for free advice that will benefit them and their company tremendously. It's really incredible how often people who already have decent income and assets will ask for time and information that will make them a ton of money, but they don't think to hire someone for the answer. The approach above is a gentle nudge that if they really want to talk to me about their business problem, they can do it if they're willing to pay. They almost always disappear instead.
3. "...and I'm happy to connect, but there is no daylight on my calendar until 2:15 p.m. ET on [*pick a date five months in the future*]." This is what I usually say to someone who I don't know personally but who is vaguely connected in some way. Maybe they are a friend of someone who used to work for me from years ago. The intent of this approach is to not reject them outright, but to let them know I'm hustlin' and have a very busy calendar. This response sends the message that their issue had better be pretty important, and if they really want to meet with you, they'll take the offered time slot in the distant future. I've found that most of these people just respond and say, "Oh, no worries, you sound swamped. Let's just connect when you're less busy." And they go away.

4. "...and my next open slot for a phone call is 2:00 a.m.–2:15 a.m. ET on Thursday of next week. Let me know if that works for you." *Notice the time slot is a.m., not p.m.; that's on purpose.* I only use this line about once a year, because if the person calls my bluff, I'll actually have to stay up late or drag my butt out of bed to take the call. But I use this on people who are really, really persistent. If I know they're a persistent stranger just trying to sell me something, I can easily say no. But if a friend or business partner suggested they call me, I don't want to ignore them out of courtesy to my friend. But this approach puts a burden back on the requester. How badly do they want to talk to me? Are they really willing to do the call in the middle of the night? Usually they respond with, "Sure, next Thursday afternoon is great, but you had a typo and wrote a.m....that would sure be a crazy time!" I then write back, "No typo. I'm a 24/7 kind of guy, and that's my only open slot for the next several months. Do you want it?" I've never actually had a person in this situation ask for the call, which is really amazing. They are willing to impose on my time to try to get some life- or career-altering information, yet they won't take the call at two in the morning. And, if anyone ever says, "You bet, I'll call you then," I can always respond and say I found a way to move something around and that we can talk during normal business hours.
5. "...but I don't think I'm the best person; I'd like to refer you to..." This is an easy one. People often request your time because they think you know something that can help them or that you are a decision maker that can buy something. If you aren't, or if you've "delegated" that decision making power to someone on your team, use this approach. You can always qualify it by saying something like, "The fastest way to make progress on this is for you to talk directly to my colleague

Paulina. But don't worry; when you're talking to Paulina, you're talking to me. She's the ultimate decider here."

6. "...but I'm not able to take any more meetings or calls during normal business hours. But I often can catch up on emails during travel or at night. Would you like to communicate via email?" This is probably the response I use most often. I really do try to respond to every email I get from readers, email newsletter subscribers, referrals, etc. And email is way more efficient than live phone calls.
7. "...and as a rule, I only schedule 15 minutes for first calls. If you're interested, could you send over a draft agenda so I can see what we'll be covering and what desired outcome you are hoping for?" Again, if you don't want to just reject the person, this type of response is a good way to let them know you're very busy, so if they really want to talk to you, they'd better be willing to do some pre-work. I usually never hear from these people again.

In Their Own Words...

Saying no to friends: Think of the consequences and what the best decision is for you; don't try to please others. Think of yourself first. Be careful of who you surround yourself with; if they're your friend, no will not be an issue.

—Haley Silva is a straight-A student at Sierra High School.

How Does This Apply If You're A(n)...

Entrepreneur: Would "just saying no" help you to reject tangential meetings from outside parties, enabling you to stay focused on your current product road map?

Executive: Would "just saying no" help you to stay out of nice-to-have initiatives, enabling you to make progress on your quarterly objectives?

Freelancer: Would “just saying no” help to reduce your pro bono hours?

Student: Would “just saying no” help you to spend more time in the library and less time at the coffee shop?

Stay-at-Home Parent: Would “just saying no” help to minimize your “volunteering” and maximize parenting?

SECRET #9

Say no to everything that doesn't support your immediate goals.

Which meetings, calls, and projects will you say no to in the upcoming weeks?

*** * FREE BONUS * ***

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The Powerful Pareto Principle

Could a simple analysis of your workload make 80 percent of it disappear?

The Amazing Discovery in an Italian Garden

Vilfredo Federico Damaso Pareto was born in Italy in 1848. He would go on to become an important philosopher and economist. Legend has it that one day he noticed that 20 percent of the pea plants in his garden generated 80 percent of the healthy peapods. This observation caused him to think about uneven distribution. He thought about wealth and discovered that 80 percent of the land in Italy was owned by just 20 percent of the population. He investigated different industries and found that 80 percent of production typically came from just 20 percent of the companies.

80 percent of results will come from just 20 percent of the action.

This “universal truth” about the imbalance of inputs and outputs became known as the Pareto principle, or the 80/20 rule. While it doesn’t always come to be an exact 80/20 ratio, this imbalance is often seen in various business cases:

- 20 percent of the sales reps generate 80 percent of total sales.
- 20 percent of customers account for 80 percent of total profits.
- 20 percent of the most reported software bugs cause 80 percent of software crashes.
- 20 percent of patients account for 80 percent of healthcare spending (and 5 percent of patients account for a full 50 percent of all expenditures!)

On a more personal note, you might be able to relate to my unintentional 80/20 habits.

I own at least five amazing suits, but 80 percent of the time or more I grab my black, well-tailored, single-breasted Armani with a powder blue shirt. (Ladies, how many shoes do you own, and how often do you grab the same 20 percent?)

I have 15 rooms in my house, but I spend about 80 percent of my time in just my bedroom, family room, and office.

I'm not sure how many miles of roads are in the small town where I live, but I bet I only drive on 20 percent or less of them.

On my Samsung S5 smartphone, I have 48 different mobile apps pinned to the tiles, but 80 percent of the time I'm sure I'm only using about 8 of them.

When I go grocery shopping, I definitely spend the most time in the aisles that are around the edges of the store: produce, the fish market, dairy, breads—and generally skip the aisles in the middle of the store (except health and beauty).

As a massive introvert, I don't actually socialize too much, but you probably find that you spend 80 percent of your time with 20 percent of your friends and family members.

In Their Own Words...

I accept that I cannot do everything so I work only on things that are vitally important using the 80:20 rule.

—James Schramko is the founder of SuperFastBusiness.

The two primary productivity concepts I apply are the following...First, the 80/20 rule, which helps me to identify which tasks deliver the biggest rewards and thus I should focus on. Two, the "Theory of Constraints," which helps me to identify what the immediate constraint is that's holding me back from a desirable result.

—Yaro Starak is the author of the blog Profits Blueprint and founder of the Entrepreneurs-Journey.com blog.

So how can we apply Pareto's principle to gain more time in our lives?

80/20 Business

In business, you could literally analyze your customer base and decide to “fire” 80 percent of the least profitable customers. I certainly fired many clients who weren’t worth the trouble back in my day.

You could do the same with your sales force. Apply the 80/20 rule and fire the majority of your sales representatives who are actually producing the least. This will enable you to reward the remaining highly successful reps with more accounts or larger territories and give you more time to support the “winners” on your sales team.

You could look at all the products you are currently offering and, using 80/20 analysis, get rid of the majority of your products that provide the least profit. This could eliminate the majority of customer service issues, free up room in your warehouse, and simplify your value proposition.

If you’re running a software company, make sure you are identifying which bugs are causing 80 percent of the phone calls to your help center. Eliminate these first, and you’ll dramatically reduce your tech support costs.

You can even apply 80/20 to your marketing efforts. I once interviewed Seth Godin at a conference and asked him why he didn’t use Twitter. This was back when Twitter was all the rage and, given that Seth is viewed as a marketing guru, people were shocked he wasn’t engaged with the platform. He said, “I have nothing against Twitter. There are only so many hours a day and if I spend time on Twitter, I won’t be spending time on other things, like writing a daily blog post.”

In this age of social media, so many of us feel like we have to be on Twitter and Facebook and LinkedIn—my gosh, I even have a Pinterest page! But a simple 80/20 analysis would reveal that most of your engagement, most of your audience, probably comes from just one platform. You could let people know that’s where you’ll be, and then ignore the rest.

80/20 Yardwork

How much time and money do you spend on your yard each year? Maybe your current practice is to mow the lawn, edge the lawn, apply fertilizer or other chemicals, weed the flower beds, trim the bushes and trees, plant flowers, and sweep the sidewalk. If you don't do it yourself, think how much you spend on mowing, replacing mulch, buying lawn fertilizer, applying weed killer, or trimming trees.

The 80/20 rule would suggest that only 20 percent of yard maintenance activities account for about 80 percent of how your yard actually looks to the neighbors and others who are driving by your home. With that in mind, you might decide to mow and weed, but stop edging and planting seasonal flowers. (Unless yardwork is fun for you, of course!)

80/20 Reading and Studying

My favorite high school teacher gave me sound advice as I went off to college. She warned that the reading assignments would be unlike anything I had done before. A book a week for classes using fiction, and multiple chapters a week from each textbook.

She taught me that if you just read the first and last paragraph of each chapter as well as the first sentence of each paragraph in between, you'll understand 80 percent of the message of the book. I learned that it might not get you straight A's, but it can get you solid B's.

Today, I have three over-scheduled kids in school. As I help my teenage daughters study for high school tests, I now know to start by looking at the chapter summaries and chapter self-tests. Knowing what the textbook author thinks is most important, and then going back and finding the answers to those questions in the text itself, is much more efficient than reading the entire chapter from beginning to end.

What's in the Dalai Lama's Bag?

My favorite story about the Dalai Lama was from an article in *The Globe and Mail* in 2002. The Dalai Lama travels the world frequently, teaching people about Buddhism and the plight of the Tibetan people. A man without many possessions,

he always carries a small red bag wherever he goes. According to the reporter at one event, someone in the audience asked the Dalai Lama what was in his bag.

Immediately, he opened it and began pulling out objects for all to see. A chocolate bar, a case for his glasses, a toothbrush, Kleenex tissues, and then after a pause—a single candy, which he promptly unwrapped and popped into his mouth.

How much stuff do you carry with you when *you* travel? Is too much “stuff” taking away your time?

Most of my friends have second homes. Some are in New York, others at the Jersey shore, others have ski cabins in the Poconos. They are surprised that I don’t have a vacation home. What they don’t realize is that I’ve listened very carefully when they talk about their homes. Rarely do they talk about how much joy they are getting from them. But I definitely hear it when they tell me that they have to deal with the aftermath of a break-in, or that Hurricane Sandy put three feet of water in their first floor, or that they’ve rented it out and someone trashed the place.

A second home is just one example to show the truth that all objects come with a cost, like collectible knickknacks that need to be dusted every week. The bigger the house, the more rooms that need to be cleaned. Electronic gadgets need to be learned, set up, stored, Bluetooth-paired, and ultimately fixed! Pools need to be cleaned. Pets need to get walked, groomed, and taken to the vet. Boats put in and taken out of the water.

With three school-age kids, I think my suburban lifestyle is practical. But once the kids are all out of the house, I will be too! I envision getting rid of almost everything I own (I’ll pack up the sentimental stuff—there won’t be much—and put it in a climate-controlled storage facility) and just spend a year renting an amazing apartment in a different city each year until I get bored with that or die. New York, Barcelona, Amalfi, Sydney or Melbourne, Hong Kong, La Jolla or Napa, who knows where!

The lesson isn’t that all “things” are bad—I have some toys to drive and two cats. It’s just that all things require time, and

we should think twice before acquiring them.

While we may not want to limit our possessions to only that which fits into one small red bag, we can probably take inspiration from the Dalai Lama, who clearly doesn't need objects to feel happy.

The 80/20 Mindset

The important takeaway from this chapter on the Pareto principle is not to run around with a calculator and actually do the math to figure out 80 percent and 20 percent calculations in different areas of your life.

It's more important to have a mindset of identifying the few things and activities that will give you outsized returns. You want to:

- Look for shortcuts.
- Do the most important things exceptionally well, and the rest just "good enough" or not at all.
- Develop your skills to be exceptional in a few targeted areas; don't try to master everything.
- Realize that you can work less, stress less, and increase your happiness by figuring out the 20 percent of goals and activities that are most important to you.

How Does This Apply If You're A(n)...

Entrepreneur: Would an 80/20 mindset help you to stay focused on your strategic plan and spend less time chasing endless new opportunities?

Executive: Would an 80/20 mindset help you to maximize the return from your limited resources?

Freelancer: Would an 80/20 mindset help you to focus on and service your most important clients?

Student: Would an 80/20 mindset help you to identify the content that matters most on a test?

Stay-at-Home Parent: Would an 80/20 mindset help you to manage the household without losing your mind?

SECRET #10

Eighty percent of outcomes are generated by
twenty percent of activities.

What 20 percent of your time generates 80 percent of your value?

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The “3 Harvard Questions” That Save 8 Hours a Week

Can three simple questions save you eight hours a week?

The Slacker Who Won a “Best Coder” Award

In January of 2013, several news outlets reported on the remarkable story of Bob.

With Bob’s programming speed and code quality, his company named him “Best Coder in the Building” and gave him an excellent performance review. He was a model employee; in his mid-40s, Bob clocked in by nine each morning and sent his boss a daily summary of his productivity before he left at five.

But if we had been able to secretly peek over Bob’s shoulder all day—to discover how he spent his time—we would have seen something peculiar. On Bob’s typical day, he would read Reddit and watch YouTube videos from about 9:00 to 11:30, which is when he would head out to his 90-minute lunch. Back at 1:00 p.m., Bob would then spend the next three and a half hours on Ebay, Facebook, LinkedIn, and other social media sites. At 4:30, he would send a report to his boss and go home—without writing a single line of code. The next day would be the same.

How could this be? How could “Bob” be his company’s star programmer, yet goof off all day?

It turns out that Bob was very smart.

Instead of asking, “How can I do this?”

He asked, “How can this get done?”

The answer, in Bob’s case, was that he outsourced his task—actually his job—to a software development company in

Shenyang, China. Bob's company gave him approximately \$200,000 a year to do his work, and he in turn gave \$50,000 a year to a programmer in China to do it for him.

For the longest time, Bob's company marveled at his productivity and quality, while he surfed the Internet eight hours a day.

Eventually Bob's company noticed unusual server access from China, and thinking they were being hacked, they stumbled on Bob's brilliant scheme. They were not amused. Bob was fired.

Research Says...

People who actively look for things to delegate report higher levels of productivity, happiness and energy, and are less likely to feel "overworked and overwhelmed."

(Source: The Kruse Group, 2015)

If I had been the CEO, I would have doubled Bob's salary and made him the CTO. That way he could have outsourced all the development work and saved the company millions of dollars.

While Bob ultimately got fired for breaking company rules, we can learn a lot from his approach to getting things done.

In Their Own Words...

See your day from a higher perspective...Avoid leveraging your time for money, instead leverage your expertise and delegate the rest.

—Jeff Moore is president of two seafood companies and the founder of a global mastermind group called Thursday Night Boardroom.

Drop, Delegate, or Redesign

In September 2013, Professors Julian Birkinshaw and Jordan Cohen shared the results of their productivity experiment in the *Harvard Business Review*.

They found that 41 percent of knowledge workers' time is spent on discretionary activities that weren't personally satisfying and could also be done by others.

So why do people keep doing these activities?

The researchers suggest that often we feel important when we feel busy; we feel engaged and satisfied as we make progress against tasks, and while meetings are often boring, they also provide an opportunity to leave the desk and socialize a little bit.

Once workers were trained by Birkinshaw and Cohen to *slow down* and think about their activities in a new way, they achieved massive time gains.

In fact, on average, *the workers who were trained saved six hours of desk work and two hours of meeting time each week.*

So what's the secret to these massive time savings?

The researchers trained everyone to analyze their tasks to see if they could:

- **Drop:** What items can I drop? What can I stop doing entirely?
- **Delegate:** What items can I delegate to a subordinate? What can I outsource?
- **Redesign:** What do I need to continue doing, but do it in a new, time-efficient way?

To put this into practice, make a list of all the tasks and meetings you worked on during the previous week and follow these steps:

1. Ask, "**How valuable is this task to me or to the company?** What would happen if I just dropped it completely?"
2. Ask, "**Am I the only person who could do this task?** Who else in or outside the company could accomplish this?"
3. Ask, "**How can the same outcome be achieved but with a faster process?** How could this task

get completed if I only had half the time?”

Those three questions will give you the data you need to identify the tasks that are of low value and should be targeted to Drop, Delegate, Redesign.

In Their Own Words...

Leverage every dime you have to outsource and buy other people's time. That is the key. Organize your 168 hours, then BUY hours from others to grow.

—Shane & Jocelyn Sams built a high six-figure business selling digital products and started FlippedLifestyle.com to help other families “flip their lives” with online businesses.

Tony Robbins Was a Teen When He Hired an Assistant

I can remember being 25 years old and mowing my lawn on a hot Saturday in August. I was the CEO of a startup, working over 80 hours per week, barely getting any sleep, getting no exercise, and I had no social life, and yet there I was spending a couple hours mowing and edging my lawn.

Sweat dripping off my chin, face baking in the sun, straining up the grassy hill, pushing the mower through a cloud of dirt and grass pollen, all the time thinking about the slide deck I needed to create before Monday, the hundreds of emails I needed to respond to, not to mention painting a bedroom, doing the laundry, and going grocery shopping.

So why didn't I just hire some kid to mow my lawn for me? Because I had no money. I should say I *thought* I had no money.

I recently watched an interview with Tony Robbins. He tells a similar story of starting out—still just a teenager—and realizing that as broke as he was, he was going to hire help, initially for just two hours a day. He tells his story:

I think in the very beginning the hard thing is you think you can only do it yourself and then there's only so many hours

and you've got kids and family and friends and how do I do it all?

The answer is you hire someone. You trade with someone. You trade them for 2 hours. That's what I did in the beginning. Because I remember, I remember, I'll never forget, I was just really young in my career, very in the early days, and I was running to get to the dry cleaners so I could get my only two suits because if I didn't get them, you know, then the place closes and I can't get on the plane.

And I was running to the airport sweating like crazy, and I'm a sweater anyway. Sweating like this, trying to get in the door, and it was like, what is wrong with this picture?

I could be doing something that's so productive and I'm standing in line at the dry cleaning place. This is just nuts. And so I was really... I was like 17, 18, 19, I don't know what I was, and I said, "I'm gonna hire somebody." Two hours a day, that's what I need to start with. And then it was 4 hours.

And so my view is I don't do anything that someone else can do better, and I don't do anything that isn't the highest and best use of my time.

You need to start paying other people to do stuff for you even before you feel you are ready. What would it cost to hire the kid down the street to mow your lawn each week?

Are you a stay-at-home dad? What would it cost to hire an unemployed college grad to watch your kids for an hour each afternoon to let you have some alone time?

In Their Own Words...

Nothing will slow you down, take you off track, or keep you unproductive more than doing things which you both: do not like to do and are not good at.

Anything that falls into that category must be outsourced to someone else (ideally who both likes it and has competence) as soon as possible. The extent to which you continue on those types of tasks is what will hold you back from truly loving what you're doing and also being fulfilled.

–Andrea Waltz is the co-author of the bestselling book, Go for No!, and a professional speaker.

I outsource anything I can using fantastic tools like Amazon Prime for two-day shipping and Peapod for grocery delivery so I don't have to go to the store; FancyHands.com to book appointments, look up vendors, research products, etc.; Thumbtack for finding any household task that can be done; and ZocDoc for making doctor appointments. Being a mom of two little ones and running a multi-office agency requires all of the help I can get!

–Kim Walsh-Phillips is a leading direct response social media marketer, bestselling author, keynote speaker, and founder of IO Creative Group.

Venture Capitalist Suster on the Value of an Admin

Are you a startup CEO? What would it cost to hire a really good administrative assistant? Why spend money on an admin when you know how to use a computer and can do it yourself?

There are only two blogs that I read religiously, and venture capitalist Mark Suster writes one of them. In *Bothsides of the Table* (<http://www.bothsidesofthetable.com/>), Suster gives advice to startup entrepreneurs. In his article “The Controversial First Role to Hire After Your ‘A Round,’” Suster makes a compelling case for the value of an admin.

Your first hire after that first round of capital is an office manager/company-wide assistant.

“What? You’re joking, right?”

No.

While I’m passionate about being scrappy when you start and controlling your costs, I’m equally passionate about performance when you have a bit of cash. And I’ve seen way too many CEOs/founders get bogged down in minutiae because they were used to it from the scrappy phase. They’ve struggled to scale.

Think about it. Your single most valuable asset in the early days is your senior team and presumably nobody is more valuable than the founding team. And you’re bogged down

in expense claims, booking hotel rooms, scheduling meetings, dealing with a leaky toilet, processing payroll, ordering computers, etc.

If you don't *have* an admin, you *are* an admin.

Even if you can do all the administrative work yourself, why should you? The one hour a day you spend running to the post office, balancing the checkbook, or booking airline tickets would be better spent calling prospects, learning, or thinking strategically. Always try to spend as much time as possible using your unique strengths on your highest leverage activities. Running out to Staples to buy printer paper probably doesn't fall into that category.

In Their Own Words...

Focus on what you are great at and hire everyone else to do the rest.

—Lewis Howes is a bestselling author, entrepreneur, and former professional athlete. He is the host of The School of Greatness podcast.

Today You Can “Uber” Everything

Ever since the success of *The 4-Hour Workweek* by Tim Ferriss, using virtual assistants has been somewhat in vogue. Initially, using a virtual assistant, or VA, generally meant working with someone in India or the Philippines to screen your email, schedule appointments, and other general tasks. While some found these arrangements to be helpful, others found the language barriers and the lower quality of work to be unacceptable.

But since the early days of VAs, the concept has really grown and morphed into the idea that you can outsource almost anything, with very little prior planning.

Uber was really the company that popularized the concept of on-demand mobile service (ODMS). Remember being envious of the “rich and famous” with their chauffeurs? Well in the same time it would take you to say, “Home, James,” you can now tap your Uber app and have your personal chauffeur show up to take you to your destination.

Spend too much time grocery shopping? See if Instacart (www.instacart.com), Peapod (www.peapod.com), or Fresh Direct (www.freshdirect.com) operates in your area. For non-perishables, use Amazon.com Subscribe & Save (www.amazon.com/gp/subscribe-and-save/details/).

Need someone to do some Internet research, make social media updates, make reservations at a restaurant, or cancel your cable? Just visit FancyHands.com.

Have miscellaneous chores to complete? See if the folks on TaskRabbit (www.TaskRabbit.com) will hop over to clean your oven, build your Ikea furniture, or organize your closets.

And don't forget, for all your general freelance needs: www.fiverr.com, www.freelance.com, and www.upwork.com.

When *The 4-Hour Workweek* first came out, outsourcing was a novelty. Now, it's just assumed you can give the work to the best people, and nobody cares where they are located. With WiFi Internet access, Skype, email, and project management communication tools like Asana (www.asana.com) and Slack (www.slack.com), working with remote team members has become no big deal.

I live outside of Philadelphia and personally use "virtual" help for all kinds of things:

- Clarissa is one of my book cover designers; she lives in Singapore, and I have no idea what she looks like (we've only communicated via email).
- Balaji lives in India, and I've used his team to do research projects, data mining, and slide designs.
- Serena answers my Mailchimp email technical questions (when we first connected, she was spending time in Ireland, and now she's in Thailand).
- Camille is one of my book editors whom I found on www.Fiverr.com (her profile page says she lives in the United States, but I have no idea where).
- Matt and Chris are the two guys who handle my websites (I've never had a face-to-face project meeting with them).

In addition to the team of remote freelancers I routinely work with, locally I also outsource these items:

- I pay \$60 a week to a company to mow my lawn.
- I pay \$100 to a guy to plow my driveway when it snows.
- I pay \$150 every two weeks to a cleaning service to clean my house.
- I pay \$20 an hour to a woman to help me get my kids off to school each morning.
- I pay a bookkeeper to handle both my personal and business accounting needs; I never write a check myself.
- I hire plumbers, electricians, and painters to maintain my home.

But Mark Cuban Still Does His Own Laundry

So what shouldn't you outsource?

Notice that while I have someone who stops in a few mornings each week to help, I've never had a full-time nanny for my three kids. While I have good friends who have live-in nannies or daily full-time nannies, I just never felt comfortable with that myself. For me, I don't want a non-family member living in my house, and parenting is my first value, so I want to do it myself as much as I can. I'm fortunate in that I have a lot of schedule flexibility that enables this. *I'm not judging others who are making different choices*; I do it consciously, knowing that it is costing me potential income and career advancement.

I also do my own grocery shopping—almost every day or every other day actually. This makes *no sense* from a time optimization standpoint. But I actually like it. I like having the freshest fruits and vegetables and fish possible, and zipping quickly through the store is my way of going to the market each day. Since I work from home, it's a good excuse to get some fresh air and sunlight.

Billionaire Mark Cuban revealed on *Shark Tank* that he still washes his own laundry. I do, too. It would be easy for me to have someone stop in each week to do my laundry or to drop it at the dry cleaning place—it would be easy for you to do that too, and maybe you should. But I just find it grounding somehow to do my own laundry.

The bottom line is you should try to outsource everything you can unless:

1. You enjoy doing it and it's part of your rest and recharging process.
2. It's part of your values to continue doing the task.
3. It costs you more per hour to outsource it than you want to make yourself.

In Their Own Words...

Every year, audit your time and find a way to delegate at least 15% of what you're doing.

—Jay Baer is the founder of Convince & Convert, a keynote speaker, and author of Youtility.

How Does This Apply If You're A(n)...

Entrepreneur: Would being aggressive about outsourcing help you to spend more time using your unique abilities?

Executive: Would being aggressive about outsourcing enable you to reduce project costs?

Freelancer: Would being aggressive about outsourcing enable you to spend more time utilizing your true talents?

Student: Would being aggressive about outsourcing (your laundry perhaps?) help you to spend more time studying for the big exams?

Stay-at-Home Parent: Would being aggressive about outsourcing give you a few hours to exercise or recharge?

SECRET #11

Focus your time only on things that utilize your
unique strengths and passions.

What are you going to outsource starting next week?

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Why Twitter Co-Founder Jack Dorsey Themes His Days

What if one simple change to your calendar enabled you to have a quantum leap in your productivity?

Jack Dorsey's Productivity Secret

Jack Dorsey is the co-founder of Twitter and the founder and CEO of Square. For a while, Dorsey worked full time at both companies. Sixteen hours a day—eight hours at each. In a 2011 interview at Techonomy, Dorsey explained his secret to his productivity.

The only way to do this is to be very disciplined and very practiced. The way I found that works for me is I theme my days. On Monday, at both companies, I focus on management and running the company...we have our directional meeting at Square, we have our OpCom meeting at Twitter; I do all my management one-on-ones on that day. Tuesday is focused on product. Wednesday is focused on marketing and communications and growth. Thursday is focused on developers and partnerships. Friday is focused on the company and the culture and recruiting. Saturday I take off, I hike. Sunday is reflection, feedback, strategy, and getting ready for the week.

And there are interruptions all the time, but I can quickly deal with an interruption and know that it's Tuesday and I have product meetings, and I need to focus on product stuff. It also sets a good cadence for the rest of the company. We're always delivering; we're always showing where we were last week and where we're going to be the following week.

How John Lee Dumas Themes His Days

John Lee Dumas built a million-dollar business in a few short years on the success of his daily podcast, *EntrepreneurOnFire*. Dumas' colleague, Kate Erickson, wrote a 2014 year in review blog post in which she described the impact daily themes have had on their business.

Something that we also both found success with doing is creating themes for each day of the week. For example, John's podcast day is Tuesday: that's when he does all of his podcast interviews for EntrepreneurOnFire.

Another example: Wednesdays are our webinar days. This is when we schedule our Live Podcast Workshops, our Webinar Workshops, and our exclusive community webinars.

Having themes for our days makes it easier to plan ahead, and easier to stay on track. Having an entire day set aside for a theme creates a bigger space in which to accomplish things, and a smaller chance that you'll "just set it aside" until tomorrow.

Three Themes from Dan Sullivan

Renowned entrepreneur coach Dan Sullivan suggests that we theme every week around three different kinds of days:

Focus Days: "Game days" are to focus on our most important activities, typically revenue-producing activities. These are also the days when we should ideally be using our unique talents; do what you do best.

Buffer Days: These are days to catch up on emails and calls, hold internal meetings, delegate tasks, catch up on paperwork, and complete any training or educational activities that are related to work.

Free Days: These are days without any kind of work. These are days for vacation, fun, or perhaps charity. No work-related emails, calls, or thinking should be done on these days; it's a time to rejuvenate.

Designing My Ideal Week

I try to theme my days as well, but not quite to the point of Dorsey, Dumas, or Sullivan. Here's what my typical week looks like:

Monday: The first day of the week is my day for internal management meetings (similar to Dorsey). I meet one on one with each direct report as a way to review key developments from the previous week and to review activities and goals for the week ahead. I also end the day with a team meeting where everybody briefly shares what their week looks like so there is a contextual awareness within the company. To be honest, I don't like Mondays because I don't like meetings. But I love starting each week with a "huddle" that I know will make the next four days highly productive.

Tuesday through Thursday: The days in the middle of each week are my "focus" days. In my current business, these are the days that I spend writing new books, designing e-learning courses, or writing marketing material. Those items are the "output" that generate revenue and are definitely utilizing my unique strengths.

Friday: The end of my week is my "buffer" day that I use to process bills, catch up on email, or respond to readers.

An Office Hour Theme

In addition to my days-of-the-week themes, I also theme the last Friday of each month as my day to book lunch or coffee appointments.

I'm inundated with "can we grab a coffee" requests each week, and for those invitations I want to accept, I just give them the next open time slot on my last Friday of the month. The waiters at LaStalla in Newtown are always amused as I arrive at 11:00 a.m. and just sit at the same table as a string of guests come and go each hour. I pick up the bill at the end of the day, which usually includes three or four lunches (I only eat one) and about ten coffees.

Bestselling author Dave Kerpen similarly "themes" a block of time on a weekly basis for outside meetings. He explained to me, "While I take meetings with just about anyone who

wants to meet with me, I reserve just one hour a week for these ‘office hours.’”

Sandwich Vacation with Buffer Days

I used to hate vacations. They stressed me out.

The idea of vacation was fine, but then the day before vacation would be an insane scramble of trying to hand things off while doing a normal day’s work. The first few days of vacation would consist of me either dealing with the undone things via phone and email or worrying about those things if I was trying to “unplug.” The day back from vacation would make me nauseous, scrambling again to catch up on emails and calls while diving back into a normal day of meetings.

To gain a quantum leap in vacation quality, just schedule a buffer day before and after your vacation. Bookend your vacation with days that are time blocked for catching up. No pre-planned meetings, no project work, no lunch catch-ups. Just block out that time—especially the day back from vacation—to catch up on emails, phone calls, mail, and quick stand-up meetings with staff to get back up to speed.

Just knowing you have this time to hand off work in an organized fashion, and then time to catch up again, will help you to truly rest and relax while you’re away.

Want the secret to making this work? Tell your admin which day you’ll be returning to work, but tell him or her to leave “vacation” marked on your calendar for everyone else to see. That way you won’t get scheduled into meetings or have people pounce on you as soon as you walk in the door.

How Does This Apply If You’re A(n)...

Entrepreneur: Would it be helpful to theme product development and customer acquisition days?

Executive: Would it be helpful to time block internal meeting times, but also free thinking times?

Freelancer: Would it be helpful to theme one day a week just to deal with pesky things like finding clients and sending invoices?

Student: Would it help to theme one night a week as “party night” and another night for “study in the library time”?

Stay-at-Home Parent: Would it be helpful to theme Sunday afternoon as time to pre-cook a week’s worth of meals?

SECRET #12

Batch your work with recurring themes for different days of the week.

How much more productive would you be, how much less stress would you feel, if your days were organized to maximize your effectiveness?

*** * FREE BONUS * ***

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Don't Touch!

(Until You're Ready)

Can one small change in your habits gain you dozens of minutes each day and free up mental energy?

How Do You Sort Your Mail?

You can tell a lot about people by how they go through their daily mail. Here's how I used to do it...

After a long day at work, I come home, grab the mail from the box and walk back into my kitchen. Curious and procrastinating, I flip through the stack. Junk mail, electric bill, junk, mortgage statement, junk, junk, magazine, hand written card with no return address, junk, junk, car loan, junk, junk.

The small card certainly stands out, and I open it right away. It's an invitation for my son to go to a birthday party in a few weeks. I pull up the calendar on my iPhone. It looks like he'd be able to go. I'll have to double check there are no other plans.

I put the card down and open the electric bill. I've been blasting the air conditioning so much I wonder how big the bill is. Yikes! I decide to open the other bills to glance at when they're due.

I set the bills down and pick up BusinessWeek and flip through the pages, reading a couple headlines and thinking I'll have to remember to come back and read one of the articles.

Finally, I put the magazine down on the island and begin to cook dinner. Later that night, I'll return to the mail, sort through it, and throw out all the junk mail. I'll leave the magazine in the kitchen (cluttering my

environment) and toss the rest on my desk in the office. In the days ahead, I'll reopen the bills to pay them and, if I remember, reopen the invitation, glance at the calendar again, and send back an RSVP.

While this type of “processing” of mail might not seem like a big deal, it's often a sign of how we do everything: we come back to things *over and over again*.

When we process our email, we might respond to each “ding” by scanning who it's from and what the subject line is. We then decide whether or not to open it. If we open it and read it, we then decide to leave it in our inbox so we can respond to it later...when we'll read it all over again.

We might take off our dirty clothes and throw them on the floor in our bedroom. Later we pick them up and throw them in a pile in the closet. Once a week—or when we can't actually close the door to the closet any longer—we get a laundry basket and put the clothes in it and then take it to the washing machine. Later we'll come back and actually start a load of laundry.

‘Touch It Once’ Mentality

Highly successful people take immediate action on almost every item they encounter. They know that to be efficient, they want to expend the least possible amount of time and mental energy processing things. In short, they practice a “touch it once” mentality.

Here's how I now go through snail mail using the “touch it once” principle:

- I walk out to the mailbox and grab the mail.
- As I walk back up my driveway, I pick out all the junk mail.
- I toss the junk mail into the recycle bin in my garage before I even walk back into the house.
- I easily pick out the magazines and put them in my magazines-to-be-read stack on the coffee table.

- I take the remaining bills—that’s all there is left, no-body sends letters anymore—and set them on my bills-to-be-paid pile next to my computer.
- Because I’ve time blocked 30 minutes every Friday morning for paying bills, I don’t even bother opening those envelopes until that time.

I actually think the ‘touch it once’ rule is so important I recommend you immediately take action on something if it will take *five minutes or less* to complete. As long as it won’t interfere with a pre-scheduled task, you are generally better off taking immediate action than having to come back to it in the future.

In Their Own Words...

Whenever I have a small task that needs to be completed (that takes less than five minutes), I should complete it now, rather than putting it off. This ensures that I do not have a long list of tasks that I have to complete later at the end of the day.

—Nihar Suthar is a straight-A student at Cornell University.

‘Touch It Once’ for Email

Most people read each email item as soon as it appears, or they open their inbox, see a bunch of new messages, and immediately click each message to open it and read it.

Unless a reply requires only a couple of words, most people close the mail message to deal with later—when they’ll have to open it and read it all over again!

The better way is to process every email message immediately. Here’s how I actually actioned my email this morning, along with the internal debate that occurred in my mind.

11:00 a.m. My morning health rituals are complete, my kids are off to school, and I’ve finished two hours of

focused writing time. Time to open my email accounts... deep breath.

The first email is a Google alert that I've set up to monitor my own name. It shows that my previously scheduled blog post went live this morning. I hop over to my blog to make sure it's all good and notice a typo right in the title of the blog post. Damn, I'll have to fix that in a few minutes after I scan the rest of my emails.

No! Touch it once, my inner voice reminds me. I quickly open WordPress, fix the typo, and click Publish.

The next email is from a freelancer giving me his employer identification number (EIN) so my accountant can prepare a tax document. I'll have to send that along with a note to my accountant later.

No! Touch it once. I hit Forward, add a few lines, and off it goes to my accountant.

Next email is from my lawyer, and an invoice is attached. *What?! I wasn't expecting a bill*. Double-click the PDF. Yep, it's correct, I had forgotten about his work on my trademark question. *Ugh, I just finished paying bills yesterday*.

I can print the invoice and place it in my bills-to-be-paid pile for processing during my normal weekly bill-paying time block, or touch it once. *Do it now!* Fortunately my lawyer takes credit cards. I fill out the credit card information on his website and send it back—it took only three minutes.

Next email...I recently joined the Pennsylvania Society and sent them my dues. Somebody needs to know if it's a nonprofit or not. *How the heck do I know? Who can I pass this on to? Oh sheesh, let's just deal with it right now*. I open a new tab in my browser and go to their web page. Quickly scan their About page. No mention of 501(c)3 nonprofit status. Reply to email: Don't think so. Send. Done.

Next email...Someone asking about my speaking fee and availability. I forward it to my virtual admin. Don't even type anything in it; she'll know what to do.

After I either clear out all the emails or come to the end of my 30-minute time block, I just close my email completely and come back to it again late in the afternoon.

‘Touch It Once’ and Calendar It

A *very* powerful tactic is if you can't take immediate action on an email, just calendar it for future action. Remember, we want to use a calendar, not a to-do list.

For example, my sister Debbie just sent me an email. Instead of replying to it, I'd like to call her to have a more detailed live conversation. But I don't add it as a task at the bottom of a to-do list. And I don't leave it in my email inbox, where it might get buried or never actioned. Instead, I set up a time on my calendar to “Call Sister Debbie.”

I use Gmail and Google Calendar, so when an email message is open and I want to create a calendar appointment for it, I just:

1. Click the “More” button (drop-down menu) near the top center of the window.
2. Choose the “Create event” option from the drop-down menu.
3. A new tab opens up displaying a new event form in Google calendar; it defaults to the current day and time and puts the email subject line as the event title. The body of the email appears in the Description field.
4. Adjust the date and time as desired and click “Save.” Voila!

If you're using Microsoft Outlook as your email client, it's even easier. While your email is open, just click the

“Schedule” button, or you can even drag an email onto a calendar date on the right side of the screen.

For more information or to find screenshots of how to do this, just Google “how to create a calendar entry from email.”

‘Touch It Once’ to Declutter

A messy environment can be mentally taxing, increase the time it takes to find stuff, and eventually demand scheduled time to “clean the house.” A touch-it-once mentality can go a long way to keeping your environment tidy all the time.

I’m teaching my three kids to practice ‘touch it once.’ They used to take their dirty dishes and put them on the counter near the sink. I would eventually have to go to the sink again, pick them up again, and then place them in the dishwasher.

Now they know when they’re done with their meal to pick up their plate and glass, rinse them in the sink, and put them directly in the dishwasher.

Same with their laundry. No more taking their shoes or socks off and throwing them on the side of the couch to be forgotten. If they take their shoes off, they immediately take them to their room or put them by the door.

When it comes to laundry, I even put two laundry baskets in my walk-in closet. One is for dark colored clothes (cold water) and the other is for whites (hot water). Why pick up and sort all the dirty clothes when the sorting can be done when I throw it in the closet?

How Does This Apply If You’re A(n)...

If you’re an **entrepreneur** or **executive**, would “touch it once” help you to keep on top of your email inbox?

Freelancer: Would “touch it once” help to keep your administrative paperwork in order?

Student: Would “touch it once” help you to power through each subject’s assignment?

Stay-at-Home Parent: Would “touch it once” help to keep the house clean and all that paperwork your child’s school

sends home completed?

SECRET #13

If a task can be completed in less than five minutes, do it immediately.

How much time will you gain when you aren't returning over and over again to "touch" the same items? Touch it once, touch it once, touch it once.

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Change Your Morning, Change Your Life

Imagine if you could have a solid hour of daily “me time” that could drive higher levels of happiness, productivity, and creativity throughout the day.

It is far too easy for us to wake up, feel the pressure of our never-ending to-do list, and immediately begin to react. React to overnight email messages, react to social media, and react to the first item on our calendar.

Even if we had intended on having a healthy breakfast at home or jumping on the treadmill, when we go into reaction-mode it's easy to think, *I'll grab coffee on the road and work out tonight—better get into the office and get some of this stuff done.*

Highly successful people design an empowering and energizing morning routine and stick with it.

In Their Own Words...

I wake up fully rested, spend 30 minutes in meditation and then go to my workout area. While working out physically, I take advantage of the rich audio programs available so that I fill that 45 minutes with physical exertion combined with mental input and expansion. I never check the news or look at my iPhone first thing in the morning, no matter how important it may seem to know the latest news...I carefully protect that first hour of the day, making sure that all input is positive, clean, pure, creative and inspirational. Many of my most creative ideas have come from this protected time of the day, often when I am in a full sweat. By 9:00 AM I am invigorated, motivated and ready to face anything the day may bring.

–Dan Miller is the author of the New York Times best-selling 48 Days to the Work You Love, No More Dreaded Mondays, and Wisdom Meets Passion.

Get up 15 minutes earlier than everyone else in your house and get into the office 15 minutes before everyone else. You can solve any problem in your life if you devote 15 minutes of focused thinking to it first thing in the morning every day.

–Craig Ballantyne is the creator of Turbulence Training and is the editor of EarlyToRise.com.

My “Sacred 60” Morning Routine

In the introduction of this book, I shared a story from a time when I was young and dumb, overworked and out of control, and would leap from my bed to the shower to my car in under 20 minutes. That was when I sped right past a state trooper without realizing he was there, until he pulled me over.

Looking back, I can see that not only was I living dangerously, but that lifestyle was impairing my creativity, ability to think strategically, and overall productivity.

Well, no more buttered rolls and flying past cop cars for me! These days my mornings look something like this:

6:00–6:20 a.m.—Get up, feed the cats, turn on coffee pot, prep kids’ lunch or breakfast items while drinking coffee, hug kids out the door to school.

6:20–6:21 a.m.—Guzzle protein shake and water.

6:21–6:22 a.m.—A minute of gratitude.

6:22–6:27 a.m.—Concentrative meditation.

6:27–6:40 a.m.—Turn on podcast, do yoga stretches.

6:40–6:50 a.m.—Resistance training: one muscle group.

6:50–7:00 a.m.—Shower, dress.

7:00 a.m.—Begin work on MIT without interruptions.

I consider this to be a very minimal “hour of power.” During less busy times, I add 30–60 minutes of cardio while listening to an audio book or podcast.

It’s pretty amazing how different I feel since I’ve started this practice:

- I feel better as a parent knowing that I got a touch point of love with my kids.
- I feel full but not sluggish with the protein breakfast, and the water seems to wake me up.
- My “attitude of gratitude” increases and extends my happiness.
- I personally don’t notice any benefits from meditation, but I believe the scientific research behind it, and I’d probably get more from it if my practice were longer than five minutes.
- The simple yoga stretches have been a life changer; pushing 50 years old, I immediately feel pains and tightness throughout my body if I forget to stretch.
- Listening to audio books or podcasts while stretching or doing cardio means no matter what else happens later in the day, I feel good knowing I already had some “me” time for learning or entertainment.

The Morning Routines of Arnold Schwarzenegger, Tony Robbins, and Other Highly Successful People

Obviously, successful people don't all follow the exact same routine, but it is amazing how you can easily identify consistent themes.

- Most wake up early—6 a.m. or earlier.
- They hydrate by drinking *a lot* of water.
- They eat a healthy breakfast, although each has a different definition of healthy (e.g., fruit and oatmeal, green smoothie, protein, slow carb).
- They exercise.
- Many meditate, journal, or read.

In a video spot recorded for Tim Ferriss, **Arnold Schwarzenegger** shared his daily morning routine:

My morning routine is very simple. I get up every morning at 5:00 in the morning, and then I go downstairs to the kitchen, start reading the various different newspapers, and then go on my iPad, do all my e-mails and stuff like that...go upstairs to the gym and work out 45 minutes to an hour, do cardiovascular training...Then after that, have my breakfast. Usually, it's oatmeal, bananas and strawberries and some blueberries in there, I mix it all up, with some coffee, eat that, go take my shower, and then go to work.

In his audio program *The Ultimate Edge*, **Tony Robbins** shares his “hour of power.” He begins each morning with a series of breathing exercises, followed by ten minutes of contemplating everything he is grateful for and visualization of everything he wants in his life. He then spends 15–30 minutes doing some kind of exercise while repeating incantations. In a recent interview with Tim Ferriss, Robbins shared that he now practices cryotherapy each morning, too, standing in a chamber that drops to around -166 F° for a couple minutes.

Shawn Stevenson is a health and fitness expert, bestselling author, and host of the podcast *The Model Health Show*. In an interview for this book, Shawn shared his morning routine:

Energy is everything. We have a certain amount of willpower allotted to us every day, and we burn through it quickly if our energy is low. I like to do most of my creative work in the morning, so I make sure that I stack the conditions in my life to ensure that my energy is high when I get to my laptop. There are three things that are mandatory for me when I wake up.

First, I take what I call an “Inner Bath” by drinking about 30 ounces of high quality water. This helps to jumpstart your metabolism by flushing out metabolic waste products accumulated in your body while you were asleep. Whether you realize this consciously or not, when you wake up you are dehydrated. This will help to instantly balance your body out.

Second, I do a short session of exercise—20 minutes or less—like rebounding (using a mini-trampoline), going for a brisk walk, or doing Tabata (which only takes four minutes!) This is not done for the purpose of getting 6-pack abs (although it couldn’t hurt), it’s done for the purpose of releasing endorphins that make you feel good and stress hormones like cortisol and epinephrine that help you to focus (and research shows that secreting these hormones in the morning will actually help you to sleep better at night).

Third, I eat a lower carbohydrate, higher fat, moderate protein breakfast.

Business Insider ran a series where they asked highly successful people to reveal their morning routines.

- **Gary Vaynerchuk**, co-founder and CEO of VaynerMedia, gets up at 6 a.m., does a news and social media scan, and then works out with a trainer for 45 minutes. He calls family members on his drive into the office.

- Cartoonist **Scott Adams** practices the same morning routine every day, including weekends and holidays. He wakes up at 5 a.m., but he told Business Insider, “...if I wake up any time after 3:30 a.m., I call that close enough and pop out of bed with a hum and a bounce.” His morning meal is coffee and a protein bar.
- Entrepreneur and Shark Tank investor **Kevin O’Leary** wakes up at 5:45 a.m. and watches the news while riding an exercise bike for 45 minutes.
- FOCUS Brands president, **Kat Cole**, wakes at 5 a.m. and drinks 24 ounces of water while checking social media for about 20 minutes. She does 20 minutes of exercise and eats a high-protein snack.
- Author and professor **Cal Newport** rises at 6 a.m., drinks a glass of water, and then walks with his dog. While in the park, Newport stops and bangs out 25 pull-ups.

Hal Elrod’s 6-Step Morning Routine

Hal Elrod (www.halelrod.com) is a professional speaker, success coach, and author who credits his morning routine with turning his life around and establishing a solid foundation for his success. In fact, he believes so strongly in the power of morning rituals, he even wrote a book about it, called *The Miracle Morning*. In an interview, Elrod told me:

The premise of The Miracle Morning is to wake up and start each day with the discipline of dedicating time to personal development, so that you can become the person you need to be to create the most extraordinary life you can imagine, and do so faster than you may currently believe is possible. While most people focus on “doing” more to achieve more, The Miracle Morning is about focusing on “becoming” more so that you can start doing less, to achieve more.

Through Elrod’s research and own experiences, he developed a system he calls *Life S.A.V.E.R.S.*

- S is for Silence (quiet, gratitude, meditation, or prayer)
- A is for Affirmations (purpose, goals, priorities)
- V is for Visualization (of goals or ideal life)
- E is for Exercise
- R is for Reading (a self-improvement book)
- S is for Scribing (journaling)

Elrod makes a compelling case that no matter what level of success you already have, using your first minutes of each morning to invest in yourself will take you to an even higher level.

How Does This Apply If You're A(n)...

Entrepreneur: Would starting your morning with a “sacred 60” routine facilitate ideation and keep you grounded through the inevitable challenges of running a startup?

Executive: Would starting your morning with a “sacred 60” routine give you the physical and mental health to have a successful career over the long haul?

Freelancer: Would starting your morning with a “sacred 60” routine increase your hourly productivity throughout the day?

Student: Would starting your morning with a “sacred 60” routine help you to reduce stress during exam weeks?

Stay-at-Home Parent: Would starting your morning with a “sacred 60” routine increase your patience and happiness?

In Their Own Words...

The morning ritual that has become sacred to me is a 35-minute power walk first thing. Getting outside, breathing the fresh air, clearing my mind and resetting my focus all results in a powerful start to an amazing day.

—John Lee Dumas is the founder and host of EntrepreneurOnFire, which generates over \$250,000 a month in revenue. Dumas offers a free 15-day course on podcasting at FreePodcastCourse.com.

Power mornings: make everything you do for the first 120 minutes a ritual, including 30 minutes for light exercise, stretching and meditation.

—Jeff Moore is president of two seafood companies and the founder of a global mastermind group called Thursday Night Boardroom.

My best productivity tip is to wake up early. An early start to the day provides time for introspection and preparation. I generally try to get into the office by 6:30am.

—Chris Myers is the co-founder and CEO of BodeTree and a frequent contributor to the Wall Street Journal, Forbes, Entrepreneur Magazine, and MSNBC.

SECRET #14

Invest the first 60 minutes of each day in rituals that strengthen your mind, body, and spirit.

What time will you set your alarm clock, *for tomorrow morning*, so you'll have time for your morning ritual?

* * FREE BONUS * *

To download your “Change Your Morning, Change Your Life Worksheet” and other FREE bonuses, visit:

www.MasterYourMinutes.com

Energy Is Everything

Would you like the *real* secret to completing twelve hours of work in just an eight-hour day?

You Can't Get More Time, Only More Energy

What if the ultimate time management secret isn't about time at all? You can't "manage" time—no matter what you do, you will have the same 24 hours tomorrow that you had today. When people talk about "time management," what they really want is to get more stuff done with less stress. And the real secret behind this is that you need to maximize your energy.

I saved this secret for the end because I didn't think you'd even read it or care about it if I put it up front. But it's the most important secret of all.

Red Bull Nation

Have you ever been reading a book, but you keep reading the same paragraph over and over, and it's still not sinking in?

Have you ever been working on an important report, and you keep zoning off into space—wasting how many minutes doing nothing?

Do you get sleepy an hour or two after lunch? How productive are you then?

Have you ever actually fallen asleep at your desk? How about right in the middle of a meeting?

Have you ever been in a brainstorming session, but you just couldn't come up with any good ideas?

If you said yes to most of those questions, you can personally understand that our physical and mental energy varies—and that it has a direct effect on our productivity.

In Their Own Words...

Don't sacrifice your sleep. Sooner or later, it will catch up with you. You won't perform at your best, and you will get sick.

—Will Dean, an Olympic rower for Canada, competed in the London 2012 games. He is currently training for Rio 2016.

Did you know that consumers buy over four billion cans of Red Bull each year? The company behind 5-Hour Energy power shots reportedly makes more than \$600 million in revenue annually.

People everywhere are fatigued and looking for a quick fix. But while an energy drink might bring short-term alertness, it's no way to handle the chronic brain fatigue so many of us have come to view as normal.

How Monica Leonelle 6x'd Her Productivity

I am a writer.

I write slowly. This is a problem. Because...I am a writer.

About a year ago I tracked my productivity and learned that I write on average 500 words per hour. Most professional writers produce at least twice that amount.

So in order to make better progress on my next book—this book actually—my natural inclination was to “time manage” my writing. I could make a list of all the things I needed to write. I could prioritize them and make sure I was spending time writing this book each day. I minimized distractions and said no more often. I tried to “find” more hours in each day, each week, and each month. I even outsourced some research, like the time management quotes you'll find at the end of this book.

And all of that helped to a degree.

But then I noticed that writing came easily around eight in the morning. Kids off to school, I'm feeling fresh, and my coffee is kicking in. I checked, and my average words per hour

in the morning was about 750–1,000. But then I checked my productivity in the afternoon—getting a little tired and already thinking about the nightly activities—I discovered that my word count was about 250 per hour. Yes, my overall average was 500 words, but the same chunk of time, 60 minutes, produced dramatically different results *based on how I felt* in the moment.

In Their Own Words...

I have to know when I'm at my best for my most important work (morning, for writing fiction), when I tend to slack off (after meetings or podcasts), and when I can get by with relatively mindless work (afternoons). It's not about getting maximal amounts done; it's about ideally matching my capacities vs. my occasional need to screw around with what needs to be done at what time.

–**Johnny B. Truant** is a co-host of the top-rated Self-Publishing Podcast, co-author of *Write. Publish. Repeat: The No-Luck-Required Guide to Self-Publishing Success*, and the author of well over 2.5 million words of popular fiction.

In *Write Better Faster*, author Monica Leonelle shares how she went from being a 600-word-per-hour writer to a 3,500-word-per-hour writer. She learned that:

- When she repeated cycles of a 25-minute writing sprint followed by a 5-minute break, she achieved a 50 percent improvement in productivity. With these short recharging breaks, Leonelle was able to maintain a near state of flow for longer periods of time throughout the day.
- Her ailing wrists and fingers caused her to rethink her tools. She switched from keyboard typing to dictation and gained an additional 33 percent in word count.
- Once freed from the keyboard, Leonelle gained a final 25 percent improvement in word count when she began to dictate her novels while walking outside.

Leonelle didn't have more hours to give, so she figured out how to increase her *energy* instead, and her productivity gains were the same as if she had “found” six times more hours!

In Their Own Words...

It is important to schedule time for yourself, to rest, or to refocus.

–Katie Uhlaender is an Olympic skeleton racer for the United States and competed in the Olympics in 2006, 2010, and 2014.

Get your blood pumping for at least a minute or two every day. Quick workouts give a huge boost to energy and feed the brain with the oxygen you need to take over the world.

–Abel James is a bestselling author, musician, and host of the #1-rated health podcast Fat-Burning Man.

Don't sacrifice sleep for productivity. Many young entrepreneurs believe they can function on little sleep while they build their business. But lack of sleep (and, more importantly, lack of brain rewiring from adequate rest) can cause you to lose your edge and sharpness.

–Mark Sisson is the author of the best-selling book The Primal Blueprint and owner of Primal Nutrition, Inc.

The Most Productive People Take More Breaks

Tony Schwartz, founder of The Energy Project, teaches that human beings are designed to “pulse” between expending energy and renewing energy. His research shows that humans naturally move from full focus and energy to physiological fatigue every 90 minutes. Our body sends us signals to rest and renew, but we override them with coffee, energy drinks, and sugar or just by tapping our own reserves until they're depleted.

Schwartz suggests that we need to purposely take short breaks every 90 minutes throughout the day to drink water, walk, or to eat healthy snacks. His mantra is, “Pulse and pause.”

The idea of pulsing energy is behind the increasingly popular Pomodoro Technique developed by Francesco Cirillo (and used by Leonelle, as mentioned earlier in this chapter).

With the Pomodoro method, you set a timer for 25 minutes, work on a single task with your full focus, then take a 5-minute break to get up, move around, maybe drink some water. Then repeat the cycle.

The Draugiem Group installed software that tracked the time and productivity of all their employees. They discovered that their top ten percent most productive employees didn't actually work any more hours than anybody else. In fact, they took more breaks. On average, this high-productivity group worked for 52 minutes and then took a 17-minute long break.

In the examples above, we see recommendations to sprint for 25 minutes, 52 minutes, or 90 minutes, all followed by breaks. The important point isn't the exact length of the sprint or the break, it's to figure out what "pulse and pause" cycle works best for you. Our cognitive capacity declines throughout the day; you must build in frequent mental breaks to recharge and maintain productivity.

In Their Own Words...

Work in short bursts of productive work, instead of long, unproductive sessions (in which 80% of the time is spent on Facebook). Strategies like the Pomodoro Technique...reduce distractions and increase productivity.

—John Ramos is a straight-A student at the University of Coimbra in Portugal and is a writer at TheStudentPower.com.

Set a timer for everything you do. When you have a deadline you are more productive. I use the Pomodoro technique...

—Ian Cleary is founder of Razorsocial, an award-winning marketing technology blog.

I believe that I can get any task completed (even hated ones) in 25 minutes... open tomato-timer.com (it's a free website), hit start on a tomato, and then dive into whatever task I find myself procrastinating on.

—Christie Mims is the founder of the Forbes Top 100 Website for Careers, The Revolutionary Club.

Energy Starts with Health

The biggest way to increase your overall energy levels is of course to take care of your health. You already know this, but keys to productivity include:

- Getting enough sleep
- Minimizing alcohol

- Minimizing caffeine, especially late in the day
- Eating more whole foods and fewer processed foods
- Maintaining a healthy weight
- Drinking a lot of water
- Exercising daily (a 20-minute power walk counts!)

In Their Own Words...

For me, it's a daily workout during my lunch hour that keeps me sane. On most days, by 1:00 p.m. I have already put in about seven hours of work. At that time, it's a no-brainer that I need to recharge and refresh so that I can handle the second half of my day with the same focus and energy as I did the first half.

—Mohammed Dewji is the CEO of Tanzania-based MeTL Group. Forbes has named Dewji the youngest billionaire in Africa.

Make intense exercise a daily habit. The more fit I feel, the clearer my head is, the better decisions I make, and the more success I seem to attract.

—J.T. O'Donnell is the CEO of CareerHMO & Careerealism. Her work has been cited in the Wall Street Journal, USA Today, New York Times, The Boston Globe, and others.

How Does This Apply If You're A(n)...

Entrepreneur: Could increasing energy and alertness (enabling you to achieve more in the same amount of time) help you to get more balance in your life?

Executive: Would increasing energy and alertness (enabling you to do more in the same amount of time) help you to get home for dinner with your family?

Freelancer: Would increasing energy and alertness help you to be more productive during sleepy afternoons?

Student: Would increasing energy and alertness (enabling you to do more in the same amount of time) reduce the number of your all-night cramming sessions?

Stay-at-Home Parent: Would increasing energy and alertness give you more patience with family members?

SECRET #15

Productivity is about energy and focus, not time.

How will you increase your energy tomorrow?

*** * FREE BONUS * ***

To download your FREE bonuses, visit:

www.MasterYourMinutes.com

The E-3C System: Putting It All Together

How can you condense the 15 secrets of time and productivity into an easy-to-implement system?

In Their Own Words...

I stay productive by developing and maintaining what I call a personal “operating system,” which is a set of processes, tools and checkpoints that define how I get work done every day. The specifics of an operating system differ from person to person, but the important thing is that you have one.

—Corbett Barr is co-founder and CEO of Fizzle, a community and training platform for entrepreneurs.

Remember, there is no one system that universally works for everyone; you don’t need to incorporate all 15 secrets to see improvements in productivity. The most important thing is to learn from the habits shared by highly successful people and adopt them in a way that works for you and your situation.

In order to help you to take immediate action, I’ve simplified the findings from all of the research into a simple system that I call **E-3C**. **The E stands for Energy, and the three C’s are Capture, Calendar, and Concentrate.**

Energy

The first step—the most important part of my E-3C system—is “E” for Energy.

You can’t make more time, but you *can* increase your productivity. Increasing your energy and focus is the most important secret to achieving 10x productivity in the same amount of time.

Highly successful people get enough sleep.

Highly successful people eat energizing foods and exercise consistently.

Highly successful people maintain morning rituals—like meditating, journaling, hydrating, practicing yoga—that establish a foundation of energy, clarity, and alertness for the entire day.

Highly successful people pulse and pause throughout the day to maintain peak performance.

Capture

The first “C” in my E-3C system stands for Capture.

You must “capture” everything and anything into a notebook instead of trying to keep things in your head. In a best-case scenario, trying to remember to-dos, to-calls, and to-buys leads to a higher cognitive load and unnecessary stress—worse, it can lead to incomplete tasks.

Highly successful people keep a **notebook** with them at all times and write down everything they want to remember. In addition to capturing to-do items, they also record notes from calls and meetings, new ideas, lessons learned, favorite quotes, and other things that might need to be referenced in the future.

Think of your notebook as your external brain. The more you put into it, the less filled your biological brain will be!

I believe paper-based notebooks (like Moleskine or similar designs) work best; you can always scan your written notes into Evernote later—or even better, have your admin or virtual assistant do it for you!

Additionally, this practice improves your effectiveness, as you no longer forget important things to do, can hold other people accountable, and can learn from your accumulated written experiences.

If you are writing things down that you need “to do,” remember: as quickly as possible, you will want to schedule it as an appointment on your...

Calendar

The second “C” in my E-3C system stands for **Calendar**.

What is implied with this step is ***don’t use a to-do list!*** If you want “to do” something, immediately schedule it on your calendar.

Highly successful people have clearly identified values which lead to top priorities and their Most Important Task (MIT). You must time block MIT time on your calendar. Time for other activities that support your top values (e.g., health, relationships, giving back) should also get blocked on your calendar on a recurring basis.

Highly successful people theme days on their calendar, too. At work, Monday might be the day for one-on-one meetings or for a weekly team huddle. Wednesday might be themed as “no meetings” or “afternoon office hours.” At home, Sundays might be the day for grocery shopping, laundry, and cooking a full week’s worth of healthy meals in advance.

Highly successful people protect their calendar, knowing and feeling the reality that nothing is more important than time. They say no to anything and everyone who does not align with their priorities and are especially wary of “distant elephants.” They do something only if they aren’t able to drop it, delegate it, or redesign it. They spend time on the 20 percent of things that contribute 80 percent of the value—and they drop the rest.

Concentrate

The third “C” in my 3C system stands for Concentrate.

Highly successful people proactively work from their calendar; they don’t react to stimuli like incoming email, social media messages, or “got a minute” meetings.

Highly successful people don’t multitask; they concentrate on one task at a time.

Highly successful people concentrate on their MIT and other priorities during times of peak energy, typically in the morning.

Highly successful people pulse and pause to maintain concentration and productivity throughout the day. Most take 5-minute breaks every 30 to 60 minutes.

In Their Own Words...

Do one thing at once. Stop multitasking!

—Mike Cannon-Brookes is the co-founder of Atlassian, an Australian software company.

The basic principle of time management is as follows: do one thing, and one thing only until it is finished, then move on. This means put your phone away so texting, Snapchat, Twitter, and Instagram aren't distracting you while doing homework.

—Elizabeth Poblete is a straight-A student who attends Xavier College Preparatory.

Your mobile device? Turn off ALL notifications. Only look when you have time or when you have scheduled time to deal with it. Granted, I have a unique tone for my wife, but that's about it. Don't let technology control you... you control your technology.

—Mitch Joel is president of Mirum, a global digital marketing agency. He is the author of Six Pixels of Separation and CTRL ALT Delete.

The Time Is Always Now

I don't collect art. But when I accidentally stumbled on a mixed-media painting by artist Peter Tunney, I had to buy it at any cost. Its simple message: the time is always now.

Be mindful.

Live with intention.

Remember, there are only 1,440 minutes in a day.

Want More Training on the E-3C System?

*** * FREE ONLINE TRAINING * ***

I personally recorded a series of video training modules that you can access FREE as a reader of this book. Just visit the link below to access the training and other bonus material:

www.MasterYourMinutes.com

20 More Time & Productivity Hacks

The 15 secrets shared above are the principles that are most likely to get you massive gains in productivity. Below are even more tips and tricks you can use to save time.

1. **Always cook more than one meal at a time.** There is a lot of inefficient time in cooking. The planning, shopping, prep work, cooking, cleaning. If I cook dinner, which is often, since I enjoy cooking, I'll make sure I get two or three different meals out of it. I personally don't mind eating the same healthy dinner three nights in a row—I mainly eat for health during the week, not pleasure.
2. **Off-load your memory with your camera phone.** I have a horrible memory, but I've learned to off-load short-term memory items to my phone. Some of the things I might take pictures of: my hotel room number, where I parked my car, the label from a good bottle of wine, a book cover that a friend shows me, a whiteboard filled with great notes, or the valet parking ticket. It's an easy way to relieve stress and save a few minutes of wandering around looking for your room or car.
3. **Mute your phone and shut off all notifications.** Working distraction free has already been a theme throughout this book, but it is absolutely crazy to let your computer, phone, or other devices “shout” at you with notifications. My phone is on silent at all times, unless my kids are out at night and I want to make sure I can respond in an emergency. There is no need to be notified every time

someone DMs you on Twitter, PMs you on Facebook, or emails you.

4. **Drink a healthy protein shake for breakfast.** Right now, you are probably skipping breakfast to save time, or you are stopping at a Starbucks or Dunkin Donuts to grab coffee and a donut. Both are bad ideas. Remember it's about productivity, not time, and drinking a protein shake gives you energy and alertness all morning, boosting your metabolism so you'll actually burn more calories than if you skip breakfast. And as fast as your dash into a donut shop is, making a shake is faster than parking, walking in, waiting in line, waiting for your coffee, and walking back out.
5. **Never watch live TV.** Why? Because of the commercials. Just DVR every show you want to watch so you can skip through the commercials. Unless it's a real-time sporting event or the Bachelor is giving his final rose, do you really need to watch a TV show the moment it's broadcast?
6. **Don't watch TV at all!** David Meerman Scott is a marketing & sales strategist, keynote speaker, and bestselling author of 10 books including *The New Rules of Marketing & PR* and *Newsjacking*. In an interview for this book he told me:

According to Nielsen, the average American spends 158 hours each month watching television! That's 1,896 hours per year. Damn. That would be enough time to write an awesome book or start a company. You want a six-pack? Exercise instead of watch TV. Eliminate television and you gain nearly two thousand hours a year. Imagine what YOU could do!

7. **Use your drive time wisely.** Think about how many hours a year you spend driving in the car. Commute times, driving to clients, long trips to your parents' house. Even if you just drive 30 minutes each way to work, that is over 200 hours a year, or almost 10 days of time. We often

reflexively just think of this as dead time on our calendar and crank up our favorite music and tune out the world. Instead, think of phone calls you need to make—whether work related or to friends and family members. Consider listening to podcasts (which can cover the daily news) or “how to” programs or even learning a foreign language. Of course you can use podcast apps like Stitcher (www.Stitcher.com) to easily find great programs and listen to them at 2x the speed to save even more time!

8. **Never call people without setting an appointment ahead of time (unless it's social, of course).** How often do you call unannounced and get someone's voicemail? “Hey Jane, just wanted to catch up to hear how the sales meeting went; call me back.” And then Jane calls you, and you're busy so she gets your voicemail, “Hey, it's Jane, just returning your call. Call me back.” And on and on, like a voicemail ping pong game. Instead, send a calendar invite or email that just says, “Jane, let's connect on phone so I can get debriefed on sales meeting. Is tomorrow at 11:00 a.m. ET good? If not, suggest a few openings on your day.” Notice “a few” so you don't end up with email ping pong trying to find time on each other's calendars.
9. **Avoid busy times out in the real world if at all possible.** This secret will save many minutes a week and many hours in the year. It's as simple as shifting when you do things you have to do. Instead of shopping for groceries on busy Saturday morning, do it late Friday night or early Sunday morning instead. Don't schedule trips to clients close to rush hour drive times. Don't go into the bank during lunch hours.
10. **Use dual monitors.** Adding a second monitor to your computer setup is one of the easiest ways to gain massive efficiency for your computer tasks. It completely eliminates that need to toggle

between two different windows. I actually work with one monitor on one computer and two monitors on another computer, so technically I have three monitors going at the same time. But even with just two, you can then easily type in your word processor while reviewing research material on the Internet, preview code in one window while debugging in the other, or if you aren't on a focus sprint, yes you can monitor email traffic or view your calendar in one window while being constructive in the other.

11. **Have a stop doing list.** The great business thinker Jim Collins has often said that your “stop doing” list is just as important, if not more important, than your to-do list. In his 2003 article (http://www.jimcollins.com/article_topics/articles/best-new-years.html), he talks about how great companies practice this, and he himself uses New Year's resolution time to work on his stop doing list. Simplicity and minimalism can free the mind, free your schedule, and enable you to do great work.
12. **Remind people of the “end time.”** There was a time when I reported to the CEO of a large company and had assumed major new responsibilities. I quickly started drowning. My CEO's assistant offered to follow me around to help. At the end of two weeks, she said, “One thing that you need to do is really commit to the end time. Don't let people keep you longer than they were scheduled for.” Great advice. Ever since, I start every meeting, and especially every phone call, with, “Before we get started, I see we are scheduled for 30 minutes, and I do have a hard stop 3:00...” This way everyone knows in advance that it won't be a casual, leisurely meeting that just runs its own course. This tip is especially critical if you schedule calls for only 10 or 15 minutes.

13. **Hang out with productive people.** Seems silly, but so powerful. If your best friends at work are the ones taking 90-minute lunches all the time, you're likely to do the same. If your social circle routinely does happy hour and discusses what happened on reality TV the night before, you're likely to continue doing the same. Consider upgrading your work friends and your other friends. If for some reason you can't find productive time ninjas around you, hang out with them online. I've joined Facebook groups for entrepreneurs, writers, runners, and on and on. It's a great way to "hang" with people who are motivating each other, sharing their productivity tips, and keeping each other on the path to success.
14. **Tell people around you to leave you alone.** As the *Wall Street Journal* reported in their September 11, 2013, edition, the biggest distraction to work isn't email or instant messenger—it's face-to-face interruptions. If you work from home, make it clear to your family that work is work, and they can't interrupt you. If you're in the office, consider hanging a "Do Not Disturb" or "Back at [time]" sign on your door or running yellow caution tape across your cube entrance. And if you're the boss, consider setting aside a couple hours of day throughout the office for quiet time.
15. **Buy birthday cards by the dozen.** Do you go out and buy a card every time a friend or family member's birthday comes up? Or do you rush out to buy a condolence card each time you need one? The next time just go out and buy 10–20 cards—whatever a year's worth is—and a roll of stamps and keep them in your desk drawer so they're ready to go. Think of how many 15-minute trips to the store you will save in a given year.
16. **Pay bills electronically.** Do you pay bills every week or two the old fashioned way, with checks

and stamps? Big time waster. Just sign up for automatic bill pay—using a credit card whenever possible so you can earn points. You do need to leave a little extra money in your checking account to make sure you never run short, but it's worth the slight cash inefficiency to save all that time.

17. Never answer a call from an unknown number.

If they're not in your contact list, it's highly unlikely the call is from a friend, family member, or big client. The odds are high it's a sales call or a friend of a friend who was given your number. And even if the call is from someone you know, it's always best to have call time scheduled on your calendar.

18. Get a business coach, mentor, or mastermind group.

This may sound unusual as time management advice, but connecting with someone who has already walked the path you're on can save you a lot of time (not to mention money and frustration).

19. Release your content through multiple channels.

Joe Pulizzi, author of *Epic Content Marketing*, offers this advice, "Plan your content creation in advance. Most people think in content tactics, like publishing a blog or a Facebook post. It's best to think in stories, and how many ways you can tell that story—an article, a blog, a book, a webinar, multiple social media posts, an ebook, a podcast and more. The time savings are immense if you only plan in advance."

20. Know that done is better than perfect.

Software developers will often say, "Shipped is better than perfect." And the release of software version 1.0 is quickly followed by version 1.1, 1.2, and on and on to fix the bugs inevitably contained in the initial release. As a writer it's too easy to keep working on my book...new material, new ideas, better ways of phrasing things. But published

imperfectly is of more value to the world than never published at all.

In Their Own Words...

I don't add time to activities. Hell, I wear a different watch each day and I don't even take the time to set them. I get as much done as I can as quickly as I can, waste no time on the little things and if I mess up I will go back and clean it up.

*—**Grant Cardone** is a New York Times bestselling author, sales expert and founder of four companies.*

Time Secrets of 7 Billionaires

“Billionaire.” Just say the word and you capture people’s attention. Seven billion people on the planet, and only 1,645 billionaires (according to *Forbes*).

Do *self-made* billionaires work differently than the rest of us? Do you think they know something about time and productivity that helped them to *become* a billionaire?



I reached out to 28 billionaires, and to my surprise, seven of them responded, albeit with brief messages. This is the same response rate—one in four—that I got from contacting 800 “regular old” millionaires and startup CEOs. Mark Cuban actually responded to my email only 61 minutes after I sent it. (Yes, I counted.)

Although this cohort is small in number, it does seem remarkable that three of the seven billionaires’ advice relates to meetings. Whether it’s keep your mornings clear of them, ban them from one day each week, or “never do meetings unless someone is writing a check” (Cuban) these highly successful people are mindful of the scourge of meetings.

Other advice tailored for entrepreneurs included a warning against multitasking, the need for self-care and not getting distracted by things that are critical to your success.

The time and productivity advice in their own words appears below.

NATHAN BLECHARCZYK is the co-founder of Airbnb. In an interview for this book Nathan referred me to his advice that originally appeared on Lifehacker.com:

I try to fill my calendar in reverse, from the end-of-day to earlier; I try to reserve the morning for doing “real work.” I find I can focus more in the morning whereas it’s harder to get focused after having been bombarded by meetings, so I try to save meetings for later in the day.

MIKE CANNON-BROOKES is the co-founder of Atlassian, an Australian enterprise software company, with over 35,000 global customers. His productivity advice:

Do one thing at once. Stop multitasking!

MARK CUBAN is the owner of the Dallas Mavericks, Magnolia Pictures, Landmark Theatres, chairman of AXS TV and appears on the TV-show Shark Tank. His productivity advice submitted for this book:

Never do meetings unless someone is writing a check.

MOHAMMED DEWJI is the CEO of Tanzania-based MeTL Group. *Forbes* has called him the youngest billionaire in Africa. In an interview for this book, Mohammed provided this productivity advice:

Making time for yourself is essential to maintaining mental fitness and it goes without saying that mental fitness is inextricably linked to your success. Based on personal experience, I have found that maintaining optimum energy levels and focus becomes increasingly challenging as one embarks on new endeavors and climbs the ranks.

Particularly when your day consists of switching gears between sifting through hundreds of emails and attending one meet after another, it's only natural for your eyes to get tired and your brain to slow down as the day progresses.

For me, it's a daily workout during my lunch hour that keeps me sane. On most days, by 1:00 p.m. I have already put in about seven hours of work. At that time, it's a no brainer that I need to recharge and refresh so that I can handle the second half of my day with the same focus and energy as I did the first half. Every person has a different way of staying invigorated and recharging his or her batteries. It doesn't matter what it is, you just have to identify it and make time for it. I would strongly encourage new entrepreneurs to heed this advice because a fresh mind holds the key to their success.

ANDREW MASON is the co-founder of Detour and former co-founder and CEO of Groupon. In an interview for this book, Andrew provided this productivity advice:

Rather than give a specific piece of advice (I have tons but none of it is rocket science), I'll just say that actually being disciplined about adopting these habits is, in my experience, a huge differentiator of successful people.

I often meet people who seem smarter than me yet are less capable because they don't have the self-discipline and/or self-confidence to introspect on their ability to do what they think they're going to do and find ways to iteratively improve. Amazingly, I think it's as simple as that. It's kind of a sore spot for me because I can't understand why more people don't take it seriously.

If I was building a character in a business video game and I had ten character points to distribute I'd put 3 of them into intelligence and 7 of them into self-discipline.

DUSTIN MOSKOVITZ is co-founder of the team productivity app Asana (www.Asana.com) and co-founded Facebook. In an interview for this book, Dustin provided this productivity advice:

Pick one day a week that you and your team can focus on getting individual work done without any interruptions like meetings. At Asana, we have No Meeting Wednesdays established to encourage flow and productivity across the company.

MARK PINCUS is the co-founder and CEO of Zynga. In an interview for this book, Mark provided this productivity advice

If you want to build great products, devote more than 50 percent of your work hours to product. Don't accept speaking opportunities if you can't justify them as benefitting your users or your company.

Nobody would argue that stellar time management is the key to becoming a billionaire, but the wisdom of those who've quickly climbed to the very peak of business success certainly can accelerate our own progress.

Time Secrets of 13 Olympic Athletes

How do Olympic athletes maintain their focus, discipline and energy? How do the unsponsored athletes juggle their “day job” with their training and family obligations?



Perhaps more than any other group, Olympic athletes are truly working against a ticking clock. Four years in between Olympic Games. Each day that passes takes the athletes closer and closer to their big moment. It’s a moment when winning a medal or not can literally come down to fractions of a second.

Similar to the other highly successful people I interviewed, Olympic athletes stressed the importance of scheduling everything on the calendar and having clear priorities.

What was unique to this group was how often they brought up the importance of sleep and the need to rejuvenate. Maximizing energy, not just time, is paramount to athletes.

Gymnast Shannon Miller mentioned, “Grabbing a power nap.” Olympic rower, Will Dean, said, “To be at your best, you need some down time. Don’t feel bad about napping.” Katie Uhlanender, a skeleton racer, advised, “It is important to also

schedule time for yourself, to rest, or to refocus.” And cyclist, Chris Carmichael, believes “Rest is perhaps the most overlooked and undervalued aspect of time management.”

The advice given by all the Olympic athletes I interviewed is below.

SARA HENDERSHOT, an Olympic rower for the United States, competed in the 2012 Olympics. She is currently training for Rio 2016. Her advice:

My philosophy is that when I have the energy and the focus to make decisions like what I want my next day to look like, that is when I have to make those decisions. I will basically plot out what I know a day needs to look like, and how I'm going to work through my to-do list and how much time I'm going to allow myself to spend on each one of these tasks so that when I actually am in that moment getting it done, there are far less decisions to be made.

I use this Moleskine notebook that I'll just carry around with me. I make training notes in it. I make work notes in it. I have a whole bookshelf full of old ones at home, because I'll go back and refer to old things in it all the time.

I don't actually use a calendar; it will be a page in my notebook that I will write...so when I get home at 7:30am, I need to use 7:30 to 8:00 to write this email. Then from 8:00 to 8:15 I need to update this document. That's the kind of plotting that I'll do.

Part of being an Olympic athlete is just that there are a lot of things that I have to miss, and moments or events that I have to skip. I've almost just gotten to the point where I'm used to having to say “No” to things. It's just getting good at knowing your limits and not trying to overstretch those limits because when I do, that's the times that I get injured or I get sick.

SHANNON MILLER, a member of the 1992 and 1996 United States Olympic women's gymnastics team, won a

combined seven Olympic medals. She is the most decorated gymnast in American history. Her advice:

During training, I balanced family time, chores, schoolwork, Olympic training, appearances, and other obligations by outlining a very specific schedule. I was forced to prioritize. There were certain things that had to be done at very specific times, like training 7-8am and 3:30-8:30pm. School was 8am-2:30pm. Those times did not waiver. Then I built in everything else around those times giving weight to the most critical to achieving my goal. Most importantly, WRITE IT DOWN. To this day, I keep a schedule that is almost minute by minute. When you do this, you find that there are often pockets of time that you aren't maximizing, for example doing homework on planes and buses. Grabbing a power nap to facilitate recovery instead of wasting an hour online. Focus on those things that bring you further to your goal each and every day. Every moment counts!

WILL DEAN, an Olympic Rower for Canada, competed in the London 2012 Olympics. He is currently training for Rio 2016. His advice:

Get one of those big blue calendars. Planning your life on your phone is fine, but it doesn't give you the same perspective.

Don't feel bad about saying no to people if you're too busy. People will always want your time, and while many things might seem small, they can add up quickly. You have to prioritize your sport and your health, only add to that if it doesn't compromise those two things.

Realize that good time management doesn't mean filling your day with non-stop productivity. To be at your best, you need some down time. Don't feel bad about napping, watching some TV, or going for a walk.

Don't sacrifice your sleep. Sooner or later, it will catch up with you. You won't perform at your best, and you will get sick.

BRIANA SCURRY won two gold medals as the starting goalkeeper for the United States women's soccer team in 1996 and 2004. Her advice:

Focus is absolutely essential to achieving anything worthwhile. At the highest levels of achievement whether it be athletic, academic, or business one must have white hot, obsessiveness and the belief that no matter what, the objective will be achieved. All great achievement in our society was realized in this essence.

About 6 months before an Olympics, I would relate all the decisions I made to the ultimate vision of winning gold. The simple question I would ask several times a day was "Will this activity help me perform better and therefore help us win gold"

This question guided me in the right direction. Even if the activity was taking the day off or stepping back for a bit to get better perspective, being mindful of that vision helped me choose the best course of action in order to achieve the goal. It became clear to me the right decision to make and in turn provided sharper focus and made it easier to be disciplined

ROY-ALLAN BURCH, an Olympic swimmer for Bermuda, competed in the 2008 and 2012 games. He is currently training for Rio 2016. His advice:

A strong discipline is required to reach the pinnacle of our sport. Each day is dedicated toward a vigorous amount of training and when not training, it's important to maximize recovery for the next workout...Having a detailed schedule to follow makes maximizing each day easier. Rather than thinking about what needs to happen in an allotted time, one can just execute the training or recovery that needs to take place. As there are thousands of athletes around the world training very hard, time maximization becomes the main race. The question of who can get in the best work for themselves each day becomes a major factor to the success of each individual athlete.

KATIE UHLAENDER, an Olympic skeleton racer for the United States, competed in the Olympics in 2006, 2010 and 2014. Her advice:

One of the most important parts to managing your time well is having an agenda, meaning you have a focus each day and a goal each week. When you are an athlete and constantly training and competing, rest is incredibly important so that you are able to be at your very best physically and mentally. It is important to also schedule time for yourself, to rest, or to refocus.

Also, when you are in a competitive sport you have to be able to adapt and overcome the obstacles you face. At the end of the day it's how well you accomplish the process as a whole, not the long term goal, and how adaptable you are to change because processes evolves and is never perfect. The key to discipline is striving for perfection but understanding perfect isn't attainable. To strive for it means you're willing to learn and overcome challenges; therefore creating solutions. It's a day-by-day process and if you walk in the light and focus on each step, you can see the imprint your footstep makes.

ANDREW WEIBRECHT, an Olympic skier for the United States, won a bronze medal in 2010, and the silver medal in the 2014 Olympics. His advice:

To me it has more to do with sacrifice and taking advantage of opportunity when opportunity is presented than management in a sense. The sport that I do is so all consuming in terms of travel and commitment that when I am training and competing that is all I focus on, and when I am off sport I am totally detached. It is more about productive compartmentalizing and making the most of the moment whether that is time off/rest or sport.

ERIN HAMLIN, an Olympic luger for the United States, competed in the 2006 and 2010 Olympics, and won a bronze medal in 2014. Her advice:

When it comes to training, I guess I have just always prioritized it so it was easy to make time for. It has also allowed me to put other things off because training is more important at the time.

CHRIS CARMICHAEL, a cyclist for the United States, competed in the 1984 Olympics. His advice:

Rest is perhaps the most overlooked and undervalued aspect of time management. In training we have to teach athletes to focus on prioritizing quality over quantity, and to achieve higher training quality an athlete has to be properly rested and recovered between hard efforts. Rest, therefore, becomes part of training rather than the absence of training.

TOBY JENKINS, a water polo player for Australia, competed in the 2004 Olympics. Today he is CEO of Bluewire Media, a web strategy and digital marketing firm. His advice:

Find someone whose work you trust and admire and who has already done specifically what you want to do. Ask them for help and then filter their advice for your own situation. It's not about saving an hour or there. It's about saving you potentially years to get to goal.

I had some great water polo coaches throughout my career. Each had strengths and weaknesses. My realization though, was that if I had a specific challenge, then I needed a specific answer.

When I wanted to put on muscle, I didn't speak to my water polo coach. I spoke to my strength coach, a discus and shot put guy who had put on more weight, faster than anyone else I knew.

When I was nervous before games, I'd speak to my captain who'd played hundreds of internationals and learn from his pre-game routines.

When I wanted to improve my swimming speed and endurance, I went to a swimming coach who was coaching some of Australia's fastest swimmers at the time.

It all seems pretty obvious but being specific about the challenge you face and then finding the specific person best in a position to help you accelerated my learning enormously. It would be nearly impossible to quantify how many hours this saved me over my career as an athlete, student and now in business.

JULIE MCDONALD, a long-distance freestyle swimmer for Australia, won a bronze medal at the 1988 Olympics. Her advice:

For me, it's about scheduling my time. If I don't schedule my time I get distracted and am not productive. So I allocate time for exercise, charity, work and fun! That way I stay organised.

SCOTT DANBERG has appeared in five Paralympics representing America in track and field, swimming and powerlifting. He is a Fitness Director at the Pritikin Longevity Center. His advice:

As a 5-time Paralympian, a way I have found successful to balance sport training and "life" is to envision my training demands and the multiple responsibilities and obligations of "life" and place it all on an imaginary shelf. Mind you, it's a long shelf with multiple, moveable, dividers that I can compartmentalize and prioritize tasks and change their distribution over time. Tasks such as work and school have fixed dividers of time as these are responsibilities that have known hours and days and need to be met for one's livelihood and future. Other tasks, such as family and leisure pursuits, have flexible dividers of time that although occupy a "somewhat" fixed area on the shelf are flexible in the hours and days or blocks of time in which they occur. Likewise, training for sport also has dividers that are "somewhat" fixed but most also remain flexible, most importantly, to balance against family and leisure pursuits. As much as one may believe they need to "live and breathe" their sport, life balance, specifically interests outside of the sport itself, is as important a quality for athletic success as the sport training itself.

Once the “shelf” is initially organized it doesn’t stay that way for long as the priority and time demands of sport training increase as the competitive season and competition nears. The fixed areas on the shelf generally stay the same, so it’s the flexible areas on the shelf that change. Unfortunately, an athlete has to cut into time for family and/or leisure pursuits in order to train to be competitive. It’s the unfortunate life of an athlete who, at times, spends less time with family and leisure, but the family who is supportive of this, in return, greatly aids in the success of the athlete. The athlete is willing to sacrifice family and leisure time to stay focused on training as it is the passion and drive to be athletically successful that justifies the compromise.

VINCE POSCENTE, a speed skier for Canada, competed in the 1992 Olympics. Today he is CEO of Big Goals Fast Institute, and the *New York Times* bestselling author of *The Age of Speed*. His advice:

Start every day listing off your five MITs (Most Important Things) and get those done first.

The biggest time waster, especially in a competitive landscape is to try to do it all. The heroes of sport are the ones who spend extra time in the gym or the batting cage or at the rink. But they can be more efficient. What got me to the Olympics was doing what the competition was not willing to do. These weren’t necessarily big things. Examples include: read books on aerodynamics, learn how skis were made, interview a PhD in the politics of sport, use visualization and imagery over two hours per day with bio feedback, sensory deprivation float tanks, hypnosis programs, meditation and read a cutting-edge book on mental training every three weeks.

Although you might not be training for the 2016 Rio games, you are definitely in competition as you fight to achieve your goals. How will these time and productivity tips get you closer to the finish line?

Time Secrets of 29 Straight-A Students

What does it take to maintain straight A's at MIT or Harvard?

What does it take to be a straight-A student in high school, while juggling varsity sports and numerous activities?



The students I interviewed gave a wide range of advice and I'm reminded in my own home that there is no one way to achieve productivity and success as a student. My two teenage daughters are both straight-A students, yet they have very different study habits. One listens to music while studying, the other doesn't. One checks social media as her "reward" for getting a piece of homework done, while the other leaves her phone in a different room to avoid the temptation.

What was most unique in this group of high achievers was how often they talked about social media. Almost everyone mentioned the siren call of Snapchat, Instagram or Facebook, and many suggested specific apps as a way to manage those urges (e.g., SelfControl, StayFocused).

In addition to the familiar advice about using a calendar and being clear on priorities, straight-A students also know how to say no. From having no social life, or limiting friends

to study groups, these suggestions—while seemingly extreme—might be the price to pay for excelling at the highest levels in academics. The full advice from the students I interviewed appears below.

ELIZABETH POBLETE attends Xavier College Preparatory in Phoenix, AZ. She will be attending the University of Arkansas as an Honors Fellow in the School of Engineering. Her advice:

The basic principle of time management is as follows: do one thing, and one thing only until it is finished, then move on. This means, put your phone away so texting, Snapchat, Twitter, and Instagram aren't distracting you while doing homework and therefore adding to the time spent doing homework.

The most important guideline to time management, especially with homework, is a simple question: "What do I need to complete tonight so when I get to class tomorrow, I'm not kicking myself for not completing an assignment?"

Secondly, and almost equally important, "What can I do now so I won't have to do it on my most busy day, when I have work, practice, volunteering, etc?" Understanding your schedule is essential for time management because there might be days in which there are six hours to do homework after school, and some days when there might only be one or two.

Finally, make a schedule. It doesn't need to be written down or set in stone, but it is important to know that on Mondays, for example, you will get home at a certain time, eat, then do homework for a certain amount of time, then have dinner and relax for the rest of the night.

CAITLIN HALE earned her associate degree from Camden County College in 2009 with a perfect 4.0 grade-point average

and is now in her third year of medical school at Rowan University School of Osteopathic Medicine. Her advice:

Staying focused on schoolwork can be a pretty daunting task, especially with all of the social media apps pinging in the background. I use an app called SelfControl, which lets me set the amount of time and specifically which apps I want to avoid—including Facebook and Instagram.

It sounds old school, but what I found to be the most effective way to manage my time was to buy an agenda with a big calendar. I handwrite what topics I need to cover and how long I need to be studying that topic each night. So when I get home from class, I set my SelfControl app for the amount of time I allotted and get to work.

Something I find just as important to staying focused is scheduling in some “me time.” I make sure that every night I dedicate at least one hour to myself. Whether that is just watching a television show or going to the gym, it is a key factor in decompressing each day. This was especially important when it came time to study for my first medical licensing board exam. I would have been burnt out within the first few weeks of study boot camp if I hadn’t taken the time each day to go for a walk outside or hit the gym. I think this balance is what allows students to succeed in all aspects of their lives.

ERIK FOGG is an MIT graduate who earned in only four years a Bachelor’s degree, Master’s degree, and 2 minors. He is also the author of the bestseller, *How to Crush College*. His advice:

Start by saving semesters before saving minutes. Clever students—especially those looking for double-majors, minors, etc.—will find that many classes will count towards multiple requirements. Finding and planning for these classes means dramatically reducing the total number of classes needed for the degree you want.

Stop working in groups. Seriously; they either waste time or give you the answers so you lose the opportunity to learn. You may in time find one or two study-buddies that will keep you accountable for being on task, and these are great.

Give yourself play rewards. Time management is mostly about staying focused—when we're playing a game we like, we're not tempted to be distracted. Knowing that we have a reward coming up, like video games, a show, or social time, is not only motivating, but it gives us a clear light at the end of the tunnel that keeps us from the malaise of feeling like we're trapped in work.

Lean on Wikipedia. If you're trying to learn concepts rather than memorize a certain part of a textbook, Wikipedia is usually a much clearer, faster way of getting 90% of the way there. Textbooks do a lousy job and there's a lot of research that says you just go cross-eyed and lose focus when you're buried in them.

My favorite app is StayFocused. The best way to beat the temptations of social media is to just block yourself from them, and not have to exert valuable, limited willpower. I allow myself 15 minutes/day total for Reddit, Facebook, Twitter, news, using this.

AMANDA KRUSE attends Council Rock High School South in Holland, Pennsylvania. Her advice:

I make my own day-by-day calendar in a notebook and write down when everything is due. I made my own system...I circle any tests I have the next day, so I'll know to study for them the night before, I put an X over anything I don't have to worry about but I was just writing it down as a reminder, I highlight the things I already did, and I box things that aren't homework but that I need to remember later, like bringing money in for a special event.

When it comes to social media, I give myself goals, like if I do a certain number of math problems, I'll allow myself five minutes of Instagram. So it's an easy and nice break.

ALEXANDRA LADOVE is a straight A student at the Grauer School in Encinitas, California. She is also one of the nation's leading junior equestrians competing in the national equitation medal finals. In the fall, Alexandra will attend Auburn. Her advice:

I set long and short term goals, and I make sure that I have enough time to realize these. For me, I had to give up going out at night. I spend my time studying, riding, training and competing. I love it; it's what I want to do. That isn't to say that it is always fun, or that I don't sometimes wish I could put it on the back burner and just go out with friends.

I recommend making sure to plan your day ahead of time, think about what needs to get done, and then do it. Leave plenty of time before you go to bed to make sure you accomplish what you need. One strategy that really helps is having a set time to start doing your schoolwork and to set an alarm to make sure you actually start then. Staying in a routine and trying to stick to a consistent schedule are key.

NIHAR SUTHAR is currently an undergraduate student at Cornell University in Ithaca, NY. Nihar's advice:

Prioritize! I always prioritize the most important tasks that I have to get done for the day. The first on the list for me is always schoolwork, then writing (I write books), any athletic practices, and then hanging out with friends. I find that if you prioritize, you will almost always be able to get all your work done and have extra time to spend with friends as well.

Another tip I learned is that whenever I have a small task that needs to be completed (that takes less than 5 minutes), I should complete it now, rather than putting it off. This ensures that I do not have a long list of tasks that I have to complete later at the end of the day.

NATALIE KRUSE attends Council Rock High School South in Holland, Pennsylvania. Her advice:

I have a homework log, which is a daily calendar, and for each class I write down when the homework is due. Even if it's due at the end of the week, I'll still write it down so if I have extra time at night I can start early. I generally write down when I have a test two to three days ahead of time so I remember to spread out the studying over a few days, to reduce the time and stress spent the night before.

When it comes to reducing distractions, I don't listen to music or watch television while I'm doing my homework. I find that this helps me push through my homework at a much quicker pace. For social media, I'll spend time on my phone when I first get home, but then I'll put it down and won't pick it up until my homework is done, or I'll pick it up between subjects as a little reward—but I don't give myself more than a ten minute break, because it will feel like you have a lot more homework than you do if you take multiple breaks.

I try to start my homework pretty early after I come home so I can be done by nine or ten at night. After that I start to get tired and lazy and work at a much slower pace.

JOHN RAMOS is a medical student at the University of Coimbra in Portugal, and is a writer at TheStudentPower.com. His advice:

Set realistic small goals. I call them daily quotas, a term that got some attention on Quora. By daily quota I mean a small goal that seems insignificant, but when repeated day after day gets daunting tasks done. For example, 20 words in a foreign language a day (using a flashcard system, for instance) means 3000 words after 5 months. That's almost complete fluency.

Likewise, 10 math problems a day, every day, mean 300 problems done by the end of a month. It works because it's a

small time investment that compounds.

Work in short bursts of productive work, instead of long, unproductive sessions (in which 80% of the time is spent on Facebook). Strategies like the Pomodoro Technique suggest working in periods of 25-30 minutes, taking a small break and then resuming for another 25-30 minute session. It reduces distractions and increases productivity.

Enforce self-discipline with the help of browser extensions like StayFocusd (blocks social media and other time-wasters during certain periods of the day) and RescueTime (holds yourself accountable by measuring exactly how much time you spend working or wasting time on your computer).

HALEY SILVA is a senior at Sierra High School in Manteca, CA. She recently received a scholarship to the University of the Pacific in Stockton. Her advice:

Tips for staying focused: Have a goal, a positive mind set, and no doubt in overcoming any obstacles (like activities or people) that may cross your path.

Time management: Have a daily/monthly planner and make a to-do list to remember what your priorities are, and limit distractions.

Saying no to friends: Think of the consequences and what the best decision is for you; don't try to please others, think of yourself first. Be careful of who you surround yourself with; if they're your friend, no will not be an issue, and neither will negative peer pressure.

How to avoid the lure of social media: If you feel the necessity to have social media, be aware and cautious of who you contact and who contacts you, as well as what you say and display. It is meant for interacting with friends, which is why social media is not a necessity; you can easily contact your friends via text or with a phone call instead.

JOSHUA EICKMEIER is an online hybrid MBA student at Carnegie Mellon University's Tepper School of Business. His advice:

You need to be a realist: it's not possible to give 100% effort on every assignment, exceed expectations at work, spend time with family, and keep up with Game of Thrones. If you try, you'll just stress yourself out.

You need to set your priorities early on and stick to them. I suggest that you maintain time with family and friends, but be quick to cut low-value activities like video games or TV shows. When you have to make more difficult choices, look at things from a long-term perspective. Don't waste time feeling guilty about your choices – think of them as effective compromises that will lead to your long-term success.

I also suggest structuring your schedule to avoid these conflicts whenever possible. For example, doing schoolwork in the morning is a great way to keep evenings free for time with family or coworkers, and making weekend plans in advance keeps you motivated to get work done during the week.

CORAIMA MEDELLIN is a junior at the University of Pennsylvania who graduated from Camden County College in 2014 as a member of Phi Theta Kappa International Honor Society, the top honor society for community college students. Her advice:

I try to stay out of my dorm room because I tend to lie on my bed, get on Facebook, Instagram, Snapchat, etc. So I go to the quietest place on Penn's campus, Fisher Fine Arts Library, and study there. The quiet helps, but I think seeing others around me working on assignments motivates me to do the same. Sure, I go on Facebook, but the amount of time I spend on it is significantly reduced. I think it has to do with the fact that people pass by and I'm afraid of being judged going to a library and doing something that I could do somewhere else!

When it comes to reducing my social media usage, I try to restrict myself, especially when I'm getting ready for an exam or writing a paper. I want to stress the word 'try' because it's easier said than done. So, I bribe myself by saying something along the lines of, 'If you read this entire chapter, you can take a half-hour break and use Facebook during that time.'

Managing my time was something that I struggled with a lot when I first started at Penn, so I visited the Weingarten Center on campus to get some help with time management. It's been suggested that for every hour of class lecture you attend, you should study for two to three hours. So when I spoke to a counselor at Weingarten, I was given a weekly schedule that I put my work schedule and my class schedule in and then wrote the times that I planned to study for each class. I found that it works when I have an exam or a huge paper coming up to keep me motivated and focused.

RANA ELMAKADEM will graduate with an associate degree from Camden County College as the student commencement speaker (valedictorian) this May and is the New Jersey State president of Phi Theta Kappa International Honor Society. Her advice:

I recommend a large 'month view' calendar. I use both paper and electronic versions (on my phone and laptop), and I enter all assignment due dates from my syllabi at the beginning of the semester. But I enter them as due three to four days before the actual due date. I also recommend entering your work schedule and any other obligations to help you visualize everything you need to do and when you can allocate your time.

Setting incremental reminders of upcoming due dates and when different parts of your project or assignment should be done helps to keep you on track and minimize procrastinating.

When studying, depending on the subject, I break up my time with one 15-to-30-minute break for every 90 minutes to two hours of studying. During my breaks, I leave my study area and walk around, grab a snack and usually just check social media for five minutes. Doing something fun that takes your mind off studying helps you stay refreshed and refocus when your break is over.

I have a Post-it Note app on my laptop where I put deadlines or my to-do list. I like it because I'm on my laptop a lot, and I have this constant reminder of what I need to get done. It always feels good when I delete the notes that I completed and declutter my screen.

We're all stuck to our phones 24/7, so visit your app store and try out different time-management and study/homework apps to see which works best for you. I stuck with MyHomework app for some time, but found that placing everything on a large visual calendar worked best for me.

Regarding friends: If you know you have to get something done, then get it done. Saying 'no' to your friends is actually very simple in practice. Just say, 'No, I have an assignment to get done.' But do set aside some time to hang out with your friends and do something fun or relaxing. It could be as simple as having lunch or going to the movies. You still need a work/play balance in your life. It doesn't have to be frequent, but making plans gives you something fun to look forward to and keeps everyone focused at the tasks at hand.

VICTORIA SHOCKLEY was a straight-A, honors student at Wakefield High School and recently graduated summa cum laude from NC State University in only three years. Her advice:

Combine multiple tasks together. Sometimes, there literally aren't enough hours in the day to do everything. Find an opportunity to combine several things at once - maybe you do homework or study while on the bus, or you listen to an audiobook for class while cleaning your room. You have to

do all four things eventually, but this way you can maximize time that you might otherwise have spent being idle (such as a bus ride). That way, you cross two things off the list at once!

Learn to say no. I know it can be hard to turn down social events or extracurriculars, but it's important to know your limits so you don't overload yourself. If you know you have a busy weekend with friends coming up, try to limit your social calendar during the week so you can get the next week's homework/reading done early (if it's available in advance). While it may be disappointing to stay in on the weeknights, you'll have a stress-free, school-free weekend to look forward to. If you're working while in school, see if you can take on fewer hours during busy weeks, like midterms and finals.

Stay organized!! I can't emphasize enough how staying organized helps people manage their time. Prioritize your tasks by what's the most important / due first, and don't just have a long-term To-Do list - create a small one each day to give yourself a concrete idea of what needs to get done. Maintain a clean workspace, which eliminates constantly having to sift through papers and binders looking for your work. Take notes in a planner, whether on your phone or hard copy (I use both!). It's especially helpful to write down important dates, like tests and paper due dates, as soon as you get the syllabus. Also, for very important reminders that you absolutely cannot miss, I'd suggest the Reminders app on the iPhone so you can immediately be notified even if you haven't yet checked your hard copy planner.

Limit your time on social media until AFTER your work is finished. This is a big one - it's so easy to get distracted scrolling through our Facebook newsfeeds or checking out photos on Instagram. We can start chatting with a friend or surfing through Twitter and before we know it, half the night is gone. Not only that, but if you're trying to write a paper and stopping every five minutes to check a notification, that paper is going to take so much longer to write...and the longer it takes and the later it gets, the more sleepy you become. In between classes or lunch time are great

opportunities to check your profiles, but otherwise wait to log in until after your homework/studying and other responsibilities are complete!

AKRAM ALASHARI, MD was the top student in medical school and today is a trauma surgeon and surgical intensivist at the University of Florida. Akram is also the author of, *The Power of Peak State*. His advice:

First, remember that there are two forms of resources: internal and external. Too much focus is placed on external resources, such as computers, the internet, other people, etc. Oftentimes, the importance of inner resources is overlooked. This entails mental strength, courage, perseverance, grit, etc. Cultivating this resourcefulness will allow the individual to excel despite challenges.

Second, there is an extraordinary amount of idle time in our lives. Instead of letting that time pass underutilized, it is best to maximize productivity by taking advantage of it. This includes ANY waiting time. For example, waiting for the bus, in the airport, in between classes, etc. Use that time to complete short tasks that would otherwise accumulate and become a larger burden, such as responding to emails or studying. Another option would be to use that time to become productive in short bursts on a larger project. This will allow the project to be completed sooner, with less perceived pain and stress. In addition, short bursts are more effective than slogging at something for hours.

Third, perform tasks that require a lot of cognitive energy during times of the day that you are most productive. This time will vary for each person, but use that time toward creative tasks, and tasks that require problem-solving. Perform tasks that don't require a lot of mental energy during times of diminished energy. These tasks include things like cleaning, organizing, responding to emails (things that can be done on autopilot).

KESHAWN BOSTIC is a sophomore at Northfield Mount Hermon. He is also a student at Breakthrough New York, a nonprofit organization that transforms the lives of motivated, low-income students by preparing them for college so that they can succeed in the world. Keshawn's advice:

Time management is a big part of being a good student, and to put it bluntly, it is not easy. It is all about motivation and self-discipline. Sometimes, you just need to tell yourself that work is more important than a social life. The best way to do that is to make time work for you.

Learn how you work, what time you work best, and where you work best; whether you work best right after school or at midnight, do what you need to do to do the best work. Personally I prefer a lamplit room between the hours of 7-10pm for optimal performance, but that is just me.

There will be times when you will have to ignore friends or that special girl/guy you've been Snapchatting everyday—this is just the reality of life as a student. But by having that initial work time alone, you can then make the most of your time elsewhere.

JOHN PAUL ENGEL graduated from the University of Iowa and was named a Collegiate Scholar. He earned an MBA from the University of Chicago. Today he is Executive Director, Project Be the Change (www.projectbethechange.com). His advice:

Always get at least 1 week ahead in your reading at the start of the semester in first week of classes. That way you can keep the work load more even through the semester and you will always have read the material the professor or teacher will cover in class.

Take notes by hand marking the important points. Then at night type the notes into your computer. This is good review and it makes sure you have a backup of your notes.

Make a one page study sheet of the items you think are the most important in the class. In other words guess what is going to be on the test - hint if it was in the book and the teacher talked about it in class there is a good chance it will be on the test. Carry your one page study sheet around with you everywhere you go and check it when you have free time. IT's easier to learn a little at a time then it is to try to cram the night before. I never got less than an A in a class I made a one page study sheet.

Convince yourself whatever you are studying is fun and will be important to you in life. IF you think it's hard then it will be hard. If you make a game of it creating songs and little games with flash cards then you are more likely to remember it.

When you study you need to study. No cell phone, Facebook, etc. You need to unplug and focus. Go someplace to study or study at the kitchen table. If you study in your room you will sleep or get interrupted by your friends.

Study on Friday nights. Seriously if you want to be more than average you have to do what the average won't do. Most students start the weekend on Thursday night. If you work through Friday then you can be sure to get your work done. If not, then you still have two days before the work is due.

Surround yourself by the 5 smartest people you can find. They will challenge you to be better. My friends and I used to compete on who could earn the highest score on a test. Make it a game with bragging rights.

JONATHAN FARLEY graduated second in his class at Harvard University, with 29 A's and three A-'s. His advice:

First, choose the right courses: (a) Don't take courses you know nothing about just because they look interesting, unless Russian roulette is one of your favorite games. (b) Do not take too many courses each term.

Second, prepare before each course: learn the subject beforehand; find the reading list for the course and read.

Third, Join study groups.

Fourth, do not bring a television to college. Go to sophisticated movies with friends if you are going to watch a screen: that way you are always improving yourself.

KRISTIN GMUNDER is a senior at Villa Walsh Academy in Morristown, New Jersey. Her advice:

Every high school and college student loves to watch TV; we're not fooling anyone. However, we all know we don't have time to watch TV every night of the week as we would like to. As students, we know that each week the workload is different in weight—some weeks we have very little work and other weeks we have so much that we are drowning. The way to combat this issue of our TV addictions is to binge watch. Yes, many people would look at me weirdly for suggesting that students binge watch using programs like Netflix or Hulu, but this really is the best way for us to enjoy TV when those workloads are less and we have more free time. This way when we're suffering under those textbooks and the papers we have to write, we're not tempted to type netflix.com into the Google search bar.

JASON KHOO is part of the President Scholar Program at California State University Fullerton and on the Dean's List for the Mihaylo College of Business and Economics. His advice:

Maintaining good grades is having a good understanding of the construct of your grade. Most classes are weighted and thus different assignments and tests have a larger impact on your grade. Know when the most important assignments, tests, and projects occur; then make sure at that time you are ready to work. I've seen many people who are excellent planners and never procrastinate only receive B's and C's. This is

because they don't properly weight their effort. Know when to put in all your effort and know when to ease back. This will help you stay energized but also not waste excessive time on academics.

ANGELA HANSON was valedictorian of her high school graduating class and is a top student at Rose-Hulman Institute of Technology. Her advice:

I have found it most helpful to do something rather than nothing. If you aren't sure what to work on first, just pick something and get started. Once you get tired of one assignment, either finish it out or move to something else. A lot of time is wasted deciding where to start or avoiding an assignment you don't like. Also, a change of scenery can be helpful. I now associate my apartment with socializing, so I try to find another place that is just for homework. This makes it easier to be productive.

MARIAM OLADIPO is ranked number one in her senior class at Milton Hershey School, in Hershey, Pennsylvania. Her advice:

During the day, I try to get as much homework done as possible so that I'm not as swamped at night. It seems to work because I get a good seven to eight hours of sleep every night.

For me, it's more balancing friends with activities. With school, I can just plan a study session where we can get work done and hang out. Activities present a different problem. Many times I have to schedule time just to hang out with my friends. It's not spontaneous, but it is still fun.

A lot of my friends have social media but I prefer not to because I know that it can take up a lot of time. I prefer to text, call, or talk to people in person.

I would say pick the things to get involved with that you truly love. You don't have to be involved in a lot of different things

because you won't be able to manage it all with your friends, your grades, and your health. Make sure that you take time for yourself so that you can be the best person that you can be.

JANE NINIVAGGI is a senior at University Liggett School and plans to attend Barnard College. Her advice:

There is nothing wrong with social media, but it can take over a student's life if they are not able to disconnect from it. During exam weeks, I delete Twitter and Instagram off my phone. I also make sure to leave my phone at home when there is something that I know I need to put all of my focus into.

A key part of staying focused is keeping your standards high. At Liggett, I play several sports and am on the Student Commission, so that helps to give us an inherent sense of time management. You quickly learn that your time is so invaluable and you want to spend it in the most productive way.

I also find ways on the weekend to combine my social and academic life — I hang out with friends who have similar standards and we do things together on the weekends such as studying for exams.

JACQUELINE KOPICKI is a senior at University Liggett School and plans to attend Miami University in Ohio. Her advice:

I put everything in my calendar on my phone, and I color code my activities and appointments. For example, I will code athletics one color, the school musical practices another color and my assignments another color.

I think setting your own priorities and figuring out what is most important helps you manage your time and stay focused. For me, school comes first, so I make it a priority to

finish my homework and talk to my teachers about all of my school-related issues before anything else. At the school, the most important thing is to have a close relationship with your teachers and other students who are focused. This helps you gain the mindset to work on your schoolwork first before you tackle anything else.

GRACE LEBRON attends Eastlake High School. Her advice:

I think about my future constantly and it's what keeps me in line. I know I want to lead a happy, successful life and that getting my work done and being the best I can be in my educational environment is a step in the right direction.

Saying No to Friends: You really need to prioritize and consider everything that's going on. If you know you have tests coming up you're not prepared for or have unfinished assignments due the next day, going to the movies shouldn't be at the top of your list.

Resisting Social Media: Personally I set mini goals and checking social media is kind of like I'm rewarding myself. For example I'd tell myself that when I finish two assignments I can check one social media. It's worked out pretty well for me.

Time Management: If it's important, then you'll find time for it. School is important to me so I make time to have all school related things in order before anything else. Lacrosse and field hockey are important to me so I make time to put in the necessary work for that as well. Family is also very important so I always make time to be with them and help around the house.

We teenagers do need some downtime though so no matter what, ALWAYS carve out time to enjoy a hobby or just relax. It'll keep you from going crazy.

ALI WARSHAY is a senior at Westwood High School and is entering Harvard College. Ali's advice:

*A piece of advice I would give to help manage time is that before anything else, know your organizational strengths and weaknesses as well as how much you can realistically complete *well* in a given day. I become distracted easily if I don't set a detailed schedule for myself; however, once I've allocated a specific amount of time for everything on my to-do list, tasks become much more manageable. I religiously use the Schedule Planner app, which syncs with my calendar and helps me visually manage my time.*

I'm also a big fan of the Stay Focused app on my computer, which blocks the amount of time I can spend each day on specific websites (especially social media).

MORGAN MUNSEY is a senior at Sullivan East High School and will attend East Tennessee State University. Morgan's advice:

I use a planner with a month view and a weekly view. I put all club meetings, planned time with friends and family, sport activities, and big tests on the month view. Daily items I need to accomplish such as homework and reading I keep in the weekly view sections. Each night I spend 5-10 minutes focusing on what I accomplished, what I need to better, and what is to come the next day. This helps keep me prepared and less forgetful.

I am a procrastinator. I always have been, and I always will be. It's so easy to say, I can do it later, and then forget to do it. So rather than making later the next day or in a few hours I use the timer function on my phone. If the time is 11:13 and I need to study but want to put it off, I give myself 17 minutes. Although it doesn't seem like much time, this routine satisfies my procrastinator personality.

Whenever I have a moment of free time I make StudyBlue notecards. Rather than taking the time to type out full definitions, I use the talk to text option on my iPad. I may look a little silly to those watching, but this makes the

process go much faster. Since I made the notecards on StudyBlue I can study basically anywhere at any time. This allows me to study even when I only have a few minutes such as between classes or during lunch. The ability to do this is great when you have a busy week.

I don't have the best handwriting which can make studying more difficult. When allowed, I love to take notes on Google Docs. The program is convenient because it updates as you type on one device to all of your other devices. The program also allows for easy color changes and graphing, which can make notes seem a little more enjoyable.

NATHAN REYNOLDS attends Reynoldsburg High School. His advice:

Do your school work in school, when you have free time. It greatly helps at home when you have a lot of other work to do. If you can't do it in school, divvy up your work and time so that you have a schedule that reads like, 8-8:30 Math, and so on. It makes you feel the need to get the work done within your time limit, and makes for free time in your day.

KRYSTIE SEESE is a graduate student at Post University. Her advice:

I have found that I work best when I use a planner to track the assignments I've completed and denote the assignments I still owe. This process has yet to fail me. At the beginning of each week I plan what I will complete each day specifically. This helps alleviate the overwhelming feeling of seeing 10-12 assignments that need to be done. As I complete them, I check them off. Simple as that! In addition, this system has helped me ensure that all work due each week is completed on time.

On that same note, it is best to plan to complete assignments when you know you have time. For example, I set aside

every Sunday for my school work. I get as much done as I can on Sundays, and spread out completing unfinished assignments throughout the remainder of the week. This takes the stress off of coming home from a long day at work and still having a ton of schoolwork to do. I've found the key to success in an online program is to plan ahead and have the discipline to follow through.

SHANE WOLF is a candidate for valedictorian of Bridgeway Academy's 2015 graduating class and plans to attend the College of Southern Maryland. His advice:

As a homeschool student the demands on my time can be a little different than that of my peers. Nevertheless, I would argue time management skills are even more imperative for homeschooling students than traditional students. As a homeschooler, I am tasked daily to write my own schedule, stick to deadlines, and balance my schoolwork with extracurricular activities, without the watchful eye of a teacher.

One thing I learned early on is that scheduling is so important. Having a schedule is the easiest way to know what you have going on and what needs to be completed. I use Microsoft Excel to write out my schedule, where I include information like my extracurricular activities, job, and current course work. My parents taught me my education is very important and comes first, so I prioritize my academics. To ensure I keep my grades up, I identify which projects need to be completed first and foremost. If I'm struggling in a particular subject, I try to allow myself more time to focus and concentrate my energies there. This helps me keep my grades up across the board, and not just in the subjects I may have a stronger interest in.

Time Secrets of 239 Entrepreneurs

Innovators, risk takers, dream chasers, business moguls, self-made millionaires...in other words, *entrepreneurs*. Arguably no other group feels the pressure of multiple obligations. Most are overseeing sales as well as product development. Customer service and raising capital. Podcasting, writing books, speaking at conferences. How do entrepreneurs manage to be so productive?



I collected over 25,000 words from entrepreneurs in response to my questions about time management and productivity. With such diversity in people and answers there is of course no one consistent answer to increasing productivity.

However, as the answers started coming back what did surprise me was how many entrepreneurs brought up the importance of a morning routine. These responses were totally unaided—I didn't ask about their routine, or if they had one, and was actually startled by how many brought it up.

Other themes that emerged included the importance of scheduling everything you want to accomplish on your

calendar, the dangers of unmanaged email, and the need for focus. No multi-tasking for this group.

The full unedited comments received from entrepreneurs appear below.

Stephan Aarstol (Twitter: @stephansarstol)

www.towerpaddleboards.com

Free time doesn't materialize by itself. You have to manufacture it. Step one is to try to strip down your current responsibilities to the bare minimum. It's a management by absence practice. You basically just stop doing certain things that you previously thought were nonnegotiable...then you see what breaks. Maybe stop answering the phone. Maybe stop coming to work on Wednesdays. Maybe only do email at a coffee shop with your laptop that has a battery life of 90 minutes. Then see what breaks. You'll be surprised at how much doesn't break. It will also force you to clean up your processes because you will basically be operating at the level of productivity, but with a significantly reduced input of time. Then, you take the free time and devote it entirely to your next project, or some sort of business development function, 100%. I did this when I transitioned from my poker chip company BuyPokerChips.com to TowerPaddleBoards.com. I got my time commitment on BuyPokerChips.com down to about 12-15 hours per week (from 40-50). I literally spend all of Tuesday and Thursday exploring new business ideas, as well as half the day MWF. The result is I went from having a business doing \$500K per year with no growth prospects, to one now where I did \$5M last year and was named the fastest growing private company in San Diego. I attribute that leap to this exact process.

Stephan Aarstol is the CEO and Founder of Tower Paddle Boards, and a past contributor to Fast Company, Entrepreneur, Search Engine Journal, Inc. & other publications.

Amanda Abella (Twitter: @amandaabella)

www.amandaabella.com

The best time management tip I've implored is to stop obsessing over time management tips and instead work with my body. I have deadlines, of course, but on a daily basis I work according to how my body is feeling. For example, I'm not really a morning person so instead of working I usually spend early morning exercising or slowly getting my energy up.

Amanda Abella is a bestselling author, speaker, and creator of the Make Money Your Honey methodology.

Miki Agrawal (Twitter: @twinmiki)

www.mikiagrawal.com and www.docoolshit.org

I used the Gmail lab "Canned Responses" to send multiple emails that are similar faster, I use Boomerang to cue up emails to send on the day/time that I choose, I use Rapportive for Gmail to get basic info about who is emailing me, I use Slack to communicate quickly with my team, and expensify app to manage all of my receipts so I don't have to keep any receipts. It's all about using the great tools that exist for efficiency throughout the day.

Miki Agrawal is a bestselling author of Do Cool Shit and a serial social entrepreneur. She is the CEO and co-founder of THINX: For Women with Periods and founder of the gluten-free pizza concept WILD. She was named by Forbes "Top 20 Millenials On a Mission".

Nellie R. Akalp

www.immad.me

First, establish a dedicated workspace. Creating boundaries between your 'work' and 'personal' lives is critical. If possible, try to give yourself a dedicated office, with a door to shut out unwanted distractions. Second, make good use of your productive time. Productivity experts will tell you to set specific office hours when you work from home. However, it's important to remember that these hours don't have to be 9-5 (unless, of course, your schedule is dictated by a client or employer). Third, end your day with a task list for tomorrow.

When creating your list, try to make your task items as concrete as possible; an abstract task item like ‘find more clients’ won’t help you focus.

Nellie R. Akalp is the founder & CEO of CorpNet Incorporated.

Immad Akhund (Twitter: @immad)
www.immad.me

Make yourself responsible for two or three core things and empower/trust other people to do everything else. This means you will do a great job with things that you consider core and will empower others you work with to take responsibility and get things done.

Immad Akhund is CEO and founder of Heyzap, a profitable and VC funded leading mobile advertising company.

Glen Allsopp (Twitter: @viperchill)

www.viperchill.com

If your current life situation has not yet reached the heights you're aiming for, your day must be dictated towards success, by you. Even if you have a boss and have colleagues which require you to help them with tasks, the first thing I recommend doing each day is to write down which hours you will dedicate to which tasks. If you get an email before email time is scheduled in your day, ignore it. As you cross off every item, you'll feel empowered that you planned something and made it happen—no matter how small—which will spur you onto the next point.

Glen was named an "SEO Expert" by the Guardian newspaper at age 21 and runs the popular marketing brand, ViperChill.

Max Altschuler (Twitter: @maxalts)

www.saleshacker.com

Find a virtual assistant in the Philippines and outsource anything that you yourself do not need to do. Do it first, document the process, and then hand it off to them. Start your day with a good habit that many don't do, like making the bed. This gets your day off to a productive start. Put your email inbox on your phone on the last screen all by itself. This way when you look at your phone you don't see the app icon unless you're actually trying to check your email. This keeps you from checking your email constantly. Checking email too much is a huge productivity killer.

Max Altschuler is the CEO of Sales Hacker Inc, a global media company focused on bring the newest tactics, strategies, and technologies to sales organizations everywhere. He also wrote the bestselling book, Hacking Sales.

James Altucher (Twitter: @jaltucher)

www.jamesaltucher.com

If something is not a “hell, YEAH!” then it’s a “no!”

James Altucher started and sold several businesses, is a bestselling author, an active investor and adviser, and a mediocre podcaster.

Raoul Anderson (Twitter: @raoula)

www.andersonmorgan.com

My philosophy in running a business across multiple countries and multiple time zones is to empower the local people to make decisions that benefit their local area. This allows quick decisions to be made without implementing a large system lined with red tape that naturally impedes efficiency and response speeds. My favourite app for keeping my schedule organized is Tempo. It not only pulls my calendars from multiple sources, but also provides a single, simple interface to alert me of things I may be interested in that have been posted on social media like Twitter, LinkedIn and Facebook without interrupting my day.

Raoul Anderson is the founder of Anderson Morgan, a technology company started in a small regional area in Tasmania that now spans the globe with operations in Australia, Canada, and the United States.

Dave Arnold (Twitter: @davejarnold16)

www.davearnoldspeaks.com

Write down the three things you are most passionate about and keep it somewhere you can see constantly. Keep those three things before you and focus on working toward them; as a result, this will help you keep focused and not get sucked into doing things which will not help you thrive.

Dave Arnold is a minister, speaker, coach, and bestselling author.

**Nikhil Arora & Alejandro Velez (Twitter:
@BTTRventures)**

www.backtotheroots.com

Focus—true focus is saying no to the things YOU really want to do. Essentialism—start each week and each morning by asking yourself what are the three most essential things that have to be done today/this week to impact the business most. Keep that list in front of you throughout the day so the black hole of email doesn't suck you up! Find partners who do what you can do better and work with them! Don't try to do everything yourself—we started off trying to collect coffee grounds, grow mushrooms, sell mushrooms, do our own packaging design, our own sales, etc.—it was just too much and we weren't doing any of it very well! We've since found partners that let us focus on developing products, getting them out there, and building a community around them!

Nikhil Arora & Alejandro Velez co-founded Back to the Roots in 2009. The two have been named one of BusinessWeek's Top 25 Entrepreneurs under 25, Inc.'s 30 Under 30, Forbes' 30 Under 30, and CNN's 10 Next Entrepreneur's to watch. Back to the Roots was named one of Martha Stewart's Top 10 American Made companies, #373 to the INC 5000 list, and has been recognized for its innovation by President Obama.

Arjun Arora (Twitter: @ArjunDArora)

www.immediatelyApp.com

First, be ruthless about your calendar—stick to it, hell or high water but create space for unstructured time as well. Second, forcing functions—use them to your advantage to get things done. Have people show up for events on the calendar that you have to be at—that force you to do certain things quickly. Work expands to fill the time you give it. Third, take care of yourself—create space and time in your calendar for things for you. You are 100x more productive when you are well taken care of. My personal example: I work out before lunch Monday through Friday. That's my time. Fourth, never eat alone—you get huge leverage from a strong network, build it out. Knowing the person who can get you what you need and who is willing to help you will save you hours and hours of time.

Arjun Arora is the co-founder of Immediately and founder and former CEO of ReTargeter. He has been recognized at the White House, at the UN, and at the Global Summit for entrepreneurship for his success and commitment to a values centered organization.

Yasmine Arrington (Twitter: @yazziespeaks)
www.scholarchipsfund.com

Balance in everything you do is key to successful time management! There are only so many hours in a day, so you must prioritize what needs to be done each day. Make a list weekly or daily of what must be done on certain days and what tasks can wait til the next day. Check them off as you go. Checking off items on your “To Do” list will help you visually keep track of your progress and give you a needed sense of accomplishment. Time management does not only include prioritizing business tasks, but also your health (time for exercising and eating), time for a sufficient amount of sleep, and recreational time. Today there are many mobile and online apps that can help you with time management and scheduling such as Google Calendar and Wunderlist, however my favorite remains the old-fashioned written planner. I also find that I am most productive early in the morning or late at night, when it is really quiet. It allows for better concentration—though some people do better concentrating in a place with background noise. The fact of the matter is, you must find what works best for you and stick with it.

Yasmine Arrington is the founder and executive director of the non-profit ScholarCHIPS (for Children of Incarcerated Parents). Yasmine started ScholarCHIPS as a junior in high school.

Julie Austin (Twitter: SpeakerSponsor)

www.createforcash.com

Because I work an average of at least 12 hours a day, I have to make sure I do all heavy brain work in the morning (like writing), and repetitive work (like filling orders) later in the day.

Julie Austin is an inventor, multiple business owner, and innovation keynote speaker.

Andreea Ayers (Twitter: @andreeaayers)

www.LaunchGrowJoy.com

Before I sit down to work every morning, I go for a 30 minute walk to clear my head and plan for the day ahead. I also know that my most creative time is before lunch, so I have blocked off 9-12 every day for work - I don't take any phone calls or do any interviews during that time. That way I can be at my most productive every morning without any distractions!

Andreea Ayers is the founder of LaunchGrowJoy.com, which is THE go-to source for product entrepreneurs who want more press, more exposure, more success, and more sales.

Justin Baeder (Twitter: @eduleadership)

www.eduleadership.org

We know that what gets scheduled tends to be what gets done, and if something doesn't make it onto the calendar, it's far more likely to remain on the "to-do" list forever. But most of us have far more to do than we can fit into our schedules. How can we get the most important work scheduled and completed, without adding more hours to the day? Three tools can work together to help us accomplish more of what matters in the time available to us: 1) An electronic to-do list. 2) A leadership agenda, a written set of goals, major projects, and priorities. 3) A calendar. An electronic "to-do" list is a great tool for organizing, prioritizing, and keeping track of tasks, but it doesn't solve the scheduling problem. Since we can't make time in our schedule for every single task, we need a filter. The agenda serves as the filter between your overflowing and

unrealistic “to-do” list, and the harsh reality of your calendar. As you plan your week, review your agenda and your “to-do” list, and schedule the work that appears in both. You’ll find that you need to add tasks to your “to-do” list to reflect your priorities, and eliminate others that don’t fit your agenda. You’ll notice when your agenda needs to be updated, and you’ll be able to see how well your use of time lines up with your priorities.

Justin Baeder is a speaker, leadership consultant, and director of The Principal Center, a professional development firm supporting school leaders in 34 countries through video-based online programs.

Jay Baer (Twitter: @jaybaer)
www.ConvinceAndConvert.org

Every year, audit your time and find a way to delegate at least 15% of what you’re doing.

Jay Baer is the founder of Convince & Convert, a keynote speaker, and best selling author of Youtility.

Craig Ballantyne (Twitter: @craigballantyne)
www.EarlyToRise.com

Get up 15-minutes earlier than everyone else in your house and get into the office 15-minutes before everyone else. You can solve any problem in your life if you devote 15-minutes of focused thinking to it first thing in the morning every day.

Craig Ballantyne is the creator of Turbulence Training, the world’s best metabolic home workout, and is the editor of EarlyToRise.com.

Zvi Band (Twitter: skeevis)
www.zviband.com

Every Sunday, I take 30 minutes to identify what my core goals are for the coming week, and have that on my desk at all times. Believe it or not, the most effective thing I’ve found, which I’ve practiced for the past eight years, is to have a small paper notepad on my desk at all times. I’ve practiced the same ritual—the first thing I do in the morning is write down the list of actions I have to do, carrying over anything from previous

days. I'll cross off and add tasks during the day, as well as record notes. Despite all the digital "to-do" tools, nothing I've found beats having a piece of paper and seeing things get crossed off.

Zvi is the co-founder and CEO of Contactually, a contact management platform that helps professionals turn relationships into results.

Eric Bandholz (Twitter: @bandholz)

www.beardbrand.com

In life, there is only one thing—action. What are you currently doing at this moment and how is it helping to improve your life? You have the same amount of time in a day as everyone else on the planet. How you break up that day will ultimately determine the legacy you build. The beautiful thing about this is when you recognize that you are 100% in control of your actions, then you can do whatever the hell you want. If you really want to be better at time management, then start acting on it; everything else will fall in line.

Eric Bandholz is the founder of Beardbrand, a company that is changing the way society views beardsmen through beard care.

Jeet Banerjee (Twitter: @TheJeetBanerjee)

www.JeetBanerjee.com

My best time management or productivity tip is waking up bright and early every morning to create a list of tasks that must get done each day. I create a list of all the items I want to get done in a single day. After that, I order each item based on the importance of it. At the top, I have a list of the things that must get done before the end of the day to all of the lower level stuff. That helps me stay focused and tackle the most important items at the beginning of the day.

Jeet Banerjee is a 22 year old serial entrepreneur, digital marketing consultant, TEDx speaker, and bestselling author.

Corbett Barr (Twitter: @corbettbarr)

www.fizzle.co

I stay productive by developing and maintaining what I call a personal “operating system,” which is a set of processes, tools, and checkpoints that define how I get work done every day. The specifics of an operating system differ from person to person, but the important thing is that you have one, and you work to make it better as you learn more about how you work and what’s important to you.

Corbett Barr is co-founder and CEO of Fizzle, a community and training platform for entrepreneurs.

Marni Battista (Twitter: @MarniBattista)

www.DatingWithDignity.com

In addition to a personalized daily planner tailored to my needs, I also use something called the CALM Prosperity Process.

As the founder of Dating with Dignity and with more than 25 years of personal relationship and dating experience, Marni Battista has dated, was married for 17 years, divorced, and then successfully dated again (and married!) in the 21st century.

Samantha Bell (Twitter: @SamBe11)

www.SamanthaBell.com.au

Gmail inbox pause—for when email explosions happen during big workloads, move unimportant emails into the hidden paused folder. Boomerang app—schedule emails to return when more relevant. Recruit well, include trial periods to find your great crew. Find people who are fun and easy to collaborate with and who can sense what you need to be in flow. From Tim Ferriss—no meetings on Monday (plan the week that day) and Fridays (life/work chores). Inbox zero as often as possible.

Samantha Bell is the co-founder of Do Lectures Australia.

Sophia Bera (Twitter: @sophiabera)

www.GenYPlanning.com

If I’m feeling stuck and I don’t want to start a project, I set my phone for 30 minutes and tell myself that I only have to work for that amount of time. Once the time is up, I usually just

spend a few minutes finishing the project. Often times I surprise myself by how much I can get done with just 30 minutes of focused work. I love doing yoga and every Sunday I look at my calendar and plan out my yoga schedule for the next week. By putting it on my calendar with my other appointments, I actually end up going four to five times per week instead of one to two times when I didn't take the time to put it on my calendar. My other tip is to do walking meetings. Any meeting that I don't need to take notes for, I try to turn into a walking meeting and just pop in my earbuds while I go outside. I find that sitting in front of the computer for more than a few hours makes me stir crazy so this is a great way to use the time within time. I'm also more focused on what the other person is actually saying instead of being distracted by my computer. I believe that finding ways to exercise or move throughout the day is one of the best things we can do for our productivity.

Sophia Bera, CFP is a virtual financial planner for millennials and the founder of Gen Y Planning.

Laura Berg (Twitter: @LauraBergInc)
www.LauraBergInc.com

I try to use the 'touch it once' principle when checking emails. If you open an email, you answer it. Before I would waste so much time reading through emails and then marking them 'unread' so that I could come back to them when I had more time. Now, if I don't have time to answer them I don't open them. Think about it, even if you take 30 seconds to re-read an email that you've already read over the course of a week you are wasting valuable minutes, those minutes add up. When you are an entrepreneur your time is precious so don't waste it re-reading emails. Of course, there is an exception when you need to give an email some thought but I try my best to always 'touch it once'.

Laura Berg is the president of My Smart Hands and author of the Baby Signing Bible. She is an expert in video marketing, certified through Google as a YouTube specialist. She successfully used YouTube to grow her company into an internationally recognizable brand.

Jonah Berger (Twitter: @jlberger)

www.jonahberger.com

Meetings, phone calls, and emails can break up your entire day if you let them, leaving you little time to get any big thinking done. Make sure to block off time to get important things done. Cancel meetings you don't need. And only check email a few times a day. You won't miss much but you'll save a lot of time.

Jonah Berger is a marketing professor at the Wharton School at the University of Pennsylvania, and bestselling author of Contagious: Why Things Catch On.

Warren Bobrow (Twitter: @warrenbobrow1)

www.cocktailwhisperer.com

Don't be afraid to dream—to find out what is your passion! It took me twenty years to realize mine and what a realization it is!

Warren Bobrow reinvented himself from cook/pasta maker, to bank teller, to private banking executive assistant for twenty years, to offshoring, to becoming a thrice published author on the topic of liquor/mixology.

Norm Bour (Twitter: @vapementors)

www.VapeMentors.com

Google calendar has become a great friend for daily scheduling and Asana, for project management with my team. Scheduling phone calls and having it load to my phone is a God-send!

Lifelong entrepreneur, developer of VapeMentors and VAPE U, which support businesses in the vaping and electronic cigarette space.

Farnoosh Brock (Twitter: @prolificliving)

www.prolificliving.com

Watch what you put in your mouth: Eat a high-energy inducing diet. Your diet couldn't be more instrumental to your productivity. Trust in this even if it's an invisible link. If you live on sodas, junk snacks and fast foods, you are willingly handing over hours of power productivity over to your body so

it can digest and deal with the “food” rather than unleash your own creative genius. Case in point: how productive you feel after a heavy lunch or a day of eating poorly on a road trip? Think how much more effort it takes to just focus when you are tired and dizzy from a hangover? Now compare this to how productive and clear and energetic you feel after a nutrient rich meal, such as healthy proteins, a green juice or a raw salad? My first and biggest advice to you is to radically improve your diet if you want to to enjoy massive productivity and creativity in your daily life.

Farnoosh Brock is an ex-corporate, published author, business coach, speaker, and is hopelessly devoted to yoga and world traveling. After a long corporate career, she started Prolific Living to help careerists in transition with building their profitable side-hustles and full online businesses.

Chris Brogan (Twitter: @chrisbrogan)

www.chrisbrogan.com

I work more on time alignment. Is this part of my mission?
Does this serve others or strengthen my ability to serve others?
Those two questions keep me tight to my map. That's how I
best manage my time and priorities.

*Chris Brogan, CEO of Owner Media Group, helps people
grow their capabilities and connections.*

Robert Brooks (Twitter: @drrobertbrooks)

www.drrobertbrooks.com

Much of my professional time involves writing and planning my presentations and workshops. I have found that to use my time most effectively and be most productive, I (a) exercise first thing in the morning since exercise is such an important part of our overall health and creativity, (b) do most of my writing in the morning since that is when I am most alert, (c) choose and focus as much as possible on those activities and topics that are not only of great interest to me but also add meaning and purpose to my life by enriching the lives of others (creating meaning and purpose help me to remain motivated and focused and are important dimensions of resilience), (d) avoid self-blame, which wastes time and energy, and recognize that some days are just not going to be as productive as other days, and (e) make certain I engage with friends and family in activities not related to my professional life. I do not use an app for time management or productivity. I discuss the main themes of my approach in my book *The Power of Resilience: Achieving Balance, Confidence, and Personal Strength in Your Life*, published by McGraw-Hill.

Dr. Robert Brooks is a clinical psychologist, author, and keynote speaker who addresses such topics as resilience, motivation, positive work environments, family relationships, effective leadership, and balancing our personal and professional lives.

Sunni Brown (Twitter: @sunnibrown)

www.sunnibrown.com

Advice: Outsource the problem to your subconscious. The verbal, conscious brain forms pretty strong habit patterns. To alter the thinking paths, to solve really challenging problems, the brain needs to deploy its diverse functionality—different networks, different parts, different associations. Once you have the information you need, the foundation for creative thinking is established, then you can often trust the subconscious to use its untapped horsepower to provide solutions. Walk away from the problem and trust that your deeper mind and body will show up and offer a response.

Sunni Brown is founder of a creative consultancy, an international speaker, co-author of the best-selling book Gamestorming, and author of Oprah.com's "must-read" The Doodle Revolution. She was named one of the "100 Most Creative People in Business" and one of the "10 Most Creative People on Twitter" by Fast Company.

Howard Brown (Twitter: @HowardBrown)

www.RingDNA.com

To me, the secret to time management is actually creating more time through increased productivity. But that doesn't mean I have to work harder. I simply invest one hour a month to research and test new productivity tools that can automate mundane tasks. We're lucky to live in a time of remarkable innovation, so there's always something new, amazing (and often free) that can make you at least 1% more productive. The process has been so effective for me that it inspired me to create my company, RingDNA, which builds sales acceleration apps that make sales teams more productive. Whatever your industry is, I encourage you to seek out productivity apps. If you have routine, repetitive tasks in your life, odds are that someone has invented a shortcut. If you can find just one or two small solutions each month, you'll soon find that you actually have a lot more time to manage.

Howard Brown is a three-time entrepreneur with a proven track record of success and innovation in marketing, sales, and cloud computing. His passion for revenue performance

optimization through technology was the catalyst for creating RingDNA.

William Brown (Twitter: @williamdeanchoc)

www.williamdeanchocolates.com

One of my favorite quotes from my days in corporate that I truly believe leads to success is “Plan the work then work the plan”. Creativity is what makes me who I am but like other creative minded people...it can be hard to stay on task and without a blueprint, nothing gets built. We also use a system where we develop a plan for the next day and prioritize five tasks that need to be done by each person, some are individual while some may be group task. We then put all other tasks on another sheet and do them when their priority is tops or after finishing the top 5 tasks for the day. It’s amazing to me how productivity builds off the success of completing tasks and moving to the next. We begin/end each day the same in the kitchen with a short huddle about what are the top goals and at the end of the day, everyone works together to clean up so we are prepared to hit the ground running the next day. I find that making chocolates is not unlike my days back in corporate America. When I start with a plan, I end with productivity and satisfaction...without a plan it can seem a very long, aimless and unproductive day and I like the feeling of a day of accomplishment over one of uncertainty.

William Brown is founder, President and Chief Chocolate Officer of William Dean Chocolates. William Dean Chocolates is an artisan chocolate company located in Belleair Bluffs Florida whose products have appeared in The Hunger Games series and have won over 100 awards nationally. William was selected as one of the Top 10 Chocolatiers in North America for 2014 by Dessert Professional.

Stephanie Burns (Twitter: @StephanieABurns)

www.stephanie-burns.com

I have a lot of different tools I use to keep myself and my time organized. Firstly, I always schedule one day a week where there are no calls and no meetings. I am completely unavailable that day. I use those days to power through things I need to get done without the distractions. I use a tool called

Followupthen.com to help me remember to follow up on emails or reminders. I love this tool because I can have an email sent back to me in one minute or one year. Finally, I schedule in all recurring reminders in my calendar so I can forget them. For example, I schedule in every three months that I need to get my oil changed, every six months, to get my teeth cleaned, every year to pay my car registration. I can't keep those things in my head, so I put them all on the calendar and forget about it.

Stephanie Burns is an author, speaker, and founder of Chic CEO, a global online resource for female entrepreneurs.

Julie Busha (Twitter: @julesbusha)
www.slawsa.com

Because I wear many hats and am a type-A personality, I find that lists keep me organized the most. At the end of the day, I re-create my list for the following day, prioritizing tasks and making sure that I handle any delegation earlier in the day. When the plan is set, you can sleep a little easier at night. I also purposefully add some tasks to the list that aren't urgent or required that day because the possibility of doing it early keeps me ahead of the game knowing unanticipated projects can and will arise in the future. The reality is that I know that my list will likely triple by days end and there is a sense of satisfaction and accomplishment to physically cross off that growing list that keeps you energized through the finish.

Julie Busha is the CEO of Nicole Foods, creator of Slawsa, which has emerged as one of the most innovative condiments in the grocery industry.

Grant Cardone (Twitter: @grantcardone)
www.GrantCardone.com

I don't add time to activities. Hell, I wear a different watch each day and I don't even take the time to set them. I get as much done as I can as quickly as I can, waste no time on the little things and if I mess up I will go back and clean it up. Time is the drug of choice and the side effect is fear—add time you feel fear. My first book, *Sell or Be Sold*, was written in three hours and had tons of grammar issues. By the time we

sold out the first run, I had people telling me about the grammar errors. I told them, “It’s not a best written book, its a best selling book.” We cleaned the book up on the next run and it became an award-winning book in business.

I leave perfection for others. Anyone that tells you to get it right the first time isn’t doing enough. Speed is the new big! Remove the brake, accelerate and get your ideas out ahead of everyone else. While others are figuring, you can be doing. The old fable suggests that the tortoise wins over the hare. The reality is, in the new economy if you want to be a millionaire you have to be the tortoise and the hare. I leave perfection to the perfectionist; I, instead, have elected to produce.

Grant Cardone is the New York Times bestselling author of The 10X Rule and other books, a real estate investor, and founder and CEO of four companies. Cardone regularly appears on CNBC, CNN, and Bloomberg TV.

Bobby Casey (Twitter: @GWPro)
www.GlobalWealthProtection.com

My morning ritual is always the same. Wake up around 9am (clearly not an early riser), stretch and exercise for 10-15 minutes, drink 600-1000mL of cold water, make protein breakfast (usually eggs) and morning coffee. Then reading for 30-60 minutes. I keep weekly lists of “to-do” items and check them off upon completion. This helps keep me focused and goal oriented, allowing me to check off minor successes along the way. I rely heavily on my google calendar synced with my email client (Thunderbird), my phone and my assistant. Everything goes in my calendar. That keeps me on point to keep a tight schedule. I use timetrade.com to give clients the ability to schedule appointments with me directly. Our members (www.GWPInsiders) can book appointments directly with me using a timetrade link in the members area. Non-members can purchase a consultation appointment on our website which redirects after purchase to a timetrade link allowing them to book their own appointment. This integrates with my google calendar as well. My #1 productivity tip though is to have a personal assistant that manages your non-income producing tasks. My PA books my travel (which is a

lot) and manages my appointments as well as a few administrative tasks. People sometimes tell me they cannot afford a PA, I tell them I cannot afford to not have one. She saves me more in travel costs alone than her wage.

Bobby Casey is a lifelong entrepreneur and student of life. He has started, bought, and sold a dozen or so businesses and currently owns three companies in the offshore finance space. He has lived in multiple countries, traveled to nearly 100 countries on five continents, and is considered a perpetual traveler running his businesses from just a laptop and cell phone.

Antonio Centeno (Twitter: @rmrstyle)

www.realmenrealstyle.com

I'm all about efficiency. Instead of taking 30 minutes to answer a question via e-mail, I often times create an article which I then blog post answering the question and share with them the answer along with making it public so it can help thousands of other men. Checklists are also very important to my day to day routine. I use them so I don't have to think, therefore I conserve my energy for the few hours a day I need to focus in on something new and be creative.

*Antonio Centeno is the founder of www.RealMenRealStyle.com and www.ATailoredSuit.com. He has created over 1000 articles & videos on men's style, blogs over at the www.ArtofManliness.com, and is the creator of the internet's best style course for professionals - *A Man's Guide To Style*. Antonio has studied clothing design in London, Hong Kong, and Bangkok. He is a former US Marine with an MBA from UT Austin and a BA from Cornell College. He loves to hear from old friends and make new ones.*

Misa Chien (Twitter: @misachien)

www.fosubo.com

I recommend keeping a calendar, such as Google Calendar, to organize yourself. Whenever you think of something that must be done, immediately record it in your calendar.

Misa Chien is a serial entrepreneur, speaker, and co-founder of Fosubo, a leader in improving the customer experience for

Telecom Providers.

Dorie Clark (Twitter: @dorieclark)

www.dorieclark.com

My inbox is a constant source of stress for me. Here's how I deal with it. First, following on a principle I first read about in Frances Frei and Anne Morriss' *Uncommon Service*, I've made a conscious choice about "what to be bad at". There are tradeoffs that must be made if you're going to excel in any area—and for me, part of being good at the most important work I do (such as writing books or consulting) is coming to terms with the fact that I'll be a little bit bad at email response times. I hate making people wait to hear from me, but that tradeoff enables me to do my highest value work. Second, I work with a virtual assistant, and have been able to delegate some repetitive emails tasks to him (like responding to LinkedIn friend requests). Third, I'll often undertake email binges on weekends, when I receive far fewer messages and can respond to many in a short burst of focus.

I also use TripIt Pro to organize all my business travel into one easy-to-reference location. I'm constantly on the road and can't keep track of which rental car agency I'm using or what terminal my flight is departing out of. It's great to know that everything is compiled in one place so I don't have to remember it or print it out. Additionally, I use the Sunrise calendar app, which has a magnificent feature—when you enter a meeting location, it links directly to a Google map. With one click, you can get directions to the site and an estimate of travel time. It takes the guesswork out of your schedule.

Dorie Clark is a consultant who teaches for Duke University's Fuqua School of Business and is the author of Stand Out and Reinventing You.

Ian Cleary (Twitter: @iancleary)

www.razorsocial.com

Set a timer for everything you do. When you have a deadline you are more productive. I use the Pomodoro technique where I work in 25 minute time slots and then take a couple of

minutes break. It's amazing how much more you can get done if you time it!

Ian Cleary is founder of Razorsocial, an award winning marketing technology blog.

Amy Clover (Twitter: @StrongInsideOut)
www.StrongInsideOut.com

To stay at my most productive, I need to move my body. Without movement, our bodies hold onto stress which can muck up the creative process! If I'm too slammed to get a full workout in, I do spurts of activity throughout the day. I'll alternate 20 squats, 10 push ups, and 15 supermans on the hour or half hour to keep my creative juices flowing and give my mind a break. While you move, coordinate your breathing with the movement, and you'll amp up the benefits!

Amy Clover is a celebrity fitness trainer, writer, and the force behind Strong Inside Out.

Derek Coburn (Twitter: @cadredc)
www.derekcoburn.com

Don't ever confuse being busy with being productive, and don't ever confuse being productive with being intentional about how you are spending your time (i.e. spending time with your kids without checking your phone). My #1 productivity hack is Bulletproof Coffee.

Derek Coburn is the bestselling author of Networking Is Not Working and the co-founder of CADRE, an un-networking community for CEOs and Entrepreneurs in Washington, DC.

Tim Conley (Twitter: @TimConley)
www.TimConley.co

Batch big. There are a many "productivity hacks" that tell you to batch your email, phone calls, and other similar tasks so that you're not using up your mental energy switching back and forth through a variety of tasks. I agree with those, but I've batched bigger. I've batched all my client work into a total of six days per month, my promotional efforts into five days per month and my vacations into two one-month sabbaticals. Big batching creates a framework of short and intense bursts

of productivity and also give you significant time to recuperate and recharge your creativity.

Tim Conley has coached, advised, and mentored more than 400 entrepreneurs—and counting—helping them gain financial freedom and life fulfillment while becoming the CEO of their own business. He is releasing his book, War of the Start, in the fall of 2015.

Cheryl Snapp Conner (Twitter: @CherylSnapp)

www.snappconner.com

The greatest advice I've received comes from fellow CEO Jason Garner (now a life balance and personal accomplishment coach, formerly a CEO of LiveNation) is to start every day with the tasks that represent my highest priority—health and balance. Exercise, a little stretching, and a healthy breakfast (he drinks a green smoothie; my choice is an oat bran pancake with coconut oil and herbal tea). After that, the rest of the day is on a great track and my approach to the challenges of the day is more effective. I have my office refrigerator stocked with healthy snacks, my calendar set, and I have stopped answering calls from any number I don't recognize until I (or my assistant) have determined that it is really a call that requires me. I also read something that enriches my spirit or my personal development every single day. It's made a great impact on both me and my company, which is growing rapidly.

Cheryl Snapp Conner is an author and expert in business and communications and the founder of Thought Leadership and PR company SnappConner PR.

Carrie Contey, PhD (Twitter: @carrieconteyphd)

www.carriecontey.com

I'm most productive when I'm feeling tuned into and aligned with my higher self/inner guidance system. I find that when I take the time in the morning to get tuned into ME I'm far more productive the rest of the day. How do I do this? I try to catch my first thoughts of the day and I steer them toward positivity. As soon as I can think of it after waking up and will take a minute or two to appreciate my comfy bed, my healthy family,

my amazing friends, the tea I will drink in a few minutes, etc. After that I go for a walk so that I can breathe in fresh air and move my body. Usually when I get back I'm ready to sit down and get to work. I'm also a huge fan of the app HiFutureSelf. I use it to send myself reminders, sometimes hourly, that keep me tuned in and feeling good and intentional.

Carrie Contey, PhD is a internationally recognized coach, author, speaker, and educator. Currently she lives, works, and plays in Austin, TX. To learn more please visit carriecontey.com.

Brant Cooper (Twitter: @brantcooper)
www.movestheneedle.com

First Sunday evening is the key to the week. Without alarms ringing and random interruptions, I can focus on what needs to be accomplished. My formula for prioritizing activities: impact/time, where impact means moving the needle of my business and time is the level of effort required. I try to focus on removing the next bottleneck of growth that is under my control.

Brant Cooper is a NYT bestselling author and founder of Moves the Needle, bringing Lean Startup practices to corporate innovation.

Paul Copcutt (Twitter: @paulcopcutt)
www.paulcopcutt.com

Always look to take three actions each day that impact your business, you personally (can be extended to family), and someone else. Impact means make a difference that without your input it would not have happened.

Paul Copcutt is a personal brand architect, speaker, and coach and helps people find their rebel voice.

Honorée Corder (Twitter: @Honoree)
www.honoreecorder.com

I use the Bullet Journal as my go-to organization system. It keeps ideas, thoughts, and other important agenda items at my fingertips. I highly recommend keeping a journal, because a life worth living is a life worth recording. Even better is using

a system that allows you to access what you need and/or want at exactly the right time.

Honorée Corder is an author, speaker, and personal transformation expert.

Scott Cramton (Twitter: @MurderMysteryCo)

www.grimprov.com

Identify your highest-leverage task each day and conquer it first.

Scott Cramton is the founder and CEO of The Murder Mystery Company, the most popular Murder Mystery Entertainment Company in the nation.

Dave Crenshaw (Twitter: @DaveCrenshaw)

www.davecrenshaw.com

You should set priorities and prioritize those tasks that need immediate attention. There are only 60 minutes in an hour. There are only 24 hours in a day. This simplistic statement is something we know academically, yet fight against in practice. Most try to fight the Truth of Time every day. Some fight it every hour. These people become time bankrupt, because they are constantly overspending time and playing a catch-up game. Yet others have learned to be at peace with the Truth of Time. They have come to accept it as the immovable truth that it is, and actually feel they are time wealthy. These people have put systems in place that allow them to smoothly manage unexpected emergencies. Allow me to share a few systems to help you be at peace with the Truth of Time: 1. Use a calendar. This may seem a ridiculously obvious suggestion. The truth is most people attempt to schedule tasks and appointments in their mind. This results in missed appointments, stress, confusion, and over-scheduling. Not using a calendar is a bit like trying to use a credit card for your time. 2. Under spend time. Make sure that all of your appointments are not back to back. Give yourself breathing room of 15 or 30 minutes; sometimes even an hour. If you find yourself unable to leave these gaps in your schedule, then push things off. Procrastinate as much as possible the things that are not necessary in the moment. Doing this will leave you the room to handle the unexpected. Ultimately, being at peace with the Truth of Time is a matter of you being truthful with yourself. While you are likely capable of doing anything you put your mind to doing,

you are not capable of doing it all at once. Finally, here are a few brief tips: take control over technology—your cell phone ringer (even on vibrate) doesn't need to be on all the time. You can turn off email notification on your computer as well. Become master over the nagging beeps and buzzes by creating some silence. Schedule what you can schedule—set regular times in the day and week to check your voicemail and email. Let others know you will be using that schedule so they know when to expect a reply. Focus on the person—when you switchtask with a computer, you simply lose efficiency. But if you switchtask on a human being, you additionally damage a relationship. Be present, listen carefully, and make sure everything has been taken care of before moving on.

Dave Crenshaw is the master of helping business owners triumph over chaos. His first book, The Myth of Multitasking: How 'Doing It All' Gets Nothing Done, has been published in six languages and is a time management best seller. His latest book, The Focused Business: How Entrepreneurs Can Triumph Over Chaos, is also a small business best seller.

Hugh Culver (Twitter: @hughculver)
www.hughculver.com

Every Friday I create my “Flight Plan” for the following week. It's a short list of what I must get done before the next Friday. The very act of creating my Flight Plan is a great exercise in prioritization, delegation, and saying “no”. The next trick is to keep returning to my Flight Plan after every interruption. After five years of using and teaching this system I'm convinced it's the most powerful discipline for overwhelmed high-achievers.

Hugh Culver researches, writes, and speaks about how to think better, plan smarter, and act now on what really matters.

Ludwina Dautovic (Twitter: @LudwinaDautovic)

www.SwitchedOnMediaGroup.com

I don't think about what needs to be done in the future today. I block out time in my calendar a day or two prior to it being completed and focus on it then. This means that my mind isn't filled with what's ahead of me, allowing me to be more productive in the now. It also puts a stop to overwhelm as I'm confident that my time has been allocated adequately for each project so I can put it out of my mind. It's a very freeing discipline. I also do it for my personal life. If there are major decisions that need to be made, I'll book in some "thinking" time for it.

Ludwina Dautovic is the host of the #1 iTunes podcast 'Switched On' and the founder of The Switched On Media Group which specialises in online, digital, and new media.

Barrie Davenport (Twitter: @coachbarrie)

www.workfromhomeduo.com

Before you go to bed at night, define the three most important tasks for the next day. These don't have to be your only tasks—just the three that are non-negotiable. Define your most productive time of day, and knock out those tasks during that time if possible. When you are working on the tasks, remove all possible distractions in order to focus intently on the work. If necessary, break the tasks down to smaller chunks, and set a timer to work for 30 minutes to an hour. Allow yourself a break, and then set the timer again. Repeat until you've completed these primary tasks for your day.

Barrie Davenport is the co-founder of LiveBoldandBloom.com.

Christina Daves (Twitter: @prforanyone)

www.PRforAnyone.com

My best tip is to determine what time of day you are most productive and kick butt during that time. I have found that I am most productive from 6:00 a.m. to noon. I'm up, fresh, creative, and that is the time I make crazy things happen. I do

more in those hours than people probably do all week. Harness your productivity time and focus on that to make the best use of your time.

Christina Daves is the author of the bestselling book, PR for Anyone: 100+ Affordable Ways to Easily Create Buzz for Your Business and the CEO and founder of PR for Anyone®.

Ryan Delk (Twitter: @delk)

www.gumroad.com

The default length of a meeting or call—both internally and externally—should be 20 minutes, anything longer should be an exception. It's remarkable how much you can accomplish in 20 minutes, especially if all parties go into the meeting with the understanding that you only have 20 minutes. Even if you're just moving from 30-minute meetings to 20-minute meetings, you can fit in four to six more meetings, calls, or appointments in a day. Over the course of a year, that's more than 1,000 more opportunities you are buying yourself. Huge!

Ryan Delk leads Growth at Gumroad, where he helps empower creators of all shapes and sizes—from Eminem to Coldplay to Bon Jovi—to sell their work directly to their audience, he was previously at Square, the iHub Nairobi, and Savannah Fund.

Desiree Doubrox

www.AnEmpoweredWoman.com

Remember, no matter how rich or how poor, how smart or how dumb, what religion, color, creed, or sex you are. We all ONLY have 24 hours in a day! The only difference is how we use that non-recurring asset called time. Use it wisely and it will reward you handsomely.

Founder, publisher, and producer of An Empowered Woman and Let's Talk Success magazine. Speaker, author, radio and TV show host. Entrepreneur for life!

Elisa Doucette (Twitter: @elisadoucette)

www.craftyourcontent.com

No Night Screens—other than my Kindle, I try to institute a stern rule in my household, that screens should be off by 9

PM. No games, no TV, no laptops, no work...everyone either has to sit there and talk to each other or curl up with a good book and start decompressing their day. Amazing how easy it is to get to bed at a reasonable hour when you start relaxing early enough at night. It also gives you a deadline to finish the day's tasks, for those of us not being clocked for our too-many hours spent on work.

Elisa Doucette is an internationally published writer, editor to a collection of the internet's top creators, and founder of Craft Your Content.

Chris Ducker (Twitter: @chrisducker)

www.chrisducker.com

I have one very easy to follow time management strategy. It could also be classed as a productivity tip. I simply put everything on my schedule. That's it. Everything I do on a day-to-day basis gets put on my schedule. 30-minutes of social media—on the schedule. 45-minutes of email management—on the schedule. Catching up with my virtual team—on the schedule. Quiet time to contemplate and plan—on the schedule. Bottom line, if it doesn't get scheduled it doesn't get done.

Chris Ducker is a serial entrepreneur, international keynote speaker, bestselling author, as well as a popular business blogger and podcaster.

John Lee Dumas (Twitter: @JohnLeeDumas)

www.EOFire.com

The morning ritual that has become sacred to me is a 35 minute power walk first thing. Getting outside, breathing the fresh air, clearing my mind, and resetting my focus all results in a powerful start to an amazing day. Also, the Pomodoro method has been essential in my productivity in 2015. Parkinson's law explains how 'work expands so as to fill the time available for its completion' and I have found that 100% the truth. By limiting the time I have to work on projects using the Pomodoro timer, I have seen my focus and efficiency skyrocket!

John Lee Dumas is the founder and host of EntrepreneurOnFire, an award winning podcast revealing the journey of today's most inspiring entrepreneurs seven days a week. EntrepreneurOnFire generates over \$250,000 a month in revenue & offers a free 15-day course on podcasting at FreePodcastCourse.com.

Jess Ekstrom (Twitter: @HeadbandsOfHope)
www.JessEkstrom.com

As an entrepreneur, it's so easy to get out of bed in the morning and go straight into your lengthy to-do list. But I've found the days I jump straight into work, I'm not as productive and my energy burns quickly. Instead I get in some kind of morning workout, even if it's only 30 minutes. During the day I feel more energized and therefore get more done. If I ever start to feel tired or unmotivated, instead of pouring another cup of coffee, I'll take a short walk outside and get some fresh air.

Jess Ekstrom is the founder and CEO of Headbands of Hope, a company that gives headbands to girls undergoing chemotherapy and also funds childhood cancer research. She's also the author of The Freshman Fabulous: The Girl's Guide to College and keynote speaker at campuses and companies.

Sean Ellis (Twitter: @seanellis)
www.growthhackers.com

I've always worked in startups where there is never enough time to do everything I want to do. So my approach to productivity is to spend about a half an hour each morning creating a new list of three key items to complete that day that are based on the objectives that are important to me at that moment. I then work on these items in addition to any commitments I've already made for the day. This approach can be a bit haphazard, but keeps me adaptable to new learnings that happen every day in a startup.

Founder/CEO of GrowthHackers.com. Was first marketer at Dropbox, LogMeIn, and Lookout.

Hal Elrod (Twitter: @HalElrod)
www.MiracleMorningBook.com

My #1 key to simplifying time management and creating extraordinary productivity (in the areas that matter most) is starting each day with the ultimate morning success ritual (known as The Miracle Morning). This simple daily ritual is made up of the six most effective and proven personal development practices, memorably organized into the Life S.A.V.E.R.S. (Silence, Affirmations, Visualization, Exercise, Reading, Scribing). The premise of The Miracle Morning is to wake up and start each day with the discipline of dedicating time to personal development, so that you can become the person you need to be to create the most extraordinary life you can imagine, and do so faster than you may currently believe is possible. While most people focus on “doing” more to achieve more, The Miracle Morning is about focusing on “becoming” more so that you can start doing less, to achieve more.

Hal Elrod is the #1 bestselling author of what's being widely regarded as one of the most life-changing books ever written, The Miracle Morning: The Not-So-Obvious Secret Guaranteed to Transform Your Life...Before 8AM.

Kyle Eschenroeder (Twitter: @kyleschen)
www.StartupBros.com

I've tried all the “strategies”, only one has worked. My philosophy is that being productive for the sake of being productive is ridiculous. I care about moving my life forward, not maximizing some abstract level of productivity. So the first thing I do is get out of bed and go work out. While working out I identify the two most important things I can do that day. I write them down on an index card. That index card is used to write down other things I need to accomplish during the day. I can't use more space than that one card. So two things: 1. Get energy to put into the thing (work out). 2. Identify the thing(s). This sets you up to be proactive. And being proactive makes you the best kind of productive.

Kyle Eschenroeder, founder of StartupBros.com.

Jason Falls (Twitter: @JasonFalls)
www.jasonfalls.com

The single-smartest thing I've ever done to manage time is actually put "Work" in my calendar as a meeting. That time is booked, it is precious and no one gets to hijack it. Whether I need to write a blog post, a strategy for a client, or research a topic I'm writing a presentation about, it goes on the calendar so I have uninterrupted time to devote to that task.

Jason Falls is strategist, author, and speaker who is the SVP of Digital Strategy at Elasticity, a marketing agency.

Jon Ferrara (Twitter: @Jon_Ferrara)

www.nimble.com

You can achieve anything you want if you remember the three P's of Success. Passion, Plan and Purpose. Find your Passion, Create a Plan to Achieve it, Make it Your Purpose Everyday.

Jon Ferrara is the pioneer and creator of #CRM solutions, CEO - Nimble, Founder of GoldMine. Interests: #SocialSelling, Social Business, Customer Lifecycle, Acquisition & Retention.

Ezra Firestone (Twitter: @ezrafirestone)

www.smartmarketer.com

Time is a concept. You have as much of it as you need for the things you decide are important enough to spend your time on. Take complete action. Once you decide to take action, fully commit to that action and don't second guess yourself during the process.

Ezra is an eCommerce entrepreneur, business educator, and a lover of life.

Pat Flynn (Twitter: @PatFlynn)

www.smartpassiveincome.com

I batch process as much as I can. From blog posts to podcast episodes, creating videos to answering emails, I focus on staying productive by maximizing my output on one particular type of content in long stretches of time. This reduces transition time between various activities and it allows me to continue to drip feed content over time to my audience while I'm busy creating new content.

Pat Flynn is a serial entrepreneur who is most well known for his work on SmartPassiveIncome.com, a website he uses to document his various income generation experiments online so that others can learn from both his wins, and his failures. He's fully transparent with everything, including how much money he's making from each of his online ventures.

Adam Franklin (Twitter: @Franklin_Adam)

www.bluewiremedia.com.au

My best advice is to schedule time in your day for exercising and thinking, ideally at the same time. Running, or walking, is perfect for this. Listen to podcasts or audiobooks whilst jogging and make sure you've got Evernote so you can stop and take notes when ideas and inspiration strike!

Adam Franklin is the co-author of Web Marketing That Works and social media speaker.

Matt Frazier (Twitter: @NoMeatAthlete)

www.NoMeatAthlete.com

When it comes to content, be a producer, not a consumer. If you can quit watching TV, stop spending time on news sites, and quit wasting “just a few seconds” 20 times a day on Facebook and Twitter, you’ll be amazed at how much time you free up. Not to mention all the negativity and fear-mongering you miss out on.

Matt Frazier is a vegan ultramarathoner and founder of the No Meat Athlete movement.

Randy Gage (Twitter: @Randy_Gage)

www.randygage.com

I always start with the most important thing on my priority list. If you didn’t spend your week working on the most important thing, it was a week wasted.

Randy Gage is the author of nine books on success, including the New York Times bestseller, Risky Is the New Safe.

Todd Garland (Twitter: @toddo)

www.buysellads.com

I have two files on my desktop: today.txt and this-month.txt. Every day, while riding home on the train, I update the contents of both files. When I start work the next day, I have an immediately actionable list of things I would like to accomplish for the day waiting for me in today.txt.

Todd Garland is the founder of BuySellAds, the monetization solution of choice for high-quality content creators

Victoria Gibson (Twitter: @VictoriaGibson1)

www.victoriagibson.com

Schedule everything and add alarms to your phone. If it’s not scheduled it ain’t real! Also, start with those things you least want to do, but will make the most difference. Google Calendar is my app for this.

Victoria Gibson is a success mentor to women who want create massive results online.

Erin Giles (Twitter: @erinmgiles)

www.eringiles.com

I recently learned the best way for me to remain productive (and sane) as a work from home mom of two is to give myself an hour of alone time every morning. It's the best gift I can give myself, my work, and my family.

Erin Giles is the founder of End Sex Trafficking Day, a published author, and an entrepreneurial coach that helps women with big ideas make real progress.

Charlie Gilkey (Twitter: @CharlieGilkey)

www.ProductiveFlourishing.com

Define your priorities and take consistent action on them. Too many people have 17 “priorities” (which means they really have none) that they erratically take action on, with the end result that they feel like they’re doing a lot but getting nowhere. Better to define the things that truly matter and commit to taking action on them regularly and consistently than to be stuck in the binge-crash-regret-recommit cycle.

Charlie Gilkey is a bestselling author, business advisor, and the founder of Productive Flourishing, one of the top websites on planning, productivity, and strategy for creative people.

Douglas Goldstein, CFP® (Twitter: @RichAsAKing)

www.RichAsAKing.com

Only Do it Twice: As an entrepreneur, investor, parent, boss, or someone who just wants to succeed, keep your eyes out for new ideas and approaches. Once you find something you like, stick with it – metaphorically, not literally. The key to success is not for you to do the same thing (no matter how successful it is) again and again. True success is creating a system and delegating the work to someone else, leaving you the time to find other great ideas. Here's how it works: Step 1. Find a new idea. That's all. Step 2. Once you've latched on to something new, build a system to allow someone (or something) else to do it. The second... and LAST time... that you will do that process will be when you are making it into a system that either a staff member, virtual assistant, or computer can do from then on.

Douglas Goldstein, CFP® is the co-author of the best-selling book Rich As A King: How the Wisdom of Chess Can Make You a Grandmaster of Investing, and he's a personal financial advisor specializing in people living outside the United States who want to have U.S. brokerage accounts.

Mitch Gordon (Twitter: @MitchGordonGo)

www.GoOverseas.com

1) Only check email once, twice a day maximum. You need slow time to think, reflect and come up with new ideas. The switching costs of going back and forth between email and other tasks can affect focus in very negative ways. Focus on one thing at a time. Studies show that multi-tasking is actually counter productive. 2) Only do what only YOU can do. Everything else? Delegate! It's the only way you'll truly be able to grow your business. 3) Automate and come up with systems as much as you can. Always think: Is there a way to automate what I'm doing right now? 4) Have a Digital Detox, tech free day. It will help you be more productive in every possible way. You need time to recharge.

Mitch Gordon is the CEO/ co-founder of Go Overseas and the Entrepreneur in Residence at the UC Berkeley Haas School of Business. His most recent company, Go Overseas, has become the most trusted resource for researching international education programs around the world.

Corrina Gordon-Barnes (Twitter: @ CorrinaGB)

www.youinspireme.co.uk

Identify the stubborn task on your To Do list—the one you keep procrastinating about. Now, identify the BELIEFS that are blocking you from moving forward. For example, let's say your task is “write new About page” you might identify blocking beliefs like “they’ll think I’m boring” or “I don’t know what to say”. Then, imagine you cannot believe those thoughts. It’s like your brain is now wired differently and it wouldn’t even occur to you to think those thoughts. What would be your next action step, if you were free from those thoughts? If your next action seems complex, break it down into 10 or 30 minute chunks and notice what it’s like to move ahead without the stressful thoughts in the way.

Corrina Gordon-Barnes supports self-employed men and women.

Jason Gracia (Twitter:)

www.TheExpertAgency.com

My productivity philosophy is simple: Do what matters. People are incredibly gifted at staying busy all hours of the day doing the trivial, doing the things that keep them away from the things they know truly matter. The problem? What matters is often what scares us. It’s those ideas that push us beyond our comfort zones that are so important, ideas most of us avoid at all costs. But our businesses change, our lives change, when we stop avoiding the discomfort of progress and begin to do what matters.

Jason Gracia is the author of Shifting the Balance and founder of The Expert Agency, the only full-service agency of its kind to offer the tools and training experts needed to build profitable online businesses around their unique experience and expertise.

Tim Grahl (Twitter: @timgrahl)

www.timgrahl.com

I always start with the “why” for the project I’m working on. I have to have a solid, deeply felt reason for why this project is important to me and to the world. Once I have that, all of the other time management stuff I do—getting up at 4am, turning off email, avoiding social media, planning my day, etc—becomes much, much easier.

Tim Grahl is the author of Your First 1000 Copies: The Step-by-Step Guide to Marketing Your Book.

Dan Granger

www.OxfordRoad.com

Nozbe and Evernote have been great tools for me. But the sheer act of placing thoughts, ideas, and plans in something external has been critical. Even if just on paper. Not just because it allows me to order my steps, but also because it serves as a ventilation system for my mind. With back to back meetings all day, it is impossible to keep everything in my head and still be strategic. Getting out allows me to make sure everything is dealt with appropriately.

Dan Granger is the CEO and founder of Oxford Road, a Los Angeles based Ad Agency helping online tech companies scale their customer acquisition efforts through advertising on channels like Podcast, Radio, and National Television.

Jen Groover (Twitter: @jengroover)

www.jengroover.com

This is probably coming at a different angle than most, but energy management is my focus on how I approach time management and productivity. My mental clarity is my most valuable asset to increase my productivity, I do this by being mindful of the foods that I eat, the thoughts I think, the hours I sleep, and how I spend time outside of the work space. I consciously choose to surround myself by other positive and productive people, I refuse to allow drama in my life (or people that create it). I watch very little television, but when I

do, it is positive and inspiring content. I am also conscious of what I read and listen to. Most people are oblivious to how critically important their health and emotional wellness is to their productivity and efficiency. Your body is a machine. Fuel it properly (physically, mentally, emotionally and spiritually) and you will naturally be more efficient.

Jen Groover is a serial entrepreneur, author, motivational speaker, TV host, and UN delegate.

Garrett B. Gunderson (Twitter: @wealthfactory)

www.WealthFactory.com

Start your day with the three “E”s: exercise, education and enlightenment. Exercising, for five minutes or 50 minutes, will jumpstart your day. Next, read or listen to something in your area of expertise. Then create space in your mind through meditation, gratitude, prayer, or whatever will help you focus and give purpose to your day. This routine will help you stay abundant in times that feel scarce, and creative in times that feel constrained.

Garrett Gunderson, NY Times Bestselling author, is a champion for finding cash for entrepreneurs without having to work harder, take any additional risk or sacrifice by spending less.

Chad Hamzeh

www.dsv2.com

My father passed away at the age of 64, back in 2011, after a battle with cancer. In his final two years I helped him with a great deal of what he was going through. However, I was also working about 12-14 hours per day at the time. The days leading up, the day of, and the days after he passed, I was answering support emails and doing other tasks that, really, someone else could have been doing. And although I was by his side, this was a wake up call that something needed to change. So, the one tip I can give, is a promise I made to myself at that time. I promised to never do another task that I didn't enjoy, and that someone else could do. When you put those two filters on your to-do list, and you're honest and disciplined about it, you'll realize that almost every actual task

can be done by someone else, and for cheaper than what your time and energy are worth. And this isn't just reserved for "\$20/hour tasks". I find that the more valuable tasks, the "triple-digit-per-hour" things, often give you the biggest ROI when you hire a real pro to handle them. Doing this frees your time and energy to work on the REALLY truly important things in your business, and of course, your life.

Chad Hamzeh is founder of DSV2 Media, where he manages over \$20 Million in online ad spend per year. He is considered by many as the "go to guy" for online traffic generation.

Craig A. Handley (Twitter: @CraigAHandley)
www.ListenUpEspanol.com

I read a lot of books and/or articles, and I'm part of many Mastermind groups where ideas and information are shared pretty freely amongst people who already are successful. I believe to be truly successful you cannot be on the hamster wheel. You need time to think and explore. This leads to a multitude of projects. We plan up to four projects per quarter per project manager to selectively invest in and plan a strategy around those projects. This means that no one person can be involved in more than four projects so we may be able to have six or seven going in a single quarter. Other ideas might be great but are delayed. So one key to being productive is to focus. We then practice committed action to hit timelines and goals of the project and I check on the progress of those projects with a 15 minute call each day where we share progress, challenges, areas we need help, or areas we're available to give help.

Craig Handley is an entrepreneur, public speaker, and philanthropist. An expert in marketing, sales, and brand expansion, Handley is the CEO and founder of the hugely successful "Listen Up Espanol," which was named #1 in Business Products and Service (#27 overall) on Inc. Magazine's 500/5000 list.

Jordan Harbinger (Twitter: @theartofcharm)
www.theartofcharm.com

Use a calendar and schedule your entire day into 15-minute blocks. It sounds like a pain, but this will set you up in the 95th percentile as far as organization goes. If it's not on the calendar, it doesn't get done. If it's on the calendar, it gets done no matter what. Use this not just for appointments, but workouts, calls, email blocks, etc. This is the difference between people who work for eight hours and get eight hours of work done, and people who work for 20 hours and get eight hours of work done.

Jordan Harbinger is the co-founder of The Art of Charm and host of The Art of Charm Podcast, a school that teaches networking and relationship-development skills.

Verne Harnish (Twitter: @theGrowthGuy)
www.scalingup.com

“Routine sets you free” is the mantra underpinning our tools and approach in Scaling Up companies, including the 15 minute daily huddle with your team (and spouse!) that will save everyone collectively over an hour each day and allow you to avoid minor train wrecks (that grow into bigger problems) and take advantage of immediate opportunities. “If you want to move faster, pulse faster”.

Verne Harnish is founder of EO; CEO of Gazelles; and author of Scaling Up (Rockefeller Habits 2.0).

Kevin Harrington (Twitter: @theGrowthGuy)
www.kevinharrington.tv

Before I decide to take on a new project, I analyze it...How much of my time will this take, and what is my financial upside potential. I create a “dollar per minute” analysis, hopefully a Million Dollar per week upside.

Kevin Harrington, the inventor of the Infomercial, best selling author, original investor on Shark Tank and founder and chairman of As Seen On TV, Inc.

Sherisse Hawkins (Twitter: @gobeneaththeink)
www.beneaththeink.com

Determine the most important thing against clear criteria of what you want to measure, then make sure you focus on those

activities first. Favorite app: Assistant.to. Philosophy: “If you can’t be positive about it start over.” Personal ritual: find time for 10 minute “mini” meditation every day. Exercising makes you 50% more productive. Not exercising is -75% (*negative 75%*).

Sherisse is a former Walt Disney Imagineer and engineering exec whose love of technology and creativity spurred her to become an entrepreneur in the digital publishing space.

Deacon Hayes (Twitter: @deaconhayes)

www.WellKeptWallet.com

I have learned that the best way to get something done is to have it on my Google Calendar. If I get a task that is time sensitive, I assign it to a free slot on my calendar. When that time approaches, I get a reminder on my smartwatch (moto 360), 10 minutes before I need to start the task. If I am doing something that i can’t break away from, I then reassign that task to a later time. This has helped me be way more productive as well as it has ensured that tasks don’t slip through the cracks.

Deacon Hayes is the founder and CEO of Well Kept Wallet which provides financial coaching and personal finance curriculum.

Carl Daniel Heaton (Twitter: @webcoursesbkk)

www.webcoursesbangkok.com

Having a lot of people wanting meetings, consulting, or just to meetup puts a lot of strain on my assistant to juggle my time. One of the most useful pages I have on my website is a live feed to my schedule. I then ask people wanting my time to recommend two to three times that suit them and we can then schedule them in accordingly. As for productivity tools look no further than Trello, it is an excellent service and works well with any industry for project management.

Carl is the founder of Web Courses International Design School, a UX consultant, speaker, and author.

Todd Henry (Twitter: @toddhenry)

www.toddhenry.com

Never sacrifice long-term effectiveness on the altar of short-term efficiency. Do something every day that will reap rewards down the road.

Todd Henry is the author of Die Empty and The Accidental Creative and the founder of Accidental Creative.

Greg Hickman (Twitter: @gjhickman)

www.greghickman.me

I live by the philosophy that if it's not on the calendar, it doesn't exist. I plan my days the evening before and I wake up and begin my Miracle Morning which I learned from Hal Elrod. The Miracle Morning has been critical to starting my day on my own terms but my calendar is sacred. I make sure to block at least two to four hours per day to spend on my highest priority for the day. I have scheduled breaks and time for email and meetings. Managing your calendar and not letting it manage you allows me to be proactive instead of reactive. If you're always reacting you're likely never to get the main priorities accomplished.

Greg Hickman is the founder of Mobile Marketing Engine, a mobile marketing agency and education company for small businesses. He is the author of The SMS Marketing Handbook

and writes about entrepreneurship and building stuff on his blog.

Ryan Holmes (Twitter: @invoker)

www.hootsuite.com

Keep emails short and sweet. Over the years, I've trained myself to write three-sentence emails (a concept expounded here), leaving out the fluff and keeping only the most essential points. It saves my time and it saves the reader's time.

Whenever I get a long email from a new employee, I ask myself if things could have been expressed more concisely. He or she has spent a lot of their own time composing it and now it's consuming a lot of my time, as well, since I have to read it. And time is often a boss's most valuable commodity. Rather than send long emails, save more substantial communication for a phone call or meeting.

Ryan Holmes is the founder and CEO of HootSuite, a social media management tool for businesses.

Lewis Howes (Twitter: @lewishowes)

www.lewishowes.com

Focus on what you are great at and hire everyone else to do the rest.

Lewis Howes is a best selling author, entrepreneur, and former professional Arena League football player. He is the host of The School of Greatness, a talk show distributed as a podcast.

Danny Iny (Twitter: @DannyIny)

www.FirepoleMarketing.com

The big lie of time management is that you can't manage time, but you can manage focus and energy. In other words, an hour will never be a minute longer or shorter than an hour, but what you can accomplish in that hour is dependent on your energy and inspiration. So how do you create an effective work routine? Simple: by choosing what you want it to be, rather than letting others dictate it for you. Except that most people do exactly the opposite, through one simple (terrible) habit: they check their email first thing in the morning, often before they even get out of bed. This means that their focus and

energy are going where others are directing it, rather than where they stand to make the greatest impact. The much better approach is to stay away from email until you've accomplished at least one thing that you feel is worthwhile, and only then turn your attention to what everyone else needs from you. I can't say that I'm always 100% successful at this, but I do it most days, and those are the days when I accomplish the most.

Danny Iny, founder of marketing education firm Firepole Marketing, is the bestselling author of Engagement from Scratch! and The Audience Revolution.

Jared Kleinert (Twitter: @jaredkleinert)
www.2billionunder20.com

Too many people search for quick fixes, time hacks, and other ways to save a few minutes here and shave off a meeting there. However, perhaps the biggest “hack” of them all is to really be conscious about all of your decisions, at a macro level and at a micro level. Personally, I don't watch TV, go to the movies more than once a quarter normally, use Snapchat or Instagram, have Netflix, and there's probably a half dozen other things most people would do that I don't. In terms of time management specifically, I save two to three hours easily, and most likely more, per day from not engaging in these activities. Therefore, at a micro level, if a meeting runs over, or I check email too much (which I do), or get lazy and decide to take a half day off every once in a while, although I feel guilty at the time, I know I've already saved a ton of time. The same principle applies in my decisions of whether or not to go to university. Last year, I decided to take a gap year between high school and college, and “saved” 40+ hours a week that would have been allocated to studying and classes, and instead applied it towards growing my businesses. When I got into NYU this year, I decided that I'd take another gap year this upcoming year because, at a macro level, I wanted to be efficient with my time in scaling my work. I could try to balance school and growing multiple companies, but by taking another gap year, I've saved thousands of hours my peers won't in terms of applying it to my career. For some, that investment of time may be a great productivity “hack” long

term because they may save years of corporate ladder climbing with better degrees, connections, and skills some universities provide. However, for me personally (and this may change... it's all about being deliberate each and every year, and with every decision), it's more productive to postpone school, saving lots of time (not to mention money) for me as a young entrepreneur specifically.

Jared Kleinert is the co-author of 2 Billion Under 20, and co-founder of the non-profit of the same name.

Luke Lorio (Twitter: @lukeiorio)

www.iPECcoaching.com

You can't manage time—meaning minutes are 60 seconds long and hours are 60 minutes long. That's not going to change. But you can manage choices. When you're clear on your choices—priorities and steps to achieve those priorities, then you become highly productive and satisfied with how you spend your time. Top three things/schedule blocking—every day I begin by looking at the top three things I want to accomplish that day, in priority order. For anything that is non negotiable, you need to practice schedule blocking—meaning, even before you begin your week really, you should block off chunks of time where you can get work done. You should never interrupt those blocks for meetings or distractions of any kind unless it's an urgent AND important issue, and even then, you should consider whether it can really wait until after you come up for air. Head Start—at least three times a week, think about your next day, think about what you will do first, and what's your starting point for that activity/task. Write that starting point down. The following morning, instead of wasting time on how to begin, you can just dive in. You start the day with a little momentum.

Luke Lorio is a performance coach, speaker, and the CEO and president of the Institute for Professional Excellence in Coaching (iPEC), the nation's leading coach training organization.

Dave Jackson (Twitter: @learntopodcast)

www.schoolofpodcasting.com

I use an office away from my home. This helps me focus when I'm there to do work. I use asana.com to create a "to do" list and I know when I'm in my office what I need to do. I am laser focused. This also allows me to focus more on my family when I'm home. I actually work less hours, but because I'm more focused, I get more done.

Dave Jackson has been podcasting since 2005 when he founded the School of Podcasting. He is the author of the book More Podcast Money, a regular contributor to Podertainment magazine. You can find him at schoolofpodcasting.com.

Abel James (Twitter: @fatburnman)

www.fatburningman.com

Get your blood pumping for at least a minute or two every day. Quick workouts give a huge boost to energy and feed the brain with the oxygen you need to take over the world.

Abel James is a bestselling author, musician, and host of the #1-rated health podcast, Fat-Burning Man.

Mitch Joel (Twitter: @mitchjoel)

www.mitchjoel.com

Your mobile device? Turn off ALL notifications. Only look when you have time or when you have scheduled time to deal with it. Granted, I have a unique tone for my wife, but that's about it. Don't let technology control you...you control your technology.

Mitch Joel is president of Mirum—a global digital marketing agency operating in close to 20 countries. His first book, Six Pixels of Separation, named after his successful blog and podcast is a business and marketing bestseller. His second book, CTRL ALT Delete, was named one of the best business books of 2013 by Amazon.com.

Nicole Jolie (Twitter: @SkinByRadiance)

www.loveradianceskincare.com

I chunk my day, using Asana and Evernote to keep in contact with my assistant and keep track of what I'm accomplishing. I write down everything I've done so that I'm able to keep track of my time. I don't "plan" my day unless I have something

that is scheduled, but rather, I look at the end result of what I want to happen for the week, month, quarter, and year and I focus on completing that milestone. I'm finding the less "to do" superfluous bling bling I have to deal with, the easier my business runs. I have to get out of my own way and the way of my business for it to run efficiently and effectively. I stay productive by hiring out for projects I know can get done faster and with more ease so that I am able to continually focus on growing my business. Morning ritual? Pee first. Then drink water. Pee again. Drink coffee. Walk Fantastic Scraptasic. Pee. :) Favorite mobile app? Lifetime Fitness because I can schedule my workouts based on the instructor. Very cool app. For scheduling things to do? Asana and Evernote. Recommended resource? Fiverr. Caffeine. Meditation. Breathing. :)

Nicole Jolie, an entrepreneur since the age of 13 when she decided to become legally emancipated and start her own cookie company called Coup de Grace now owns Radiance Naturally Advanced SkinCare her own line of skin care for athletes.

Colby B. Jubenville, Ph.D. (Twitter: @drjubenville)
www.redherringinc.com

I work with CEO's, COO's and CFO's, CMO's, and sales people throughout the country. The first question I ask is, "What is the highest value of your time?" Most of the time they pause and sit back in their chair and say, "I don't know if I can answer that." And it's what every entrepreneur should be asking themselves. That's when the coaching starts. To know what the highest value of your time is, one must first know their dominant focus or the one thing they want to accomplish in the business or life. I then ask if they can do three things a day, five a week, 60 a month towards a dominant focus in their business or life. What you will find is if you know your dominant focus and the highest value of your time and then build a system to bring that to action—it can and will happen.

Colby B. Jubenville, Ph.D. is principal of Red Herring Innovation and Design and an accomplished author, speaker, professor, entrepreneur, and inventor.

Aunia Kahn (Twitter: @auniakahn)

www.auniakahn.com

Time management is a very important aspect in how our lives are lived each day. With so many transformations in the world today, such as the reliance on technology advancements and how quick everything moves, we need to work diligently in managing time effectively, efficiently, and joyfully to get the most out of life. As a person who's fast-paced and enjoys her job, I find it essential to schedule time to recuperate and relax because it makes the whole cycle of work and play so much more productive. I start my days with exercise, a good healthy breakfast, and I walk my three rescue dogs to help me wake up, clear my mind, and prepare for the long day ahead. I schedule my week on Sundays and create a plan for the week ahead based in deadlines, personal interests, and while also leaving room for changes, and things that might come up unexpectedly. I always get out of the way the things I don't enjoy doing before I jump head long into the things I find more joyful. I break up my day by heading outdoors for a few moments to take in some fresh air—even if raining or cold (but not if we are having tornadoes *wink*).

Aunia Kahn is internally aware and an exhibited figurative artist, photographer, published author, creative entrepreneur, and inspirational speaker. She is the owner of Aunia Kahn LLC, Alexi Era Gallery, Lokreign Publishing, and the Create & Inspire Podcast/Blog.

Braden Kelley (Twitter: @innovate)

www.bradenkelley.com

I achieve maximum productivity by utilizing a single input, multiple output content creation approach, and by focusing on exerting the minimal effort possible for maximum effect on the tasks before me. Over-delivery on one task usually leads to under-delivery on another when you're super busy, and so over-delivery is to be avoided.

Braden Kelley is a popular author, innovation and change management keynote speaker, and co-founder of InnovationExcellence.com.

Dave Kerpen (Twitter: @DaveKerpen)

www.LikeableLocal.com

If it's not in my calendar, it won't get done. But if it is in my calendar, it will get done. I schedule out every 15 minutes of every day to conduct meetings, review materials, write, and do any activities I need to get done. And while I take meetings with just about anyone who wants to meet with me, I reserve just one hour a week for these "office hours". People can schedule time at <http://ScheduleDave.com>, and I can get the important things done—the rest of my calendar.

Dave Kerpen is the NY Times bestselling author of three books, the co-founder & chairman of Likeable Media, and the founder & CEO of Likeable Local.

Travis Ketchum (Twitter: @TravisKetchum)

www.ContestDomination.com

I leverage marketing automation tools, as well as a few key philosophies to maximize my productivity. Tools: Infusionsoft and ScheduleOnce. Being able to communicate with our customers and prospects based on their actions and the path they choose to take through our products and services is huge. By designing a funnel that accounts for contingencies, our offers are simultaneously more human and more effective. By using a scheduling service, my higher profile calls and meetings slot into my available time based on a few simple business rules and the availability on my calendar. No more endless "when are you available?" email loops. To keep myself sharp, I've found that being more focused and actually spending less time in front of the computer makes me more effective than pouring endless hours into email etc. I've found there to be diminishing returns to raw screen time, so breaking up that time into smaller sprints and having a regular workout regimen does wonders to boost productivity.

Travis Ketchum is the founder & CEO of ContestDomination™, the most powerful and proven lead generator for sales.

Phyllis Khare (Twitter: @PhyllisKhare)

www.TimeBliss.Me

I just had no choice, you see: I was simply forced into finding a better way of managing myself, my tasks, and my time. It was either that or go crazy, or completely give up on my career—or quit writing my books. None of those were an option, so I was forced to invent a new approach, one that actually enabled me to take control over my schedule, instead of constantly being controlled by it. You know how they say: evolve or die? Luckily, I evolved. With no other options and with my back against the wall, I developed a new way to use Google Calendar to schedule my day...and it ended up transforming my life.

Phyllis Khare is co-founder of Social Media Manager School, creator of TimeBliss.ME, and author of Social Media Marketing eLearning Kit for Dummies and co-author of Facebook Marketing All-In-One for Dummies.

Shannon Kinney (Twitter: @shannonkin)

www.dreamlocal.com

Rather than being daunted by the sheer volume of items on my “to do” list, I focus on bite-sized elements. I track tasks in big groups (i.e. Client Work, Company Needs, etc), and then for each I review each week “What’s the next action?”. So rather than say: “Build new training department” it will say something more like “Interview three top candidates for training role Friday”. This way I’m able to see where I can have the best impact and keep all of my projects moving. I also spent time and thought to create my system of lists, task assignments, and trust that it will work. I don’t lose sleep wondering if I’ve remembered everything, because I trust my system. Focusing on the next action has helped me get more done, faster, and I believe my quality of work is higher because I’m not daunted. I’m inspired to take that step!

Founder and Client Success Officer at Dream Local Digital, digital marketing strategy development, management, and implementation for thousands of companies.

Jake Kloberdanz (Twitter: @jakekloberdanz)

www.onehopewine.com

Follow where your energy takes you and put one foot in front of the other. Before you know it you'll be looking at the view from the top of the mountain. It's less about how big the steps are along the way and more about continuing to take steps in the right direction. To know the right direction you must continue to look up toward the longterm vision and not always be heads down looking at the short term steps. Others have made the quest before you, so be not afraid, but respect what it will take and be humble along the way.

Jake Kloberdanz, CEO and founder of ONEHOPE, creator of and expert in Cause-centric Commerce.

Donna Kozik (Twitter: @DonnaKozik)
www.FreeBookPlanner.com

Practice putting in the big rocks first. In other words, do your most important and revenue-generating items as soon as you can. My best practice is to write for 20 minutes using the Evernote app on my iPad as soon as I get up when energy and ideas are fresh. These tools make it so easy I don't even have to get out of bed to be productive.

Donna Kozik is an award-winning author, speaker, and creator of Write a Book in a Weekend.

Vasavi Kumar, LMSW (Twitter: @askvasavi)
www.vasavikumar.com

Get clear on your priorities. The rest will follow.

Vasavi Kumar is an advocate of liberty. She can be contacted at www.vasavikumar.com.

Jessica Kupferman (Twitter: @jesskupferman)
www.ladybusiness.biz

I don't think one tool is the answer. I think the key to staying productive, on task, and organized is being DIGITAL. Whatever tool you tend to use, whatever you gravitate to, make sure it's online so you can never lose it, so you can share it with others, and so you can receive notifications. Digital is the way to go. A notebook can't remind you of anything and it's easily lost. I use a variety of things but mostly Google

Calendar and an iPhone, and I would be wandering around lost without both.

Jessica Kupferman is the founder of the popular podcasts Lady Business Radio and She Podcasts, and the founder of Podcasting School for Women. She has been a digital business consultant helping other entrepreneurs with their online businesses for over 15 years.

Brian Kurtz (Twitter:)

www.briankurtz.me

First, I write down three things I am grateful for every morning and I also write down three things that will make the day great. Plus two or three affirmations. Second, every piece of paper has a place...and my goal is to be able to put my hands on any piece of paper, idea, follow up item within one minute. Third, I write down “three wins” every day before I go to bed...no matter how good or how bad any day is, there are always three wins in every day. Tools used: 1) “Five Minute Journal” (book or app). 2) Workflowy, Swiftfile and I follow the principles of Barbara Hemphill (key books: *Taming The Paper Tiger at Work* and *Less Clutter, More Life*). 3) “Win Streak” (app).

Brian Kurtz is a serial direct marketer who never met a medium he didn't like. He spent 34 years building one of the leading direct marketing/publishing companies ever (Boardroom Inc.) and is now dedicated to direct marketing education, teaching the eternal truths of direct response marketing to marketers past, present and future.

Roger Lee (Twitter: @RogerLeap)

www.rogerleearts.com

I equate productivity with visioning. I always live by the motto “If you can see it, you can achieve it!”. I start each day with a prayer before starting my work. I pray for focus, strength, and vision. The vision helps me see my goals in real life form. It makes my goals tangible. I work hard to turn my visions into specific action steps. These steps turn into tasks and To-Do Lists. These lists help me stay productive each day. I always

have something new and exciting to work towards. The ultimate payoff is seeing my initial visions turn into realities.

Roger Lee is an award-winning artist, educator, speaker, and entrepreneur. He is the owner and director of Roger Lee Arts Academy, Roger Lee Arts & Entrepreneurship Conference, and Roger Lee Dance Company.

Lee LeFever (Twitter: @leelefever)

www.commoncraft.com

We've spent years at Common Craft creating a business that scales like a startup, but with only two employees. Time management and planning are key. Our philosophy comes down to the idea that you plant the garden you want to tend. We are very intentional about the seeds we plant because some plants may suck up all of your time without providing any nutrition.

Lee LeFever is a keynote speaker, founder of Common Craft, and author of The Art of Explanation.

Tammy Levent (Twitter: @TammyLevent)

www.tammylevent.com

As CEO of Elite Travel my days are filled with several things that I need to do. At the same time I also have several projects on the side such as training travel agents through my Travel Agent Success Kit, speaking at conferences worldwide and contributing to a number of publications. Needless to say, it's never a dull moment. I'm always asked how I do it all and it boils down to two simple things—First, I text myself a daily list of tasks I must complete before my work day is done and then as I complete them I delete them from my list. Second, if I don't have time to fit something in I'll either reschedule it for the next day or if I can I'll outsource it. In fact, outsourcing frees up a lot of time for me. I have a writer, a web designer, a graphic artist, other agents, and more that I can call on to handle tasks for me. If you need to free up time in your schedule I would highly recommend outsourcing. It doesn't cost as much as you might think and it will open up a world of possibilities for you.

Public speaker, renowned business woman, philanthropist, and mentor. Want to know more? Google Me!

Daniel J. Lewis (Twitter: @theRamenNoodle)

www.TheAudacitytoPodcast.com

Make appointments with yourself. I often struggle with getting around to do things. I get wrapped up in one project and forget the other things I need to do. That's where making and following my own calendar helps. Schedule time to work on nothing but that task that needs to be done. I even have "email processing" and "social-network participation" scheduled into my average days. This gives me dedicated time to focus on these tasks. It also gives me freedom in the rest of the day to avoid being distracted by those tasks because I know I have a set time for handling them.

Daniel creates training resources and podcasting tools (like My Podcast Reviews); offers one-on-one consulting and group training; is a keynote speaker on podcasting and social media; and Daniel hosts a network of award-nominated shows covering how to podcast (The Audacity to Podcast), clean-comedy (the Ramen Noodle), and the #1 unofficial podcast for ABC's hit drama Once Upon a Time (ONCE podcast).

Terry Lin (Twitter: @itsmeterrylin)

www.buildmyonlinestore.com

Anti-Social is a tool I've been using since 2012 to block social media websites to increase productivity. Once blocked, you must restart your computer or wait for the timer to expire before you can access the sites. You can also include custom domains like news, gossip, or forums that you frequent and know are a distraction.

Terry Lin is the founder of Build My Online Store, a podcast dedicated to help E-Commerce entrepreneurs grow their sales and traffic.

Rebecca Livermore (Twitter: @rlivermore)

www.professionalcontentcreation.com

I designed my ideal day and weigh out commitments against it. For example, my prime writing time is in the mornings, so I

avoid making appointments in the morning, since they would create an “un-ideal” day for me. I also have a theme for the day rather than doing multiple things each day. For instance, today the theme may be client work, and the theme tomorrow may be writing content for my own site. This keeps me focused and helps me get more done each day.

Rebecca Livermore is a bestselling author, content marketing consultant, and founder of Professional Content Creation.

Josh London (Twitter: @JoshLondonPPC)

www.ClickConvertProfit.com

I have a dedicated To-Do list that I print every morning with just the essential tasks I have to complete (sort emails, complete emails, complete reminders, etc.). I also use an app called Teux Deux to organize my projects.

Josh London is an online entrepreneur who helps organizations create and manage remarkable SEO and Paid Advertising campaigns.

David Long (Twitter: @Top10Manager)

www.MyEmployees.com

Get up early, and read as much as you can every day. I read three to four hours every day, and have for years. I attribute that to my becoming a multimillionaire. If you fail to learn new things, you will become “roadkill” in the path of your competitors.

Founder/CEO of MyEmployees, a 25 year-old firm in the Top 1% Worldwide in the Employee Engagement and Recognition industry. His firm specializes in helping managers build stronger, more engaging relationships with their team members, while linking the rewards and recognition program to the desired goals of the company.

Gary Loper (Twitter: @GaryLoper)

www.GaryLoper.com

The most important Time Management strategy I have discovered is investing 1% of your day in scheduling the next day’s activities. That is only 14 minutes a day. Surely investing 14 minutes before bed is a very beneficial habit.

Scheduling the next day, just before going to bed, has a couple of time saving benefits. 1. Your next day's activities will be prioritized, knowing what needs to be accomplished. 2. Your mind is relaxed, and you are much less apt to toss and turn trying to go to sleep, thinking about all the stuff you need to do. 3. Your subconscious mind is working while you sleep on the best methods to achieve completion of your tasks. 4. It's been said that investing 14 minutes in scheduling, creates an extra 56 minutes of productivity in your day. Extra productivity, extra and better sleep, peace of mind, and focused attention are all available in investing 1% of your day in prioritizing the next day's revenue and goal accomplishing activities.

Gary Loper is a recognized Twitter expert, life, business, mindset coach, motivational speaker, trainer, radio host, and highly respected entrepreneur, helping people master the business of life by Building Better Relationships.

Nathalie Lussier (Twitter: @NathLussier)
www.AmbitionAlly.com

I set five overarching goals per quarter for myself and my team. I write these down on a notecard and keep it by my computer or workstation at all times. Whenever I find myself wondering what to do next, or if the thing I'm working on is the right thing...I look over my five goals and priorities, and if it's not contributing to these priorities then it doesn't need to happen. This helps me eliminate a lot of the "cool but not important" things that might come up in the course of the day or week.

Nathalie Lussier is an award-winning entrepreneur, keynote speaker, and co-founder of business software company AmbitionAlly.

Natalie MacNeil (Twitter: @nataliemacneil)
www.SheTakesOnTheWorld.com

While apps can be wonderful and help us increase productivity, I prefer to plan in my Moleskine Executive Daily. I break my day into four parts: Be, Do, Learn, Play. BE. We spend so much time being busy, and very little time just being.

I start every day getting into a state of flow, moving my body through yoga or exercise, journaling or reflecting on what I'm grateful for, and doing a meditation. I will use a mudra (like yoga for your hands) to set an intention for the next part of the day. DO. These are the tasks that must be done to move me forward towards my five big goals for the year. I plan my year in a 5x5, I set five major goals and create five milestones for each, giving me 25 main things to focus on for the year. Usually there are three to five major things I need to do each day to stay on top of deadlines for those milestones. Keeping my eye on the bigger picture in this way allows me to stay super productive and laser focused. I only spend time on what matters most. LEARN. With the major tasks out of the way, I love diving into learning new things. It's our responsibility as leaders to continually learn and expand our knowledge. I keep on top of my industry, but I also pick topics to study that take me out of my work and introduce me to something new. For example, I've studied herbology and how to make herbal tonics and medicines. I've also taken Thai cooking classes, French lessons, and meditation teacher training. Even when we're grown up, we should never stop learning and trying something new might introduce you to a part of yourself you never knew before. And every day we have to PLAY. Many of us spend a lot of time at a desk and working. I think staying connected to your inner adventurer and free spirit can help lower your stress levels, increase productivity, and prevent burnout.

Natalie MacNeil is an Emmy award-winning media entrepreneur, creator of SheTakesOnTheWorld.com, and author of The Conquer Kit (Perigee 2015).

Aubrey Marcus (Twitter: @aubreymarcus)
www.AubreyMarcus.com

The way I best utilize my time is to acknowledge and cultivate stretches where I am in flow. When I am in those heightened states, it is an all-out sprint.

Aubrey Marcus is the founder and CEO of Onnit.com and the host of several top podcasts.

Philip Masiello (Twitter: @philipmasiello)

www.800razors.com

Every day I organize my workday by tasks that will impact growth in revenue and customers first. Next are items that will impact cost then items that will impact our people and finally items that will impact the future of our business.

Philip Masiello is the co-founder, CEO of 800razors.com. Prior to co-founding 800razors.com, Mr. Masiello was co-founder and president of Raw Essentials by Carol Alt, a pioneer in the raw and natural skincare industry. As an entrepreneur, Mr. Masiello has been disrupting business supply chains to create consumer value in the food, fashion, and personal care channels, founding over 10 businesses since the early 1980's. Mr. Masiello holds an MBA in Finance and Marketing from the University of Maryland.

Tracy Matthews (Twitter: @tracymatthewsny)

www.FLOURISHTHRIVEACADEMY.COM and

www.TracyMatthews.com

My belief is that creative people often struggle with structure, even though structure is the key to productivity and creativity. It wasn't until I started mapping out my days, that I was able to reach the levels of creativity and the business success I craved. My days start with two hours of self care (journaling, meditation and exercise) followed by time-blocked sections which are focused on my main objectives for the week and month. In addition to time blocking, we are implementing "Scrum" in my businesses and I encourage my team to single-task (as I do myself). As a results oriented person but a creative at the core, time-blocking and efficiency tools like "Scrum" have changed my life!

Tracy Matthews is a Fine Jewelry Designer and the founder of Flourish & Thrive Academy, the premiere resource for jewelry business education.

Carl Mattiola (Twitter: @cmattiola)

www.carlmattiola.com

Work on the one most impactful thing on your business, first thing in the morning. Spend time thinking and analyzing what

is most important each week.

Carl Mattiola is an entrepreneur and the founder of ClinicMetrics, ClinicRise, and Breakthrough Physical Therapy Marketing.

Andrew McCauley (Twitter: @andymac71)

www.autopilotyourbusiness.com

I prepare a MUST DO list the night before...when I get to my desk, I do those items first before I turn on my email. I use Trello to keep my in line with my day's tasks and celebrate all that I achieve in a day. I keep off social media most of the day, unless it's related to my specific work.

Andrew McCauley is the co-founder of Autopilot Your Business. Speaker, author, podcaster, and ranked top 100 most Influential Twitter users worldwide.

John McGinn (Twitter: @builtbysouth)

www.south.io

How do you stay productive? Truthfully, being creative and productive is a very rare occurrence for me. I try to focus on a single important task per day. Completing this one important task let's me feel more successful in the midst of everything else going on. Being overwhelmed crushes my creative spark. I also get up and walk around frequently during the day. Joking with our team and asking about their lives. These little diversions almost always trigger my best ideas. How do you plan your day? Most weeks my wife and I run through the week ahead on Sunday night, since we have a shared calendar and she adds things on her phone, it's more of a casual thing. Mondays after lunch our team gets together for a 'speed read' where everyone says what they're working on, and if they need any help on anything. Our project manager will take notes and update everyone's calendar (my wife can see this as well). One company policy that has really helped us—no client meetings on Mondays or Fridays (there is an eternal recurring block). This really helps prevent people from working on their weekends for a Monday deadline, or stay late on Friday trying to wrap up something after a meeting ate up their day. Do you have any morning rituals? With three kids, my ritual is frequent chaos. My ideal morning is coffee with my wife before kids wake up, controlled chaos for them to get out to school, two mile walk on the beach, BEFORE I check my email for the latest overnight blow up. Favorite mobile app? We all use the Slack mobile app for communication between our entire team (four time zones). This saves SO much time digging through email threads. I also rely on Flipboard to keep track of news related what I'm interested in. Recommended resource? Our primary application stack is: Base / Proposify / Basecamp / Lastpass / Asana / Adobe CC / Github / Vagrant / DeployHQ / Slack / Google Apps.

John McGinn is an award-winning creative director and founding partner of SOUTH, a full service digital agency based in Charleston, SC.

John McIntyre (Twitter: @johnmcintyre_)

www.themcmethod.com

Use <http://simplynoise.com/> to block out noises. Music is too disruptive, and the ambient sounds of an office or coffee shop distract me, especially when I'm writing.

<http://simplynoise.com/> creates a wall of white noise that blocks out all distracting sounds, without being distracting, so I can get into a flow state while working.

John McIntyre is a behavioural reengagement specialist, marketing strategist, and founder of The McMethod.

Becky McKinnell (Twitter: @iBecCreative)

www.iBecCreative.com

Create a theme for each day of the week so you can sort and focus on your priorities each day. You wear a lot of hats as an entrepreneur—breaking up your week will help you find time to make progress to grow and improve each key part of your business.

Becky McKinnell, president of iBec Creative, helps traditional businesses who are embarrassed and frustrated about their website feel proud and discover what a powerful tool it can be for their business.

Matt McWilliams (Twitter: @MattMcWilliams2)

www.mattmcwilliams.com

For me, there are three keys to getting more done in less time. First, I divide my day into segments where I must intensely focus and those where I can be less focused. Checking email does not generally require a lot of focus, so I can do that while listening to a podcast or eating a snack. Writing a blog post or writing copy for a product launch requires absolute focus, though. During those times, I remove all distractions, close all windows, put on the headphones and listen to some meditation music. Second, meditation. Speaking of meditation music, meditation is new to me, but has helped tremendously in helping me to focus. I have a tendency to have an idea a minute and be easily distracted. Since starting meditation, I can more easily focus for longer stretches of time. Third, I set deadlines throughout the day and set a definitive end time to

each day. I work better on a deadline, so I set them throughout the day. I must complete project X by noon, project Y before I eat, and I must finish all work by 6:00pm. That time varies as my schedule varies but those self-imposed deadlines keep me moving quickly. My goal is to get the most done, do it as well as I can, but be content with it being 95% right, moving to the next thing, and spending my best time with my family, not giving them my leftovers.

Matt McWilliams is the founder and CEO of Matt McWilliams Consulting, Inc., an award-winning provider of product launches and affiliate management.

Ari Meisel (Twitter: @arimeisel)
www.lessdoing.com

The entire system of Less Doing was created out of my goal to help people free up time, stress less, and reclaim their minds. The nine fundamentals include, the 80/20 Rule, Creating an External Brain, Customization, Stop Running Errands, Choose Your Own Workweek, Batching, Organization, Finances, and Wellness. My number one tip is regarding email. I think that the state of your inbox says a lot about the bigger picture that is your life. Inbox Zero means that you are taking advantage of the wonderful tool that is email so you can get more done. You should process all email using the three D's (you can apply this to most aspects of your life where you are receiving inputs whether it's paper or requests of your time). Only deal with things one time. Delete—if it doesn't require a response, doesn't need further action, or isn't relevant to you, delete it. Deal with it—if you can do it in the next five minutes, DO IT NOW, you'll accomplish something and just the act of accomplishing something will make you motivated to do more and get more done. The subset 4th D is delegate. Dealing with it could mean forwarding it to an assistant, a team member, or a spouse to get it done. Defer—the most interesting, you have to realize that there are better times and worse times for you to do everything and be able to deal with something at the right time mean you'll do it the most efficiently. The best tool for this is FollowUp.cc. All you do is forward an email to or add an address to the bcc field of email like 3days@followup.cc or Monday@followup.cc or April15@followup.cc and the email

will come back to your inbox at that time and will include a snooze functionality so if you were wrong about the timing, you can try again, but now you'll be further along and have more information.

Ari Meisel is the author of Less Doing, More Living and the creator of the Less Doing system of productivity and wellness. Ari is a human performance coach, speaker, and consultant.

Bryan Miles (Twitter: @bryanmiles)

www.eaHELP.com

Hire a virtual assistant from eaHELP and start delegating RESULTS not tasks. Give your virtual assistant the “why” behind the result and empower them to execute on your behalf. The best assistants become an extension of the leader and multiply the result of the leader. This is done through the speed of trust. When this happens—your productivity and results will go through the roof!

CEO and founder of eaHELP Virtual Assistants.

Dan Miller (Twitter: @48DaysTeam)

www.48Days.com

Treat the 168 hours we have each week as you would carefully earned dollars. Decide in advance how you will invest, save, and spend those hours.

My biggest productivity tip is that I work in uninterrupted, focused blocks of time. Not grabbing 10 minutes here and there but dedicating three to four hours to one important task in my office where there is no phone, no email or text messages, and no opportunity for someone to pop in to see me.

I have not used an alarm clock for the last 25 years, because I go to bed at a reasonable time and have clearly in my mind when I want to start the next day. I wake up fully rested, spend 30 minutes in meditation, and then go to my workout area. While working out physically, I take advantage of the rich audio programs available so that I fill that 45 minutes with physical exertion combined with mental input and expansion. I never check the news or look at my iPhone first thing in the morning, no matter how important it may seem to know the

latest news. The news is filled with rape, murder, pestilence, and heartache, and that is not the input I want in my brain. Later in the day, I can scan the news for anything related to my areas of interest and quickly sort through what I need. But I carefully protect that first hour of the day, making sure that all input is positive, clean, pure, creative, and inspirational. Many of my most creative ideas have come from this protected time of the day, often when I am in a full sweat. By 9:00 AM I am invigorated, motivated, and ready to face anything the day may bring.

Dan Miller is the author of the New York Times best-selling 48 Days To The Work You Love, No More Dreaded Mondays and Wisdom Meets Passion. Over 130,000 people have subscribed to his weekly newsletter, his 48 Days Podcast consistently ranks in the top 3 under Careers on iTunes, and the 48Days.net business community is viewed as an example around the world for those seeking to find—or create—work they love.

Jonathan Milligan (Twitter: @JonMilligan)
www.BloggingYourPassion.com

Do creative work first. Reactive work second. As an entrepreneur, you get pulled in a million different directions. In order to do what matters most, you must begin each day in your creative genius zone. This requires discipline. For example, it's easy to want to start your day checking email. Most of the time when I check email first thing in the morning, I end up spending my mornings in reactive work. My most creative work, where I add the most value, is left undone. By starting each day with a 60-90 minute focus session, I'm able to do my most creative work first. This is what builds my business.

Jonathan Milligan is an author, blogger, speaker, and online business coach. Since 2009, Jonathan has been building a portable, lifestyle business through blogging. Today, he teaches others the roadmap to doing the same.

Christie Mims (Twitter: @revolutionsclub)
www.therevolutionaryclub.com

I believe that I can get any task completed (even hated ones) in 25 minutes. This is actually completely UNtrue, but that belief gets me to open tomato-timer.com (it's a free website), hit start on a tomato, and then dive into whatever task I find myself procrastinating on. After 25 minutes, I end up so absorbed I do another 25, and eventually things wind up finished. :) It's amazing how lazy I am that I cannot set a timer myself, but tomato timer works! As for morning rituals, I'm a big believer in starting your day off right—so I do two things: 1. I read in the morning because that feels good to me—I often read business related books, but I also read terrible trashy novels. Either one wakes me up and gets me going in a nice way and 2. I open up my calendar when I'm done reading, look at what I committed to getting accomplished that week (I commit to three big things a week), and figure out what I absolutely need to do THAT day. I put it on the calendar and nothing else gets done until I do that. Voila! Productivity.

Christie Mims is a professional career coach and the founder of the Forbes Top 100 Website for Careers, The Revolutionary Club.

Justin Mitchel (Twitter: @justinmitchel)

www.codingforentrepreneurs.com

If anyone can do it, so can you. It might take you longer and it might come at greater personal sacrifice but it's true. If another human can do it, so can you. "If you think you can or if you think you can't, you're right." -Henry Ford

Justin Mitchel is an entrepreneur, programmer, teacher, and founder of Coding For Entrepreneurs.

Jeff Moore (Twitter: @wildthingscfood)

www.InternationalPacific.com,

www.ThursdayNightBoardroom.com

Power mornings: make everything you do for the first 120 minutes a ritual, including 30 minutes for light exercise, stretching and meditation...two or three 90-minute focus blocks per day, including a personal block...

www.Asana.com...www.Followup.cc...Fancy Hands...

Advice, see your day from a higher perspective. Do the math

on your activities. Avoid leveraging your time for money, instead leverage your expertise and delegate the rest. You will find that you have seemingly more down time than usual. You will want to fill the time with “stuff”, but avoid this. Take the time for peaceful thought and reflection. Cloistering for 90 to 120 minute blocks per day will reinvigorate you in a way that very few things can...couple it with exercise like a brisk walk and you will be fully charged and ready to go. Morning and night are great for this. Relationships go to the next level during long walks. Best thing my wife and I have ever done in 26 years of marriage.

Jeff Moore is president of two seafood companies and the founder of a global mastermind group called Thursday Night Boardroom with over 485 members from 24 different countries. He is a passionate marketer, entrepreneur, and is a world class expert in food supply chain dynamics, solutions and profitability.

Tom Morkes (Twitter: @tmorkes)

www.insurgentpublishing.com

The best way to 10x your productivity is to remove everything but the essential from your to-do list. Do you need to check email right now? Do you need to send that message? Do you need to take that call? Unless it's part of your critical path, ditch it.

Tom Morkes is a West Point grad and Iraq War veteran, and the founder and CEO of Insurgent Publishing, a full service book marketing and publishing company that launches books to bestseller.

Andy Murphy (Twitter: @AndyMurphytv)

www.andymurphy.biz

Understanding why, what, and how to leverage your peak mental state is truly the difference between failure and success. You can create laser focus, belief, flow, and massive motivation simply by understanding that you are thinking, feeling, and performing using neurology that runs on auto pilot in the background of your mind. Just like software runs in the background of your computer, your neurology also becomes

outdated. By exercising your mental muscles, meaning the thoughts and feelings that the world-class version of you would have, you create new neural pathways. This deepens and intensively connects you to whatever and whomever you focus on the most. EXTRA: “When you control your mind, you control your emotions. This leads to a controlled peak mental state and the ability to achieve any result.”

Andy Murphy is a Master Practitioner of Neuro Linguistics and Mental Performance Coach to royalty, world champions, and 8 figure entrepreneurs.

Chris Myers (Twitter: @chris_myers_)
www.chris-myers.net

My best productivity tip is to wake up early. An early start to the day provides time for introspection and preparation. I generally try to get into the office by 6:30am.

Chris Myers is the co-founder and CEO of BodeTree and a frequent contributor to the Wall Street Journal, Forbes, Entrepreneur Magazine, and MSNBC.

Akshay Nanavati (Twitter: @existing2living)
www.existing2living.com

At its core, the secret to time management and productivity is to remove thinking from the process as much as possible. Psychologists have repeatedly stated the normal state of the mind is chaos and the brain is lazy, so without direction it will naturally guide itself to the easiest course of action. In order for me to manage multiple projects like training to run across every country in the world, starting a non-profit, finding sponsors for and planning my run, working on my coaching and speaking business, writing a book, building a brand, managing a real estate investment firm, and contracting for the government, I need clear instructions to guide my brain daily. As such, I have created very clear five year goals, three year goals, one year goals, and then broken those down into months, weeks and days. So I stay present to the larger vision but focus only on the smaller tasks at hand. To maintain focus, I plan my week every Sunday with the larger goals in mind and I relentlessly chunk my time into smaller blocks where I

focus on only one project and one task in that project at a time. I also track almost every hour of my day and then compare the tracked time to the planned time at the end of the week. So when I start a chunk, I hit go on my timer. That action has become like an anchor that tells my brain “its go time,” immediately sending me into laser focus mode. This makes it playful as well so I don’t take the laundry list of tasks I have to do so seriously and get overwhelmed by them. I use the todoist app to track the list of very specific next actions in each project, I use Asana for the longer term goal planning, and I use atimelogger to track my time. These multiple systems ensure that my brain can act out the tasks it needs to in order to accomplish my goals while on autopilot without having to think about what action to take next. I think during the planning phase to remove thinking from the action phase.

Akshay Nanavati is an author, trainer and explorer on a mission to run across every country in the world to build a global community that works together as one for the common good.

Ali Neely (Twitter: @alexisneely)
www.eyeswideopenlife.com

I used to be called the hardest working woman in the business. But it wasn’t sustainable and I’m a mom of two kids, so I’ve had to discover how I can come into right relationship with time, money, and how I get paid. That started with getting really clear about how much I actually needed to make so I could stop chasing more and get clear about enough, or sufficiency. Then, I went through a meticulous process of clarifying how much time I wanted to spend actually delivering my services (after allocating time for self care, family, and all of the non-service delivery parts of my business). Finally, I was able to use that data to structure my fees into packages with high value outcomes that would pay me exactly what I needed to have the life I want and plenty of time to enjoy it. I created a tool to help others do the same at <http://tool.moneymaptofreedom.com>. Oh, and nothing gets done unless it’s on my Google Calendar. Even completing this request from you got calendared on my Google Calendar so

that when it popped up, I could do it and until then, I didn't think about it. Hope this all helps! :)

Ali Neely built a few million dollar businesses and now guides people to discover their own true success in the new economy.

Ben Newman (Twitter: @ContinuedFight)

www.BenNewman.net

We all have the POWER to choose our daily habits and to focus on the PROCESS (action steps) rather than on results we can't control. Here is a proven mental training tool we use in our coaching called YOUR Prizefighter Day. This has driven performance with athletes in the NFL, PGA, MLB, Boxing, NCAA as well as driving growth with business professionals and entrepreneurs around the world. The key: Each day identify three activity-driven goals (a personal goal, a business goal, a service goal) that, if accomplished, will make the day victorious, regardless of any other obstacles that come your way. Remember, you are focusing on activities which you can control, and not results that are ultimately out of your control.

Ben Newman is a best selling author, international speaker, and performance coach for business executives and professional athletes.

Dan Norris (Twitter: @thedannorris)

www.wpcurve.com

The best way to effectively manage your time is not spend any of it on things you don't want to do and you aren't good at. It's amazing how time-efficient you can be when you are doing what you love and the opposite is even more true. Build up your skills in delegation and automation so you don't have to do work you don't want to do. Make sure there is enough underlying profit in your business model to support hiring people to replace you. From there just work on things you love, it won't feel like work and you won't be watching the clock. But if you did you'd notice you work a whole lot faster and more productively.

Dan Norris is a serial entrepreneur, award winning content marketer, and the author of the best selling business book, The 7 Day Startup.

Kary Oberbrunner (Twitter: @karyoberbrunner)

www.karyoberbrunner.com

By far, the biggest place people waste time is in the area of decision making. Conservative sources estimate we make hundreds of decisions per day. Liberal studies estimate thousands. If each decision takes seconds to make, then clearly, delays in decision making equate to hundreds of lost hours per year. I solved this time waster by writing my OPUS. Before doing this process I didn't know how to make quick decisions. However, now that my OPUS is authored, I can make decisions in microseconds. As a result, I'm able to accomplish so much more.

Kary Oberbrunner is an author, coach, and speaker dedicated to igniting souls.

J.T. O'Donnell (Twitter: @jtodonnell)

www.Careerealism.com

Productivity tip: Make intense exercise a daily habit. The more fit I feel, the clearer my head is, the better decisions I make, and the more success I seem to attract. The discipline of exercise has helped me balance life and pursue my entrepreneurial dreams. It's kept me strong in times of crisis. It's given me uninterrupted time to visualize my goals. It's empowered me to believe I'm capable of doing things I've never done before. It keeps me from getting sick. It keeps me happy! It bonds me to other like-minded professionals. It sets a good example for my kids. It's something my husband and I can do together.

J.T. O'Donnell is the CEO of CareerHMO & Careerealism. Her work has been cited in Wall Street Journal, USA Today, New York Times, The Boston Globe, CNN.com, BusinessWeek.com, Mashable.com, and more.

Mike O'Hagan (Twitter: @mikesmanilatour)

www.MikesManilaTours.com

I started my business with \$100 and a burning desire to make money. At about employee number six I employed a Personal Assistant. That was 30 years ago - today I have 6 businesses in 4 countries and employ over 400 people. My personal assistant

is Virtual and in the Philippines. My Tip: Learn the art of working with an Assistant - your productivity and lifestyle balance will soar.

Mike O'Hagan is a speaker, author, bootstrapping business builder and a successful serial entrepreneur who currently owns 6 businesses in 4 countries. Mike teaches practical business solutions through his business speaking engagements and in 3-day business learning tours available in MikesManilaTours.com.

Steve Olsher (Twitter: @steveolsher)
www.SteveOlsher.com

My time management tip is based on an old adage that advises that two like-sized objects cannot occupy the exact same space at the exact same time. The same holds true for priorities. You cannot complete two tasks, activities, exercises, etc. at any one given time. A choice must be made that reflects what is most important at this exact moment and reflects the best investment of your time, energy and focus. Kurt Lewin named this phenomena, the Approach-Approach Theory of Conflict, whereby a single choice must be made amongst two equally attractive options. While additional detail about this theory can be provided, I summarize it as "Something's gotta give." This is my mantra during those moments when multiple priorities appear to be equally important for completion. In the end, only one activity can be performed and it should always be that which provides the best return on your emotional and physical investment. When you are unclear as to how you should allocate your time, simply say to yourself, "Something's gotta give" and then make a proactive choice about which endeavor you must pursue.

A 25+ year entrepreneur, Steve is the Chairman & Co-Founder of Liquor.com, online pioneer who launched on CompuServe's Electronic Mall in 1993, New York Times bestselling author of What Is Your WHAT? Discover The ONE Amazing Thing You Were Born To Do, author of Internet Prophets: The World's Leading Experts Reveal How to Profit Online, creator/host of Internet Prophets LIVE!, and

keynote speaker, who has appeared on CNN, Fox Business and other national outlets.

Michael O'Neal (Twitter: @solohour)

www.solopreneurhour.com

For massive productivity, use a service like songza.com to choose some ambient, lyric-free music to work to. They have a special section called “working, (no lyrics)” which will keep you focused and distraction-free for hours.

Michael O'Neal is the host of the podcast, The Solopreneur Hour, which features lively conversations, candid insights and bold advice for proudly unemployable people who are primed for real prosperity and fulfillment.

Dave Ortiz

www.nextdoornyc.com

The early morning is the perfect time to get mentally focused. I like to start off the morning with exercise. It gives me a mental energy that allows me to stay even keel throughout the day. Then I'll spend a half hour planning out my day, setting goals and focusing my efforts on strategic tasks. I'll AVOID checking emails even though I'll have many in my inbox that have come in from Asia overnight. As an entrepreneur it's easy to get caught up in the 100's of emails and fire drills that come up each and every day. If you don't have a plan and a mental strength when you start your day you can easily get caught up in things that take your attention away from driving the company in the right direction.

Dave Ortiz is a co-founder of NextDoor Design & Mfg, a custom manufacturer of home goods and consumer products.

Tracy Osborn (Twitter: @limedaring)

www.limedaring.com

I juggle my startup as well as various side projects, like writing my latest book. I have a “Daily Goals” doc I update every morning — at the top, my big long term goals (high level, “Recognized as one of the top people in the tech industry.”), then medium goals (“Make Hello Web App a success”) then short-term goals (daily to-dos). I review the list

every morning (takes only 5 min), then I plan out my day in hourly chunks dedicated to tasks to complete those goals. This keeps me focused throughout the day and I spend MUCH less time futzing around on the internet now!

Tracy Osborn is a designer, developer, and entrepreneur. She's the author of Hello Web App, and the founder of WeddingLovely.

Paula Pant (Twitter: @affordanything.com)

www.affordanything.com

Every night, choose one or two major goals that you'd like to accomplish the following day. Don't bog yourself down with a million small tasks: pick two that weigh on your mind, and resolve to accomplish only those two things the following day. Also, use toggl.com to track your time.

Paula Pant is the founder of AffordAnything.com, an online movement on wealth, travel and financial freedom.

Lisa Parmley (Twitter:)

www.PatentEducationSeries.com

I create a big 'to-do' list that usually takes up a sheet of paper at the beginning of every month. It's usually just tasks all listed out that I feel are the best tasks to focus on to grow the company and is based a lot of times on customer feedback. Once I have all the tasks written out I go through and start ordering them from most likely to make a big impact on customer satisfaction and revenue, to least likely. I also take note of how long the task might take and factor that into the final order of tasks for the month. Some months there is only one really large task, others there are dozens of smaller tasks, but they are all organized based on the impact they will have on the growth of the company.

Lisa Parmley is the founder of the Patent Education Series, which helps professionals, inventors, and entrepreneurs navigate the complex patent law maze.

Neil Patel (Twitter: @neilpatel)

www.neilpatel.com

If you want to be more productive, start using a free tool called Rescue Time. It will monitor how you spend your time and show you where you are being inefficient. As you cut those inefficiencies out, you will become more productive and have more spare time.

The Wall Street Journal calls him a top influencer on the web, Forbes says he is one of the top 10 marketers, and Entrepreneur Magazine says he created one of the 100 most brilliant companies. He was recognized as a top 100 entrepreneur under the age of 30 by President Obama and a top 100 entrepreneur under the age of 35 by the United Nations.

Maggie Patterson (Twitter: @magspatterson)
www.maggiepatterson.com

My biggest productivity tip is to stop trying to do everything yourself. It doesn't matter if you're a manager, a solo business owner or the CEO. Creating systems and processes that are well documented lets you get lower value tasks off your plate so you can focus on where you're most strategic and valuable. This was a huge shift in my business that has allowed for major growth in a relatively short period of time. Now, I live and die by our systems and project management tool, Basecamp. End result? Greater revenue, more focus and way less time lost due to having my hands in too many pots.

Maggie Patterson is a communications strategist, blogger, podcaster and speaker focused on storytelling and conversions.

Matthew Paulson (Twitter: @MatthewDP)
www.mattpaulson.com

Get anything that you want to remember out of your brain. While the human brain is good at complex reasoning and problem solving, it's not so good at remembering to-do lists, reminders and calendar items. Setup a note taking application like Evernote on your phone and immediately take note of any to-do list items that pop into your head. By storing your lists in an external memory of sorts, your mind will be freed up to do

more important tasks and you'll rest assured knowing that you're not going to forget to buy milk.

Matthew Paulson is the founder of Analyst Ratings Network, a digital publishing company that publishes an investment newsletter to more than 210,000 subscribers daily.

Francis Pedraza (Twitter: @francispedraza)
www.francispedraza.com

Organization. My friends consider me one of the most organized people they know, but I consider organization one of my greatest opportunities for growth. That's because — like Socrates said of wisdom — the more organized you get, the more you can do, and the more you can do, the more organized you need to get. It is a virtuous cycle. Elimination is one of the key principles in organization. It is far easier to organize a few things than to organize a lot of things. For example, I went from 2,500 Facebook friends to 150 Facebook friends, after doing the math: to get coffee with each of my 2,500 friends once a year, I would need to do 7 coffee meetings a day! So instead of building an elaborate system to organize my relationships, I decided to organize my friendships around investing in a far smaller set of incredibly high quality people.

If you love ideas, brainstorming, and reflections — you'll love Francis Pedraza's latest project, Cheeky. His last project, Everest—an app to achieve personal goals—failed, ironically, in 2014, after several years of trial and error.

April Perry (Twitter: @LearnDoBecome)
www.LearnDoBecome.com

The VERY best productivity tip I have ever learned is how to identify “Next Actions.” Do you find yourself procrastinating big projects? Do you feel overwhelmed by all there is to do... and so you zone out in front of the TV or on social media? Do you keep thinking that “one day” you'll get to that idea/business/book/project/dream? I used to be that way, too. Then I learned about Next Actions from David Allen's best-selling book, “Getting Things Done,” and my life changed. In essence, it's this: When you have a big project on your mind, you don't think about the WHOLE thing. You think about the

next specific, visible activity that will move that project toward completion. Are you putting bookshelves into your office? Do you already have the shelves? No? Okay, do you know what size they need to be? No? All right, then your Next Action is to measure the walls in your office to figure out which size bookshelf you can purchase. But wait...you can't find your measuring tape. (The kids were playing with it the other day.) Then your REAL Next Action is to "Find the Measuring Tape" or "Go buy a new measuring tape." See how easy that was? Now when you look at your office wall and think, "Man, I wish I had a bookshelf in here," you can breathe deeply and focus only on the measuring tape you need to buy/locate. Wasn't that fun? Seriously, Next Actions will change your life.

April is the Co-Founder of LearnDoBecome.com and powerofmoms.com, online communities that include more than 50,000 individuals from around the world. She specializes in applying the principles of David Allen's "Getting Things Done" in a fun, simple way, and her main focus is to help others architect a life of excellence.

Dwight Peters (Twitter: @BackersHub)
www.BackersHub.com

Productivity is key to success - the difference between winners and losers is the time devoted to taking action. As an entrepreneur, taking action can seem so overwhelming as there are always a million and one things that need to be done. The best recommendation I have for any entrepreneur is build a team, sell people on the vision of what you are trying to build - get them involved and learn how to effectively delegate. If you want to go quick, go alone - but if you want to go far, go together. Building an effective team that understands their role is better than any app I can recommend.

Dwight Peters is a crowdfunding expert, motivational speaker and the founder/CEO of BackersHUB.com.

Corey Poirier (Twitter: @thatspeakerguy)
www.thepassioncure.com

I have two strategies (of roughly 10 total strategies) for determining how I spend my time that I'd like to share. One, I spent the time determining my purpose. It is to always find ways to donate, educate, inspire, motivate and entertain. How I determine what to say no to (so I can free time to say yes to things that are in line with my purpose) is I ask myself if the task will be in line with any of those purpose items. If the answer is no, then it's an easy NO and doesn't make it's way on to my to-do list. If it's 3 or above then it becomes a solid YES and makes its way onto my to-do list. If it's in-between a 1-3 then I evaluate further to decide. The second thing I did (and re-visit often) is make a list of the people I surround myself with (clients, friends, other) and place a Plus (+) sign beside the ones adding positivity and value and a Negative (-) sign beside the ones that are bringing negativity and perhaps not bringing value (professionally and perhaps personally) and I adjust accordingly so that I'm spending my time with the people who are bringing positivity and value and therefore to do list items that add value overall

Corey Poirier is an international bestselling author, award winning keynote TEDx speaker, and host of a top rated personal development radio show

Joe Pulizzi (Twitter: @JoePulizzi)
www.joepulizzi.com

Plan your content creation in advance. Most people think in content tactics, like publishing a blog or a Facebook post. It's best to think in stories, and how many ways you can tell that story—an article, a blog, a book, a webinar, multiple social media posts, an ebook, a podcast and more. The time savings are immense if you only plan in advance.

Joe Pulizzi is the founder of the Content Marketing Institute and author, Epic Content Marketing.

Samantha Quist (Twitter: @samanthaquist)
www.samanthaquist.com

If you use Gmail, use the keyboard shortcuts feature relentlessly. I'd estimate this saves me 5-10 minutes of mindless clicking per day, which adds up fast. I've been eating

the same protein-packed energy bar every morning as “breakfast” for the past 16 years. It makes me feel full, gives me the nutrients I need for the rest of the day, and best of all saves me from having to think about what to do for breakfast each day or run on no fuel. Wear the same clothes every day. Ok, well not the exact same clothes every day. But the fewer decisions you need to make in the morning, the faster you’ll get out the door, so standardizing your wardrobe helps a lot. When I find pants I like, I buy multiple pairs and have been known to wear them every day for a week. This works especially well on weeks when I meet with different people each day. Work when you feel inspired. Stop working when you feel your productivity lagging. Otherwise you’ll waste a lot of time trying to work when in fact you’re too tired to be productive (such a huge time sink), or you’ll miss opportunities to produce your best results by doing something else at a time when you are having great ideas about your work. Surround yourself with productive people. Try to remember that sending *any* response to an email (even just a couple words) is better than no response. Try to remember this: done is usually better than perfect. Few things need to be perfect, so you can get a lot more done at the expense of perfection. (Easier said than done; I’m still working on this one myself.)

Samantha Quist is a Silicon Valley entrepreneur and advocate for women in technology.

Dan Radcliffe (Twitter: @ivhq)

www.volunteerhq.org

Use your inbox in tandem with your diary to ensure you stay on top of work and always know what you’re doing tomorrow.

Dan Radcliffe is the Executive Director of the world’s leading volunteer travel organization, International Volunteer HQ. In 2014, Dan was named New Zealand Entrepreneur of the Year in recognition of the impact that IVHQ has made globally.

Robert Rawson (Twitter: @ManageYourTime)

www.Timedoctor.com

Do NOT accomplish all of your tasks. In fact if you are accomplishing all of your tasks it's a pretty good indicator that you are NOT productive. Why? Because you want to start by writing down everything that you can think of that you might want to do on your task list. Get it all out of your head and onto a list. On that list you are going to have some lower priority items. Some items that might seem good at the time you wrote them down but are not super-high priority. It's important to focus on the most important tasks and prioritize these tasks before you get around to the lower priority items on your list. Actively procrastinating these lower priority tasks is crucial to being productive.

Robert Rawson is a former medical doctor, now productivity expert, and owner of Timedoctor.com and Staff.com.

Jeremy Reeves (Twitter: [@jeremyreeves](https://twitter.com/jeremyreeves))
www.JeremyReeves.com

When you're thinking about productivity, the first thing you have to figure out is where your time is best spent. Most people focus on getting more done in a specific amount of time. However if you're still working on things that don't matter, it won't make a difference. Once you know exactly where your time is best spent, you have to master the art of getting into a flow state. I typically can produce up to 4x the amount of work in the same amount of time in a flow state as compared to when I'm not. Here's how I personally do it. First, I use an app called "Self Control" which blocks access to certain website pages (your email, for example) for a specific amount of time. That cuts out distractions. Then, I take a pair of headphones, plug them into my computer and turn on an app called "Brainwave Studio". It's a \$1.99 app which uses binaural beats to put your brain into certain states that clear your mind, keep you focused and enhance creativity. I then set a timer for 50 minutes and work in a fully engaged state for 50 minutes. I shoot for four of these 50-minute blocks per day. In those days, I can typically produce between 3-4x the amount of work I do when not using that strategy.

Jeremy Reeves is a sales funnel specialist at www.JeremyReeves.com, where he shows business owners how

to build automated marketing funnels.

James Reynolds (Twitter: @FollowJames)

www.veravo.com

Understanding that will power is limited and it depletes overtime. Cut yourself off from all distractions and do your best work in the morning.

James Reynolds is the Founder of Veravo.

David Risley (Twitter: @davidrisley)

www.blogmarketingacademy.com

One of the best things that has worked for me is to recognize the importance of separating PLANNING from EXECUTION. The act of planning out what you're going to do is a SEPARATE action from actually doing it. One of the most effective ways to WASTE your time is to attempt to be productive while planning it out on the fly. Or to just "jump in" without planning it first. So, I take regular sessions for myself simply to plan. During that time, I am being the EXECUTIVE of my own business, not the technician. I figure out what I'm going to do, how I'm going to do it, and (very importantly) what my deadline is. If there are any decisions to be made, I make them. And I do all this before I start working on it. Then, when I go into "work mode", I just buckle down and execute.

David Risley is the founder of the Blog Marketing Academy, where his 17 years of experience as a blogger is used to teach a systematic and strategic approach to online business using blog-based marketing.

Greg Rollett (Twitter: @gregrollett)

www.ambitious.com

Ambition starts in the morning. From the moment your feet hit the ground you begin to make decisions for your your day will play out. What you choose to spend your first waking moments doing will determine your success for the day. If you want to be more productive, create a morning routine that allows you to focus on what will make your day a success.

Greg Rollett is a best-selling author, Emmy nominated producer and the president of the Ambitious Media Group where he help young people to live more ambitious lives now instead of living in a state of quiet desperation.

Nick Ruiz

www.AlphaHomeFlipping.com

I stay productive by putting every ounce of my time into my strengths. Life's too short to try and stay balanced and strengthen your weaknesses (I have much more weaknesses than I have strengths). If everyone did this, the WORLD would have more balance! We need to be focused on balancing time based on a whole unit (department, company, industry, world, etc)...By spending all my time on my strengths, I'm able to grow exponentially, while delegating other stuff. For example: I'm a people person, negotiator, trouble shooter, and deal maker. I suck at most other parts of my entrepreneurial endeavors (organization, clerical, office stuff, bean counting, computer stuff, online marketing, social marketing, web stuff, etc.). I'm a freaking happy camper with this set up and I think more people would be too if they followed this simple model. Stick to using your time for what you're awesome at! When you do, you're happier...when you're happier, you produce more with the limited 24 hours we all have...

Nick Ruiz is a twice self made real estate entrepreneur. He's also the founder of AlphaHomeFlipping.com where his passion is helping people become self-made entrepreneurs from scratch.

Toby Salgado (Twitter: @superagentslive)

www.tobysalgado.com

Staying on task and being productive go hand in glove. The two tips I use to achieve high level productivity is time-blocking and batching. I block out an hour to 3 hours to completely devote to a single task. That is the one singular task I work on during that time blocked session. The other thing I do is batch similar tasks into one day. By batching similar items I can reach a flow state much easier and switching from task to task is much more efficient.

Toby Salgado is a serial entrepreneur founding four multimillion dollar businesses in the last 15 years.

Shane & Jocelyn Sams (Twitter: @flippedls)
www.FlippedLifestyle.com

Relentlessly plan every hour of your week, but only one week at a time. It is almost impossible to move too much farther in that much detail, but you must know the next 7 days. Every Sunday night we sit down together and look at the week. We all have 168 hours (from the janitor at the white house to the president, everyone), but what priorities must fill those blocks of time. Your schedule is a list of priorities. Block off the hours you sleep, the half hours you eat, the “musts” like go to work or take kids to sports. Whatever is left is yours. We start with family. Time each day with each other and our kids. Then we schedule time for self. Then our business. If there is time left for other stuff, we prioritize the activity and fill it in. Then stick to it and do it again next week. e built our business while working full time and raising kids. Because we set priorities. Your schedule will make or break your dreams. If it’s REALLY important to you, you will find a way to put it on that schedule. If it’s not, you will find an excuse and it won’t make the cut. After that, leverage every dime you have to outsource and buy other people’s time. That is the key. Organize your 168 hours, then BUY hours from others to grow.

Shane & Jocelyn Sams built a high six figure business selling digital products like ebooks and how to videos to teachers and football coaches. After their huge success, they started FlippedLifestyle.com to help other families “flip their lives” with online business!

George Siosi Samuels (Twitter: @siosism)
www.siosism.com

Energy management can sometimes be more powerful than time management. Morning rituals are certainly a huge factor in creating successful habits. Productivity can be enhanced even further when you empower yourself with a team and move beyond “I can do everything myself.”

George Siosi Samuels is a creative entrepreneur who's passionate about people, culture and technology.

Ben Sardella (Twitter: @bensardella)

<https://about.me/bensardella>

My top 10 rules for time management and productivity: 1. Focus on what matters most first 2. Block out all distractions 3. Set time limits on all meetings/calls - shorter is always better 4. Set up email inbox routing rules to help prioritize 5. Set correct expectations on when you can respond or complete a task 6. Wake up earlier 7. Outsource or automate as much as possible 8. Block off time on your calendar for things like responding to emails or time to just think 9. Create folders in your inbox for things like ideas or good reads for later 10. Ask others that are successful and busier than you how they manage their tasks

Datanyze Chief Revenue Officer, Ben Sardella, has spent over 15 years building successful SaaS sales teams. He started his career by pioneering the SaaS sales model as a founding member of the NetSuite sales team back in 2000.

James Scarmozzino (Twitter: @scarmozzinosocs)

www.onlinebizstartup.com

Wake up and do the task you least want to do. It's often the task you least want to do that's the most important. I ask myself one simple question every morning, "what task that I accomplish today will make the biggest impact on my business and life." If I accomplish that one task, my day has been successful.

James Scarmozzino is the founder of Sunergetic, a company that manufactures advanced supplements for anti-aging and healthcare. He also owns an internet marketing company focused on helping entrepreneurs build their own online businesses.

Wes Schaeffer (Twitter: @SalesWhisperer)

www.TheSalesWhisperer.com

Daily Discipline Done Diligently Determines Destiny. Every day do something to promote and grow your business, even if

you're sick, traveling, or just overwhelmed with the "stuff" of life. You do this by leveraging automation tools such as web forms and auto-responders for lead capture and nurturing, auto-schedulers like TimeTrade to streamline appointment scheduling, and social media schedulers like HootSuite to plan your social engagement. Shooting from the hip is fine if you're in the circus, not if you're wanting to grow a business.

Wes Schaeffer is The Sales Whisperer®, a ruthlessly pragmatic entrepreneur, sales trainer, author, and speaker who believes marketing is just selling in print.

Bill Schley

www.billschley.com

A fast B+ is always better than a slow A-.

Bill Schley is co-founder of BrandTeamSix, and a bestselling author.

James Schramko (Twitter: @jameschramko)

www.SuperFastBusiness.com

Routine sets you free. I go to bed before 11:00 so that I can be well slept in the morning. Using Schedule Once I only have appointments on Wednesday and Thursday in time slots I am at maximum energy for. Rescue time keeps an eye on how long I spend on the desktop. 20 hours per week is my target maximum. I set a hard limit of 30 hours a week. I accept that I cannot do everything so I work only on things that are vitally important using the 80:20 rule. My managers run the service business and standard operating procedures ensure we are automated in this area.

James Schramko is the founder of SuperFastBusiness the worlds most convenient online coaching community, SEO services and wordpress website development.

Aaron Schwartz (Twitter: @MosesOfWatches)

www.ModifyWatches.com

Put all of your to-do's on a calendar. It's really easy to create a list, but really hard to get things done. Carve out specific time for your important priorities and handle them accordingly!

Aaron Schwartz is Co-Founder and CEO of Modify Watches.

David Meerman Scott (Twitter: @dmsscott)

www.davidmeermanscott.com

According to Nielsen, the average American spends 158 hours each month watching television(!). That's 1,896 hours per year. Damn. That would be enough time to write an awesome book or start a company. You want a six-pack? Exercise instead of watch TV. Eliminate television and you gain nearly two thousand hours a year. Imagine what YOU could do?!

David Meerman Scott is a marketing & sales strategist, keynote speaker, and bestselling author of 10 books including The New Rules of Marketing and PR and Newsjacking.

Jerrod Sessler (Twitter: @sessler)

www.jerrodsessler.com

Time management is merely a result of living our priorities. We demonstrate our priorities in the ways that we invest our time. If you do not agree with yourself then change how you are investing and enjoy the results. The alternative is to get better, faster and to buy every manner of tool and app to make you more efficient. I suggest doing all that but also having a stoic focus on priorities to maximize the effort building the life you really want.

Jerrod Sessler is a serial entrepreneur, expert in the franchise industry, has mechanical and manufacturing engineering degrees, awarded SBA Veteran Champion of the Year (2010), recognized by Entrepreneur Magazine as a Top 500 Franchise and Top 50 Emerging franchise concepts. He is a cancer survivor and mentor in the health industry.

Peter Shallard (Twitter: @petershallard)

www.petershallard.com

We have a productivity system, philosophy and coaching program (in one) at www.commitaction.com

Peter Shallard is known as The Shrink for Entrepreneurs.

Gideon Shalwick (Twitter: @GideonShalwick)

www.veeroll.com

Here's what works great for me...First, I figure out what my definite chief aim in life is for the moment - this is normally in the form a project (limited in time) that I am super passionate about. Then, I figure out the MAIN priority to make this project a reality and a success. I do my best to JUST focus on this ONE MAIN priority at any given time, until it's complete...and then move onto the next priority on the list. To help me stay focussed, I use things like Trello to collect and manage all my to do lists related to this main project. And I also use a physical egg timer to help me stay focussed on any given task for the day. For 45 minutes, I would work on the main priority, and then for 15 minutes, I would either take a total clean break, or clear some emails or messages, depending on my energy level. If necessary, I would dedicate some 45 minute slots to clearing emails, messages and admin... but still try and keep them as focussed as possible on my main project. I also constantly look for building a team to help relieve me and my business of our biggest bottlenecks in getting to our goals.

Gideon Shalwick is co-founder of Veeroll.com, the world's first ever YouTube video ads management platform, to completely automate and optimise the whole YouTube Video Ad creation process and allow every day businesses to start leveraging incredibly affordable, but extremely targeted traffic on YouTube.

Josh Shipp (Twitter: @JoshShipp)
www.JoshShipp.com

Wishful thinking is NOT a strategy. You must have a plan in place for how and when you're work day will start. AND how and when your work day will stop. At my predetermined stop time I give my wife my laptop and she locks it away from me. WHY? If you're someone who is self-employed you must give yourself guardrails to enable long-term, sustainable success. Boundaries are not constraining they're freeing. A limited window of time forces me to be focused and manage my time well even when I don't feel like it.

Josh Shipp is an award-winning entrepreneur named to Inc. Magazine's 30 under 30 list.

Kate Marie Grinold Sigfusson (Twitter: @ KMGrinold)
www.babies4babies.com

Between being a full time entrepreneur and a full time mom, I have moved on from the silly idea of “balance” and instead focus on ways to harmonize my world by being intentional. If I’m with my baby, I’m with my baby. If I’m working, I’m working.

Kate Marie Grinold Sigfusson is the founder and CEO of Babies4Babies, the luxury baby brand with a mission to reduce global child mortality.

Naomi Simson (Twitter: @ NaomiSimson)
www.NaomiSimson.com

Why use 100 words when 10 words will do. Whether that is in an email, a report, a presentation or a pitch. Brevity can be powerful.

Naomi Simson is the founder of RedBalloon, author of Live What You Love, and an investor on Shark Tank Australia.

Mark Sisson (Twitter: @Mark_Sisson)
www.MarksDailyApple.com

Don’t sacrifice sleep for productivity. Many young entrepreneurs believe they can function on little sleep while they build their business. But lack of sleep (and, more importantly, lack of brain rewiring from adequate rest) can cause you to lose your edge and sharpness. Better to go into planning sessions, creative brainstorming or even negotiations with the clear focus, calm demeanor and crisp reactions from a fully functioning brain. The hour or two you might give up in checking a few more things off your list by staying up too late might save you from a serious error in judgement later on. Or simply might allow you to be more productive overall because you just don’t get sick or worn down.

Mark Sisson is the author of the best-selling book The Primal Blueprint, publisher of the world’s most well-trafficked blog on paleo, primal and ancestral health and the owner of Primal Nutrition, Inc.

Jeffrey Slater (Twitter: @Moments_Later)

www.themarketingsage.com

I keep a not to do list of things that are a waste of time. It is of equal importance to my daily list of three things to focus on before taking on anything else. I find that it is important to be hyper-focused on leveraged activities that will move important things forward. My 'not to do list' is a reminder of how easy it is to get distracted. I rarely answer my phone and my outgoing message asks for people to email me so I can quickly sort through distraction and requests. Another critical part of my ritual is 15 minutes of meditation before I open my emails or go to work. It centers me and allows me to stay focused on a bigger picture of what is important.

Jeffrey Slater is an accomplished entrepreneur whose business, Rachel's Brownies was on INC 500 fastest growing business. He publishes the blog, MomentSlater at The Marketing Sage and coaches small to mid-sized business with marketing advice so they can grow their brand.

Pamela Slim (Twitter: @pamslim)

www.pamelaslim.com

At the beginning of each year, I identify my three critical priorities. Then I organize these priorities in my project management system, Trello. I break large goals into quarterly projects, then chip away at them one month at a time. By creating daily awareness of my key priorities which are named as categories in my project management system, it is easier to say no to the wrong business activities, and yes to the right ones.

Pamela Slim is professional speaker, business coach and award-winning author.

Rakesh Soni (Twitter: @OyeSoni)

www.loginradius.com

We use the program, Asana, in our office on a daily basis to increase productivity and time management. It is a scheduling mechanism that allows us to have a Team Calendar, create and assign individual or group tasks, assign due dates, and upload documents and files for shared use. We can create projects for

specific departments or for the team as a whole. It keeps everyone on task, and allows us to create goals for the future.

Soni is the CEO and co-founder of LoginRadius, the rapidly-expanding social platform provider. He has explicit interest in innovation and creating a better experience to connect users to a website.

Felicia Spahr (Twitter:)

www.feliciaspahr.com

One of the core reasons for lack of productivity and time management is a lack of caring about oneself. You hear from a lot of top execs and entrepreneurs about all the demands on their time, all of the things they have to do...it's 'busy, busy, busy'. You will be hard pressed to find someone who demands time with themselves — yet this is what THE most successful people do. And a way to get started is prioritizing time for yourself. You don't have to meditate or have a morning ritual — the idea is to carve out time to do something you love, sit and think for 10 minutes, and make that time non-negotiable. Because if you don't, no one else will, either.

Felicia is a charisma and leadership coach who helps leaders —CEOs, execs, and founders—achieve peak performance and increase their charisma so they can focus on dramatically growing their business and focus on what matters in their life.

Josh and Jill Stanton (Twitter: @screwthe9tofive)

www.ScrewTheNineToFive.com

We always begin our day with what we like to call our “Wake Up and Break Up” morning routine. We wake up at 6:45, drink a litre of water to wake us up (sometimes a tea if we're feeling dangerous) and then go our separate ways for the next 90 minutes. We use that alone time for quiet visualization and exercise. This is our time to gather our thoughts, set our intentions for the day and set our day off on the right foot. Once that's over we meet back up and toast the day with one of Josh's famous green smoothies. Ever since we started implementing the Wake Up and Break Up our productivity has gone through the roof, we've gained loads of clarity and we've

built serious momentum in our business. Everyone needs a little Wake Up and Break Up throughout their morning!

Josh and Jill Stanton are the co-founders of Screw the Nine to Five, their little slice of the internet where they teach unsatisfied 9-to-5ers how to take their skills from their day job and transform them into an online business they love.

Yaro Starak (Twitter: @yarostarak)

www.entrepreneurs-journey.com

The two primary productivity concepts I apply are the following...First, the 80/20 Rule, which helps me to identify which tasks deliver the biggest rewards and thus I should focus on. Two, the “Theory Of Constraints”, which helps me to identify what is the immediate constraint holding me back from a desirable result. When I focus on the tasks that remove the constraints that lead to the biggest results, I don’t have to do much work to deliver an outcome. In my opinion intelligent task selection is the single most important part of productivity, hence these two concepts are vital to my success.

Yaro Starak is the author of the Blog Profits Blueprint, founder of the Entrepreneurs-Journey.com blog. He’s made over a million dollars selling digital products via blogging.

Jon Stein (Twitter: @jonstein)

www.betterment.com

I manage my time tightly. There are three things I do: tell the Betterment story (mission and vision), hire the best people in the world to work on our vision, and create an environment in which our team can do the best work of their lives. If I’m not doing these three things, I’m likely wasting time. To manage my time, I keep a running list of my priorities, force ranked in terms of importance. Whatever is at the top of the list is what I work on first. As emails come in, I manage to inbox zero (pausing my inbox so that I can process new mail in batches), and I add work items to my list. Then I work on the top item on the list.

Jon Stein is the CEO and founder of Betterment. Passionate about making life better, and with his experience from his career of advising banks and brokers on risk and products, he

founded Betterment in 2008. Jon is a graduate of Harvard University and Columbia Business School, and he holds Series 7, 24, 63, and is a CFA, Chartered Financial Analyst.

Dr. Sean C. Stephenson (Twitter: @theseantourage)
www.SeanStephenson.com

Hire someone whose sole purpose is to protect your energy from interruptions and distractions. Make your productivity inevitable.

Sean Stephenson is a world-renowned speaker, international bestselling author and speaker trainer.

Shawn Stevenson (Twitter: @ShawnModel)
www.TheShawnStevensonModel.com

Energy is everything. We have a certain amount of willpower allotted to us everyday, and we burn through it quickly if our energy is low. I like to do most of my creative work in the morning, so I make sure that I stack the conditions in my life to ensure that my energy is high when I get to my laptop. There are three things that are mandatory for me when I wake up. First, I take what I call an “Inner Bath” by drinking about 30 ounces of high quality water. This helps to jumpstart your metabolism by flushing out metabolic waste products accumulated in your body while you were asleep. Whether you realize this consciously or not, when you wake up you are dehydrated. This will help to instantly balance your body out. Second, I do a short session of exercise—20 minutes or less—like rebounding (using a mini-trampoline), going for a brisk walk, or doing Tabata (which only takes four minutes!) This is not done for the purpose of getting 6-pack abs (although it couldn’t hurt), it’s done for the purpose of releasing endorphins that make you feel good and stress hormones like cortisol and epinephrine that help you to focus (and research shows that secreting these hormones in the morning will actually help you to sleep better at night). Third, I eat a lower carbohydrate, higher fat, moderate protein breakfast. Let’s face it, in our country, we have been trained to have dessert for breakfast - Sugary cereals, pancakes, bagels, muffins, Orange Juice, and all manner of things that will shoot your blood sugar through the roof and inherently lead to you going

hypoglycemic shortly after (i.e. your blood sugar crashes - and so do you). This is a guaranteed energy and productivity zapper. We want to keep our blood sugar stable and steady so that we are not constantly pulled away from our objectives because we need to “fix” our blood sugar again. Bonus is, you’ll also put your body in a fat-burning state instead of a sugar burning state. Breakfast would look like a protein/healthy fat entree of choice: Eggs, pastured sausage, a grass-fed burger, or leftovers from last night’s dinner. If you’re vegetarian, pates made from nuts would be one choice you could go with here. Next, we need our non-starchy veggies (which should take up half of your plate). This will give you a ton of micronutrients to help your brain and nervous system function. This could be anything from sautéed kale or garlicky spinach, to curried zucchini, sauerkraut, bok choy, or so many other options. Lastly, we need our extra fats. Did you know that your brain is mostly made of FAT? And your nervous system (how your body transmits signals) is insulated by fat? If you’re deficient in healthy fats, your brain and nervous system suffers. If you ever thought that a low fat diet was a good idea, then hopefully this will divulge the naked truth to you. You could go for things like avocado slices, olives, raw nuts, seeds, coconut oil and more to give you the extra serving of healthy fats your body needs. Follow these three daily practices and you’ll supercharge your energy and productivity.

Shawn Stevenson is a bestselling author and creator of The Model Health Show, featured as the #1 Fitness & Nutrition Podcast on the iTunes charts.

Luke Stokes (Twitter: @lukestokes)

www.foxycart.com

Clock your time. Even as a founder, owner, or salaried worker, use a time clocking software and make sure every minute counts for something. Give each minute a name and make sure you are spending it wisely in the categories you planned on instead of your day spending you.

Luke Stokes is the co-founder and CTO of FoxyCart.com. He’s passionate about living life on purpose and interested in Bitcoin.

Melanie Benson Strick (Twitter: @melcoach)

www.MelanieBensonStrick.com

My best tool is to keep front of mind this idea: Everything you say yes to means you are saying no to something else. Is this REALLY the best use of my time? Once I'm clear then I use online project management tools (like teamworklive.com) to log actions and deadlines for myself and my team. It keeps us all focused and 100% more productive.

Melanie Benson is co-author of Entrepreneur.com's Start Up Guide to Starting an Information Marketing Business and has her success tips featured in magazines such as American Express OPEN Forum, Woman's Day, Parenting Magazine, University of Phoenix Alumni Magazine and the LA Times.

Deborah Sweeney (Twitter: @mycorporation)

www.mycorporation.com

Believe in yourself and stay focused. When you have a good mindset and believe in yourself, you can make anything happen. There will be times when you have self doubt, but you must put that aside and persist and keep the focus and drive. If you stay focused and thoughtful (and organized), you can make anything happen!

Deborah Sweeney is the CEO of MyCorporation, which she purchased out of Intuit back in 2005. She has led the company to continued growth and success as a stand-alone company.

Brandee Sweesy (Twitter: @ BrandeeSweesy)

www.BrandeeSweesy.com

#1 thing I do is "chunking" and I use the Pomodoro app on my phone. Pomodoro times 25 minutes of straight work on one task, turning everything else off. No matter if I am in the flow or not - I get up at 25 minutes and take a 5 minute break to stretch, drink water, etc. This helps me to avoid all the distractions. Morning ritual is meditation and from there I create my day in my mind, seeing the smiling faces of clients, successful meetings, etc. Mobile App: Pomodoro Newsfeed eradicator is also a favorite of mine to not get sucked into the FB world.

Brandee Sweesy has been dubbed the Youtube Whisperer and is the founder of Video Ad Optimizer the only way to advertise on Youtube. With 20 years marketing, public relations and speaking experience she helps businesses to Engage! Ignite! Expand! their audiences.

Betsy Talbot (Twitter: @betsytalbot)

www.BetsyTalbot.com

Before I write the first word of a book, I know when it will publish. There is a power to setting deadlines, whether you're talking about tomorrow's to-do list or the biggest goal you've ever had. If you put it on the calendar, you can work backward to find the daily steps. And then you do them, one by one, spurred by your deadline. I've used this method to do everything from write books to sell everything I owned to travel the world with my husband. Personal or professional - deadline setting works!

Betsy Talbot writes contemporary romance for women over forty.

Jaime Tardy (Twitter: @eventualmillion)

www.eventualmillionaire.com

Active Actions vs Passive Actions. I think we fill our to do list with things that don't align with our goal too often! An active action is one that pushes you outside of your comfort zone—and something that will give you results that push you toward your goal. That is what should be filling out to do list! (And first you need to know your ONE goal to make progress on!)

Jaime Tardy is founder of EventualMillionaire.com where she has interviewed over 200 millionaires that started their own businesses.

Jim Tedesco (Twitter: @jimbotravel)

www.jimbotravel.com

Time Management is often the question during an interview that gets asked the least but once hired, becomes the biggest area of development a leader will highlight as a concern in their new employee. While writing "to-do" lists can often help you remember to do your daily tasks, time management is about productivity. How can you do more in the same amount of time you have now? I'm a firm believer that you need to ask questions, and be very clear from the start as to what the expectation is of your boss or the leader of the project you are

working on. Why spin your wheels doing something you think will be good, or spend extra time researching something, when it is not the direction the project manager was looking for. Save time by asking the right questions in the beginning, and this will allow you to challenge the current mindset if necessary, but ultimately leave that initial meeting on the same page and clear on what you need to do the first time, rather than the second time around. I am also a firm believer that prioritization is key. You must decide how much time each necessary task will take and then prioritize your day on those time allocations and the importance of each. Keep in mind, just because something may take 30 minutes and not be as important, it is ok to do that first knowing it will help free up the rest of the day to work on the more important stuff. You don't always have to do the most important stuff first, but you must allocate yourself time to ensure the important stuff gets completed by the deadline given.

Jim Tedesco is a sales and branding expert, and has held numerous sales and marketing positions within the travel industry. He has twice been named a "Rising Star in Travel" by Vacation Agent Magazine, is a highly touted speaker/coach on branding, and widely quoted in travel related stories.

Johnny B. Truant (Twitter: @johnnybtruant)
www.SterlingAndStone.com

I have tons of little tricks and tools I use to keep myself on track, but as simple and possibly cliché as it sounds, knowing myself is far more important than any one tactic. I have to know when I'm at my best for my most important work (morning, for writing fiction), when I tend to slack off (after meetings or podcasts), and when I can get by with relatively mindless work (afternoons). It's not about getting maximal amounts done; it's about ideally matching my capacities vs. my occasional need to screw around with what needs to be done at what time.

JOHNNY B. TRUANT is a co-host of the top-rated Self Publishing Podcast, co-author of the #1 Marketing bestseller Write. Publish. Repeat: The No-Luck-Required Guide to Self-

Publishing Success, and the author of well over 2.5 million words of popular fiction.

August Turak (Twitter: @augustturak)

www.augustturak.com

The key to my productivity is through a disciplined goal setting process. My goals produce my priorities and my priorities determine how I utilize the scarcest of all resources: Time.

August Turak is a successful entrepreneur, corporate executive, and award-winning author of Business Secrets of the Trappist Monks. In 2005 he won the \$100k Grand Prize in the Templeton Foundation's Power of Purpose Essay Contest and he is a popular leadership contributor on Forbes.com

Rory Vaden (Twitter: @rory_vaden)

www.roryvadenblog.com

You multiply your time by giving yourself the emotional permission to invest time into things today that create more time tomorrow.

Co-Founder of Southwestern Consulting and New York Times bestselling author of, Take the Stairs, and Procrastinate on Purpose.

Andrea Vahl (Twitter: @andreavahl)

www.AndreaVahl.com

I try to start most days with exercise. I love to run and I think that helps clear my mind and energize me for the day. I use a combination of a paper to-do list (I still love paper and crossing things off) and I star the 3 things that must get done that day. Then I use Google Calendar to block off time to get things done in the coming weeks. If it's scheduled, then I can defend that time from other things that pop up. That also helps me know when my time is full so I don't over commit. I use Calendly to give my clients an easy way to schedule time with me and it works with my Google calendar to show them my availability.

Andrea Vahl is a Social Media Consultant and Speaker and is the co-author of Facebook Marketing All-in-One for

Dummies. *She was the Community Manager for Social Media Examiner, one of the most influential social media news sites, for over 2 years and was named 50 Favorite Online Influencers of 2014 on Entrepreneur.com. She also uses her improv comedy skills to blog as a slightly cranky character, Grandma Mary—Social Media Edutainer on her site at www.AndreaVahl.com.*

Sheila Viers (Twitter: @sheilaviers)

www.sheilaviers.com

Start your day with five to ten minutes of meditation and journaling. By doing this, you can focus your attention on what matters and ultimately how you want your day to feel. Time management tools like scheduling everything into your calendar (including things like workouts and self-care) are great, but if you are operating in a reactive state, life doesn't feel very meaningful. Set yourself up for success and for the life that you really want, by taking just a few minutes at the beginning of your day to get into your power, set your intentions, and THEN take action with the end goal (the vision you have for your ideal life) in mind.

Sheila Viers helps women break free from yo-yo dieting and self-sabotage so they can lose weight naturally and feel amazing in their skin.

Amber Vilhauer (Twitter: @AmberVilhauer)

www.InsightfulDevelopment.com, www.AmberVilhauer.com

The demands on an entrepreneur are at an all time high and the intensity is only rising. To-do lists are getting longer and customers expect results faster which means you are being forced to manage your time—every minute of it—otherwise your business will crumble. If you want to stay on top of your A game, these are some helpful tips: (1) My highest productivity tip is to “get it done in the moment.” If a task comes in that takes me less than 5 minutes, I immediately knock it out. That could be an email request of someone needing a file, or me delegating a quick task to a team member. It's the volume of tasks and emails that stress us out the most. So by getting things done immediately, in the moment, I don't have to worry about it later and let that

anxiety build. (2). Live by your to-do list. Write everything down, big and small. Divide your tasks by day and get the most crucial tasks done first thing in the morning to build momentum, reduce stress and make sure you hit your deadlines. Any task you didn't accomplish on the day should be transferred to tomorrow's list and if nothing else, you'll get it done out of sheer annoyance from writing the same task each day. (3). Get into an end-of-day routine. The last thing I do for the day is completely clean and organize my desk. I write tomorrow's to-do list to brain dump everything that's on my mind so I can be present with my family (and not let mind chatter get in the way of my free time). By leaving my desk organized at the end of the day, I can come in the next morning and feel fully energized to take on the day. By managing hundreds of clients with thousands of to-do's, in addition to my team and online platform, I've had to learn how to completely maximize my productivity. Of course there's a lot more I could share so let's stay connected and I'm happy to continue to teach you what I know. Hang in there and keep fighting for your dreams!

Amber Vilhauer is an online business development expert who supports entrepreneurs to establish a powerful, integrated online presence that gets results and empowers them to make a difference in their industry.

Kenneth Vogt (Twitter:)

www.veraclaritas.com

Whenever you see an email that comes from a list you may have subscribed to and it doesn't compel you to take immediate action, take this immediate action: unsubscribe. You can always subscribe again. But chances are you won't. Do this faithfully and you will find you spend a lot less time juggling email.

Kenneth Vogt helps founders outpace the growth of their businesses at Vera Claritas.

Mark W. Schaefer (Twitter: @markwschaefer)

www.businessesgrow.com

You need to focus only on the activities that are critical and revenue-producing. For example, if you are having website tech problems, don't spend time fixing it yourself, especially if you love to do that sort of thing. Delegate as much of the administration as you can so you can focus on developing the core business, acquiring customers and solving problems.

Mark Schaefer is a college educator, a keynote speaker and the author of five books including The Content Code.

Kim Walsh-Phillips (Twitter: @KWalshPhillips)

www.IOCreativeGroup.com

I am constantly learning and evolving, but I am most a product of David Allen's "Getting Things Done" and Dan Kennedy's "Ruthless Management of Profits and People." I write everything down that I have to do the minute I think of it on one large post-it note in my planner and then I assign things to do each day to specific times of the day. Anything that will take me more than 15 minutes is put in my official scheduling calendar and blocked from other appointments my assistant makes. I also keep a list of tasks that are non-energy tasks (like ordering flowers for a friend or emailing my travel agent to book a flight) that I can do at night when my brain is spent. I follow the Rockefeller Habits model of quarterly rocks and have action items each week to get those things done so I work

on what's important, not just what is urgent. And finally, I outsource anything I can using fantastic tools like Amazon Prime for two-day shipping and Peapod for grocery delivery so I don't have to go to the store, FancyHands.com to book appointments, look up vendors, research products, etc., Thumbtack for finding any household task that can be done, and ZocDoc for making doctor appointments. Being a mom of two little ones and running a multi-office agency requires all of the help I can get!

Kim Walsh-Phillips is the world's leading direct response social media marketer, bestselling author, keynote speaker and founder and CEO of IO Creative Group, focused on creating qualified web traffic, leads and sales from social media for their clients and students.

Andrea Waltz (Twitter: @GoforNo)
www.GoforNo.com

Nothing will slow you down, take you off track, or keep you unproductive than doing things in which you both: do not like to do and are not good at. Anything that falls into that category must be outsourced to someone else (ideally who both likes it and has competence) as soon as possible. The extent to which you continue on those types of tasks is what will hold you back from truly loving what you're doing and also being fulfilled.

Andrea Waltz is the co-author of the best selling book, Go for No! and a professional speaker.

Jim Wang (Twitter: @wangerific)
www.jimwangenterprises.com

Whatever you're doing, always finish it and never leave it lingering. If you start a task, finish it so you can cross it off your list and it doesn't sit around and start to accumulate on your list of "things to do." The feeling of accomplishment you get from completing the task is a great motivator to tackle the next challenge and closing those open loops feels incredible.

Jim Wang is a serial entrepreneur, investor, and founder of Jim Wang Enterprises.

Danielle Watson (Twitter: @PurseProcess)

www.PurseProcess.com

Do what you do best and hire someone else to do the rest!

Danielle Watson is a global provocateur, professional muse, choose your own adventurer, and the creator of The Purse Process®.

Angela Watson (Twitter: @Angela_Watson)

www.TheCornerstoneForTeachers.com

Always break large projects from your long-term goals down into smaller, actionable steps, then schedule those steps into your daily to-do lists. Knowing in advance exactly what projects involve will help you plan your time wisely, space out individual tasks at a manageable pace, and feel a sense of accomplishment as you tick off the boxes each day.

Angela Watson is a National Board Certified Teacher with 11 years of classroom experience. As founder of Due Season Press and Educational Services, she's created four books, two webinars, a blog, podcast, curriculum resources, and conducts seminars in schools around the world.

Susan Weinschenk (Twitter: @thebrainlady)

www.theteamw.com

Tools: Trello for task lists, Scrivener for planning books and videos. Philosophies... 1) Do what you love and you will be beyond productive—you will be driven; 2) Start your day by taking care of YOU; 3) Learn what are your own productivity/creativity cycles and accept and work with yourself when you are in an up or down cycle.

Dr. Susan Weinschenk is a behavioral scientist, author, keynote speaker, and CEO of The Team W—We can show you how to get people to do stuff.

Dana Wilde (Twitter: @themindaware)

www.DanaWilde.com

First, Implement Intentional Action, which means to get your mindset right first, then take action. In other words, intentionally get yourself feeling good and *then* take action in your business. When you are feeling good, the action you take

is more effective and seems to happen effortlessly. Second, implement a 50-minute work session at the beginning of every work day. Set a timer for 50 minutes and spend the first 50 minutes of every work day focused on money making tasks. Stay away from email, off the internet, and away from social media. Only work on tasks that put money directly into your pocket during this time session ... and especially tasks that bring in new business. Third, use technology to leverage your time. My favorite apps are: Unroll.me, RescueTime, Hootsuite, and IFTTT.com.

Dana Wilde is the host of The Mind Aware Show and the bestselling author of Train Your Brain, which teaches entrepreneurs how to grow their businesses in record time by leveraging the power of their minds.

Neil Willenson (Twitter: @powerofhumans)
www.powerofhumans.com

Instead of moving paper from one pile to another, I actually “roll up my sleeves” and begin to tackle the pile! Too often we make “to do” lists versus actually accomplishing tasks. I have a “red hot” box on my desk that contains the most time sensitive projects. I work hard to address these matters first and then move on to checking daily emails, social media accounts and other less urgent tasks.

Neil Willenson is a national non-profit leader, public speaker, actor and entertainment industry executive.

Andy Wilson (Twitter: @andywilsonhvn)
www.rexter.com

In the world of the open social graph, who you know has the potential to be as important as what you know. Understanding how to develop and engage your business network systematically and in scale will differentiate high performers for the rest of the pack.

Andy Wilson is a passionate builder of companies and obsessed with helping professionals realize the full potentials of their business networks.

Stephen Woessner (Twitter: @stephenwoessner)

www.onwardnation.com

I schedule a series of 90-minute “Jam Sessions” throughout my day/week where I focus exclusively on one vital priority and nothing else. And during the Jam Sessions, I stream music from FocusAtWill.com, which is designed to boost productivity by keeping one’s subconscious mind busy—and wow—it really works!

Stephen Woessner is host of the Onward Nation podcast, bestselling author, and CEO of Predictive ROI.

Woody Woodward

www.MeetWoody.com

Productivity is for wannabes! Time does not exist. Wantpreneurs are always wanting more. They want to make more money, they want to achieve the next level, they want the next award-accomplishment. Just stop! I have been self-employed for 26 years. I have done all the time management techniques. Read Gary Keller’s book *The One Thing*. Just focus on the “One Thing” you need to do. The rest falls into place. My business took off when I decided to retire from working on Monday and Friday. I get more done Tuesday thru Thursday than an entire week. I also added 11 more years to my life. The difference of taking two days off times 40 more years till I die. Do what you love that makes money and don’t spend time on useless meetings, emails, social media and TV watching. Get off your assets and make it happen! It is that simple.

Woody Woodward is a Performance Strategist whose M.O.N.E.Y. Mastery system reaches 1,423,821 entrepreneurs everyday.

Desiree Vargas Wrigley (Twitter: @desireegf)

www.GiveForward.com

Like most people there is not a single tool that can do it all. Since I love taking notes on paper in meetings, my system for keeping track of all of my to-do’s is a hybrid approach. I start all to-do’s as I’m writing them, then enter them into Asana and highlight them in my notebooks once they’ve been entered.

That way, if I'm in a meeting, I can quickly find them in my notebook, and I still get the annoying but necessary email reminders. I'm also a firm believer in time-boxing. I don't check email all of the time. I do it during set periods in the AM and PM. I reserve 5-8 PM for my husband and children, and I never check email after 9pm.

Desiree Vargas Wrigley is the founder of GiveForward.com, the leading crowdfunding platform for loved ones facing a major life event.

Athena Yap (Twitter: @Jackboybakery)
www.jackboydogbakery.com

The key to time management, especially for an entrepreneur, is managing one's emotion. Each day entrepreneurs are bombarded with problems, pressing matters to take care of, demands from every where and unexpected events. Being able to manage one's emotion, to not react to circumstances, not to be upset by outside forces so he or she can focus on the goal and task at hand, is the main ingredient in time management, hence staying productive. All the tools, todo lists or apps are no use if one cannot stay emotionally solid.

Athena Yap is the founder and CEO of Jackboy's Dog Bakery, a dog birthday and celebration headquarter. The company helps dog parents and dog lovers celebrate all happy, loving and fun lifetime memories with their dogs through healthy and delicious dog treats.

Yamile Yemoonyah (Twitter: @yemoonyah)
www.CreativeWebBiz.com

My best productivity tip goes a bit deeper than that of most other entrepreneurs because to me productivity is mainly a tool to achieve empowerment. Let me explain: Why do we all want to be more productive? Because being more productive empowers us to make our businesses more effective, impactful and financially successful. And real, authentic empowerment comes from aligning our unique personality with our vision, purpose and goals. As entrepreneurs we are usually clear on where we want to go and what we want to achieve. But too often we try to emulate our highly successful role models to

get there without taking our own individual personality into account. To do so, you need to figure out what makes you tick. Are you a morning person or a night owl? If you are the latter, there is no use in trying to get work done at 6 am in the morning, no matter what you read in that blog post or heard on that podcast. Are you an extrovert or an introvert? Create a work environment that speaks to that character trait. Noise canceling head phones can do the trick if you need it quiet, a busy cafe or office is the way to go if you thrive on human interaction. Vegetarians will need different food to feel productive than carnivores, nature lovers might join a entrepreneurial hiking group on meetup.com group instead of attending a traditional networking event. So to get more productive, all you need to do is to get to know yourself, accept yourself and accommodate your own personality traits, no matter how quirky they might be.

Yamile Yemoonyah helps artist entrepreneurs build and grow their businesses. She is the founder of CreativeWebBiz.com, the host of the Creative Web Biz Show, the creator of the #30DayArtBizChallenge and she also runs the Creative Web Biz Club, a high level mastermind community for artists who mean business.

Valerie Young (Twitter: @valerieyoung)

www.ImpostorSyndrome.com

With so much fighting for our attention it's not always easy to see the forest from the trees. Most people keep lists and lists of trees in the form of to-do lists while keeping their high impact activities which require multiple steps and multiple time periods to complete in their head. I keep a Current Goals and Projects list on a white board. The only things on this list are activities that start with "big" verbs like develop, coordinate, research, create, plan. Anything that starts with a "little" verbs like call, email, buy birthday card etc. are on a separate list. That's because when you mix big verbs and little verbs on the same list, it forces your subconscious to choose between "develop strategic plan" and "call Fred." Given the choice, the higher pay-off but more involved activity will lose out over the more manageable quick hit tasks every time.

Award-winning author Dr. Valerie Young is an internationally known speaker and expert on the impostor syndrome.

Tom Ziglar (Twitter: @TomZiglar)

www.ziglar.com

Once you have determined why you are building your business (your life goals), the rest is just discipline and work. Invest the first part of your day working on your number one priority that will help build your business. Do this without interruptions—no email or txt, and before the rest of the world is awake. If your most creative time is later in the day, then you can do this practice then, but you must be relentless in keeping this time sacred and interruption free.

Tom Ziglar is the CEO of Ziglar Inc and travels the world speaking on leadership and performance.

Quiz: Discover Your Time Management Personality

The Time Management Style Assessment (TMSA), by Kevin Kruse, will give you a thorough analysis of your current time management behaviors. The two primary factors driving time mastery are being clear on your priorities, and using the mechanics of planning (based on the groundbreaking 1994 research of Dr. Therese Hoff Macan). Understanding your current level of competence in these two domains will enable you to identify areas for improvement and further productivity gains.

Take the quiz and get your custom report at:

www.KevinKruse.com/time

110 Best Time Management Quotes

1. Yesterday is history. Tomorrow is a mystery. Today is a gift. That's why it's called the present. – **Eleanor Roosevelt**
2. Don't wait. The time will never be just right. – **Napoleon Hill**
3. A day wasted on others is not wasted on one's self.
– **Charles Dickens**
4. A man who dares to waste one hour of life has not discovered the value of life. – **Charles Darwin**
5. **A wise person does at once what a fool does at last. Both do the same thing; only at different times.**
– **Baltasar Gracián**
6. Live each day as if it be your last. – **Marcus Aurelius**
7. All great achievements require time. – **Maya Angelou**
8. All that really belongs to us is time; even he who has nothing else has that. – **Baltasar Gracián**
9. All the flowers of all of the tomorrows are in the seeds of today. – **Chinese Proverb**
10. All the forces in the world are not so powerful as an idea whose time has come. – **Victor Hugo**
11. Be mindful of how you approach time. Watching the clock is not the same as watching the sun rise. – **Sophia Bedford-Pierce**
12. Believe that time is going to help you do what you want. – **William Morris Hunt**
13. Better three hours too soon than one minute too late.
– **William Shakespeare**
14. Clock watchers never seem to be having a good time.
– **James Cash Penney**

15. Determine never to be idle. No person will have occasion to complain of the want of time who never loses any. It is wonderful how much can be done if we are always doing. – **Thomas Jefferson**
16. Do not confuse motion and progress. A rocking horse keeps moving but does not make any progress.
– **Alfred A. Montapert**
17. Do not dwell in the past, do not dream of the future, concentrate the mind on the present moment. – **Buddha**
18. Don't be fooled by the calendar. There are only as many days in the year as you make use of. One man gets only a week's value out of a year while another man gets a full year's value out of a week. – **Charles Richards**
19. Don't be stomping on ants when you have elephants to feed. – **Peter Turla**
20. Don't let the fear of the time it will take to accomplish something stand in the way of your doing it. The time will pass anyway; we might just as well put that passing time to the best possible use. – **Earl Nightingale**
21. Don't say you don't have enough time. You have exactly the same number of hours per day that were given to Helen Keller, Pasteur, Michelangelo, Mother Teresa, Leonardo da Vinci, Thomas Jefferson, and Albert Einstein. – **H. Jackson Brown**
22. Don't spend a dollar's worth of time on a ten-cent decision. – **Peter Turla**
23. Dost thou love life? Then do not squander time, for that's the stuff that life is made of. – **Benjamin Franklin**
24. Even if you're on the right track, you'll get run over if you just sit there. – **Will Rogers**
25. Nothing else, perhaps, distinguishes effective executives as much as their tender loving care of time. – **Peter Drucker**

26. For time and the world do not stand still. Change is the law of life. And those who look only to the past or the present are certain to miss the future. – **John F. Kennedy**
27. Gaining time is gaining everything in love, trade and war. – **John Shebbeare**
28. Half our life is spent trying to find something to do with the time we have rushed through life trying to save. – **Will Rogers**
29. I made this letter longer than usual because I lack the time to make it shorter. – **Pascal**
30. He does not seem to me to be a free man who does not sometimes do nothing. – **Cicero**
31. He lives long that lives well; and time misspent is not lived but lost. – **Thomas Fuller**
32. He that rises late must trot all day. – **Benjamin Franklin**
33. **He who gains time gains everything.** – **Benjamin Disraeli**
34. He who knows most grieves most for wasted time.– **Dante**
35. I don't think of the past. The only thing that matters is the everlasting present. – **Somerset Maugham**
36. I recommend to you to take care of the minutes; for hours will take care of themselves. – **Lord Chesterfield**
37. I'm too busy mopping the floor to turn off the faucet. – **Unknown**
38. If it weren't for the last minute, a lot of things wouldn't get done. – **Michael S. Traylor**
39. If you want to make good use of your time, you've got to know what's most important and then give it all you've got. – **Lee Iacocca**
40. In the real world, nothing happens at the right place at the right time. It is the job of journalists and historians to correct that. – **Mark Twain**

41. In truth, people can generally make time for what they choose to do; it is not really the time but the will that is lacking. – **Sir John Lubbock**
42. It is a mistake to look too far ahead. Only one link of the chain of destiny can be handled at a time. – **Winston Churchill**
43. It is better to have lived one day as a tiger than a thousand years as a sheep. – **Tibetan saying**
44. It's better to do the right thing slowly than the wrong thing quickly. – **Peter Turla**
45. It's how we spend our time here and now that really matters. If you are fed up with the way you have come to interact with time, change it. – **Marcia Wieder**
46. It's not enough to be busy, so are the ants. The question is, what are we busy about? – **Henry David Thoreau**
47. Know the true value of time; snatch, seize, and enjoy every moment of it. No idleness, no laziness, no procrastination; never put off till tomorrow what you can do today. – **Lord Chesterfield**
48. Lost time is never found again. – **Proverb**
49. Never leave till tomorrow that which you can do today.
– **Benjamin Franklin**
50. Lost wealth may be replaced by industry, lost knowledge by study, lost health by temperance or medicine, but lost time is gone forever. – **Samuel Smiles**
51. Make use of time, let not advantage slip. – **William Shakespeare**
52. Managing your time without setting priorities is like shooting randomly and calling whatever you hit the target. – **Peter Turla**
53. Many people take no care of their money till they come nearly to the end of it, and others do just the same with their time. – **Goethe**

54. Money is a wonderful thing, but it is possible to pay too high a price for it. – **Alexander Bloch**
55. Money, I can only gain or lose. But time I can only lose. So, I must spend it carefully. – **Unknown**
56. Never let yesterday use up today. – **Richard H. Nelson**
57. Nothing is a waste of time if you use the experience wisely. – **Rodin**
58. Nothing is ours except Time. – **Goethe**
59. Once you have mastered time, you will understand how true it is that most people overestimate what they can accomplish in a year—and underestimate what they can achieve in a decade! – **Anthony Robbins**
60. One always has time enough, if one will apply it well. – **Goethe**
61. One worthwhile task carried to a successful conclusion is worth half-a-hundred half-finished tasks. – **Malcolm Forbes**
62. Ordinary people think merely of spending time. Great people think of using it. – **Unknown**
63. Realize that now, in this moment of time, you are creating. You are creating your next moment. That is what's real. – **Sara Paddison**
64. Take a rest. A field that has rested yields a beautiful crop. – **Ovid**
65. Take care of the minutes, and the hours will take care of themselves. – **Lord Chesterfield**
66. The bad news is time flies. The good news is you're the pilot. – **Michael Altshuler**
67. The great dividing line between success and failure can be expressed in five words: "I did not have time." – **Franklin Field**
68. The key is in not spending time, but in investing it. – **Stephen R. Covey**
69. The most important question to ask is, what am I becoming? – **Jim Rohn**

70. The surest way to be late is to have plenty of time.
– **Leo Kennedy**
71. The time for action is now. It's never too late to do something. – **Carl Sandburg**
72. The time you enjoy wasting is not wasted time.
– **Bertrand Russell**
73. The worst days of those who enjoy what they do are better than the best days of those who don't. – **Jim Rohn**
74. There is nothing so useless as doing efficiently that which should not be done at all. – **Peter Drucker**
75. This time, like all times, is a very good one, if we but know what to do with it. – **Ralph Waldo Emerson**
76. Those who make the worst use of their time are the first to complain of its shortness. – **Jean De La Bruyere**
77. Time and I against any two. – **Baltasar Gracian**
78. Time and the hour run through the roughest day.
– **William Shakespeare**
79. Time as he grows old teaches many lessons. – **Aeschylus**
80. Time is a great healer, but a poor beautician. – **Lucille Harper**
81. Time is a great teacher, but unfortunately it kills all its pupils. – **Hector Louis Berlioz**
82. Time is at once the most valuable and the most perishable of all our possessions. – **John Randolph**
83. Time is money. – **Benjamin Franklin**
84. Time is really the only capital that any human being has, and the only thing he can't afford to lose. – **Thomas Edison**
85. Time is the coin of your life. It is the only coin you have, and only you can determine how it will be spent. Be careful lest you let other people spend it for you. – **Carl Sandburg**

86. Time is the rider that breaks youth. – **George Herbert**
87. Time is the school in which we learn, time is the fire in which we burn. – **Delmore Schwartz**
88. Time is the wisest counselor of all. – **Pericles**
89. Time is what we want most, but what we use worst.
– **William Penn**
90. Time lost is never found again. – **Benjamin Franklin**
91. Time makes heroes but dissolves celebrities. – **Daniel J. Boorstin**
92. Time stays long enough for those who use it.
– **Leonardo Da Vinci**
93. Time will take your money, but money won't buy time.
– **James Taylor**
94. To do two things at once is to do neither. – **Publius Syrus**
95. To think too long about doing a thing often becomes its undoing. – **Eva Young**
96. Until we can manage time, we can manage nothing else. – **Peter Drucker**
97. Until you value yourself, you will not value your time. Until you value your time, you will not do anything with it. – **M. Scott Peck**
98. We can no more afford to spend major time on minor things than we can to spend minor time on major things. – **Jim Rohn**
99. What may be done at any time will be done at no time. – **Scottish Proverb**
100. When I am getting ready to reason with a man, I spend one-third of my time thinking about myself and what I am going to say and two-thirds about him and what he is going to say. – **Abraham Lincoln**
101. Whether it's the best of times or the worst of times, it's the only time we've got. – **Art Buchwald**

102. While we are postponing, life speeds by. – **Seneca**
103. Work expands so as to fill the time available for its completion. – **Cyril Parkinson**
104. You can't change the past, but you can ruin the present by worrying about the future. – **Unknown**
105. You cannot do a kindness too soon, for you never know how soon it will be too late. – **Ralph Waldo Emerson**
106. You cannot kill time without injuring eternity. – **Henry David Thoreau**
107. You may delay, but time will not.– **Benjamin Franklin**
108. You must get good at one of two things. Planting in the spring or begging in the fall. – **Jim Rohn**
109. You will never find time for anything. If you want time you must make it. – **Charles Buxton**
110. **You've got to think about big things while you're doing small things, so that all the small things go in the right direction.** – **Alvin Toffler**

Join the #1440 Movement

Did you learn at least one thing in this book that will make you more productive and give you more time for yourself? If so, please help me to spread the word!

Please share your time and productivity thoughts, notes or questions on Twitter, Facebook and Instagram using the hashtag #1440 (remember, only 1,440 minutes in a day). And search #1440 to see what other people are talking about.

Other ways to help people take back their lives:

1. Share this book with friends who are “overworked and overwhelmed”
2. Buy copies of this book for your employees
3. Recommend this book to your book club
4. Recommend Kevin Kruse to speak at your next corporate event or conference

Extreme Productivity Workshop or Keynote

Imaging dramatically improving productivity in your organization, while also improving work-life balance!

Extreme Productivity with Kevin Kruse

Kevin Kruse speaks around the world at executive retreats, leadership meetings and association conferences. Based on his bestselling book, *15 Secrets Successful People Know About Time Management*, and on his interviews with hundreds of top achievers, Kevin shares the surprising ways everyone can achieve extreme productivity and stop feeling “overworked and overwhelmed.”

To invite Kevin to speak at your next event

email info@kevinkruse.com

Or call 267-756-7089

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Kevin Kruse

Kevin Kruse is a *New York Times* bestselling author, *Forbes* contributor, keynote speaker and founder of several multi-million dollar companies. He has advised Fortune 500 CEOs, Marine Corps generals and members of Congress.

In pursuit of the American Dream, Kevin started his first company when he was just 22 years old. He worked around the clock, living out of his one-room office and showering each day at the YMCA, before giving up a year later deeply in debt. But after discovering the power of Wholehearted Leadership and how to “Master Your Minutes”, Kevin went on to build and sell several successful companies, winning *Inc* 500 and Best Place to Work awards along the way.

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This book contains articles that were previously published as part of the author's blog on kevinkruse.com, Forbes.com, or other online forums, but have been revised and updated since the date of their original publication.

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ISBN-13: 978-0-9850564-3-8

eISBN-13: 978-0-9850564-4-5